

ACTS

THE ACTS OF THE APOSTLES.

PREFACE.

S. Luke, who had published his gospel, wrote also a second volume, which, from the first ages, hath been called the Acts of the Apostles. Not that we can look upon this work, as a history of what was done by all the apostles, who were dispersed in different nations; but we have here a short view of the first establishment of the Christian Church, a small part of S. Peter's preaching and actions, set down in the first twelve chapters, and a more particular account of S. Paul's apostolical labours, in the following chapters, for about thirty years, till the year 63, and the 4th year of Nero, where these acts end. Wi. — S. Luke, after giving us the history of the life, actions, miracles, sufferings, and instructions of Jesus Christ, in his gospel, here give us the life and actions of the apostles, the primitive Christians, and particularly all that relates to S.

Paul, by way of an appendix. And what could he give more useful or more important to the Church, whether we consider the noble examples he offers for our imitation, or the excellent lessons for our improvement in spiritual wisdom? He describes in this book the accomplishment of many things that had been predicted by Jesus Christ, the descent of the Holy Ghost, the prodigious change effected in the minds and hearts of the apostles: we behold here the model of Christian perfection, in the lives of the first Christians, and the practice of the most eminent virtues, in the conduct of the blessed apostles; the miraculous operations of the holy Spirit, in the conversion of the Gentiles, and this wonder of wonders, the foundation of the holy Catholic Church, the establishment of the spiritual kingdom of God, promised through all the inspired oracles, and the daily addition which the Lord made to his Church, of such as should be saved. c. 2. v. ult. and c. xv. v. 5. — S. Luke has entitled this work, the Acts of the Apostles, that we may seek therein, says S.

Chrysostom, (tom. 5. hom. xii.) not so much the miracles that the apostles performed, as their good deeds, and eminent virtues. In appearing to give us a simple history, says S. Jerom, this holy physician

furnishes us with as many remedies, to cure the maladies of our souls, as he gives us words for our instruction. Ep. 103. — It is thought, that his principal design was to oppose to the false acts of the apostles, that were then in circulation, a true and authentic history of the actions of S. Peter and S. Paul. The Catholic Church has ever held this work in such great esteem, that it has not only superseded every pretended history of the kind, that preceded it, but also every ascitious one that has succeeded it. S. Aug. de consen. Evang. l. iv. c. 8. — It is very probable, that S. Luke wrote his acts at Rome, whilst he was near S. Paul, during the time of his confinement, for he remained with him till his deliverance. There can be no doubt that the work was written in Greek, and in a more pure and polished style, than we find in any other writing of the New Testament. S. Luke generally cites the Septuagint, apparently because he was ignorant of the Hebrew; and because, S. Paul more frequently having to preach to the Gentiles, preferred citing the sacred text in the language known in common, sooner than in Hebrew, which was understood by few. See S. Jer. in Isai. vi. and again, tradit. Hebr. in Genes. 45. — The Catholic Church has ever admitted this book into the canon of Scriptures; though many heretics, says S.

Augustine, have rejected it, ep. 253. and l. de util. cred. 7. S. Chrysostom, (hom. i. in Acta) complains, that this book, in his time, was not sufficiently attended to, which he esteems as no less useful than the gospel itself.

Erasmus, in his preface to the Acts, says, that he had, in the first instance, some notion of adding this book to S. Luke's gospel, as they are both addressed to the same person, and the Acts are not inconsiderable part of the sacred history; for, as the gospel shews the seed committed to the earth, and sown in the field, the Acts represent it as taking root, shooting up, and producing its fruit. — The Acts have not uniformly held the same place in the Testament which they hold at present. Sometimes this book was inserted immediately before the book of Revelation, as S. Augustine and others insinuate. At other times, we find it between the epistles of S. Paul and the canonical epistles. Some persons express their surprise, that S. Luke, who was the inseparable companion of S. Paul, has not given the account of S.

Paul's martyrdom. S. Chrysostom (hom. i. in Acta) gives an excellent solution:

"the apostles, and other apostolic men, wrote little, but did a great deal." The martyrdom of S. Paul, that took place in the public theatre of Rome itself, and before the eyes of all the Christians of this capital of the world, could not remain unknown, but the voyages and other circumstances of his life, too useful to the Church to be suffered to pass into oblivion, called for the exertions of S. Luke's eloquent pen, which, though admirably accommodated to an historic design, is not wholly free from Hebraisms, and Syriacisms. The Acts of the Apostles include the history of the infant Church, from the day of our Lord's ascension into heaven, till the deliverance of S. Paul, two years after his arrival at Rome, i.e. a space of thirty years, from the year 33, to the year 63 of Jesus Christ, or from the 19th year of Tiberius, till the 9th year of Nero. This golden book paints, as it were, the face of the primeval Christian Church; it places before our eyes the singular providence of God, in founding and protecting his Church, and how the apostles, (in spite of every opposition of the armed power of the whole world, to oppress the gospel,) without any foreign assistance of learning, credit, power, or expectation of any temporal advantages, but relying solely on the power of truth, and the virtue of the holy Spirit, laboured in the propagation of the faith, without intermission, till the power of God, under the ignominy of the cross, became eventually triumphant.

See Wm. Whitfield Dakins, LL.D. in his prolegomena. — It may be divided into four parts. In the first eight chapters, S. Luke gives the origin and progress of the Christian Church among the Jews. From the 9th to the 16th, he shews how widely it was spread among the Gentiles: from the 16th to the 20th, the diverse peregrinations of S. Paul, till his last journey to Jerusalem: and from the 20th to the end, with what patience he underwent innumerable sufferings, trials, and indignities, with what magnanimity he made head against the violent surges of persecution, and his astonishing equanimity under every possible calamity. — This account, which is not continued beyond his two years'

imprisonment in Rome, contains a general sketch of the history of the Church during the epoch it describes of thirty years. The leading facts therein contained are, the choice of Matthias to be an apostles, in the room of Judas; the descent of the Holy Ghost on the day of Pentecost; the preaching, miracles, and sufferings of the apostles at Jerusalem; the conversion of S.

Paul; the call of Cornelius, the first Gentile convert; the persecution of the Christians by Herod Agrippa; the preaching of Paul and Barnabas to the Gentiles, by the express command of the Holy Ghost; the decree made at Jerusalem, declaring that circumcision, and a conformity to other Jewish rites and ceremonies were not necessary in Gentile converts; the miraculous cures performed by the handkerchiefs and aprons which had only touched the body of S. Paul; whilst the latter part of the book is exclusively confined to the history of S. Paul, of whom, as we have already seen, S. Luke was the constant companion for several years. — The place of its publication is doubtful. A learned prelate advances, that the probability appears to be in favour of Greece, though some contend for Alexandria, in Egypt. This latter opinion rests upon the subscriptions at the end of some Greek manuscripts, and of the copies of the Syriac version; but the best critics think, that these subscriptions, which are also affixed to other books of the New Testament, deserve but little weight; and in this case they are not supported by any ancient authority. But the sentiment of this learned prelate, does not bias the opinion we gave at the beginning, and which we find confirmed by Alban Butler, in his life of S. Luke, vol. x. p. 432. where he says, "that S. Luke attended S. Paul at Rome, whither he was sent prisoner from Jerusalem in 61.

The apostle remained there two years in chains; but was permitted to live in a house which he hired, though under the custody of a constant guard; and there he preached to those who daily resorted to hear him. From ancient writings and monuments belonging to the Church of S. Mary in via lata, which is an ancient title of a Cardinal Deacon, Boronius, in his Annals ad an. 55. and Arringhi, in his Roma Subterranea, l. iii, c. 41. tell us, that this Church was built upon the

spot where S. Paul then lodged, and where S. Luke wrote the Acts of the Apostles."

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ACTS 1

CHAPTER I.

Ver. 1. S. Luke, who was the author of this history, alludes, in this verse, to his gospel, which he calls his first discourse. In that he informs us, not only of the actions, but also the doctrines of our Saviour. These words, to do and to teach, are the abridgment of the whole gospel: here he gives us the Acts of the Apostles, that is, an history of their travels and preaching. In the beginning of this work he speaks of all the apostles, and what they did before their dispersion. As soon as he comes to the mention of S. Paul, he takes notice of no one else, but is entirely taken up with the narrative of his actions. He addresses his book to Theophilus, which signifies a friend of God, or one who loves God, as if he intended to dedicate it to all the faithful, who believed in, and loved God. But it is more probable that this was some distinct person, well known to S. Luke, and illustrious for his birth, because he gave him the title of kratiste, most excellent. Calmet.

Ver. 2. Until the day on which, giving commandments by the Holy Ghost to the apostles whom he had chosen, he was taken up. As the Scripture was written without distinction of verses, and without any stops, or commas, which were added afterwards) the construction, and joining of the words in this verse, is ambiguous. The question is, with what part of the verse these words, by the Holy Ghost, are to be joined. The sense might be, 1. that he was taken up by the Holy Ghost: but this is generally rejected. 2. That he gave his commandments by the Holy Ghost to his apostles; that is, says S. Chrys. that he gave them spiritual commands, that came from the Holy Ghost, or from his holy Spirit. 3. The most probable exposition seems to be, that he gave his special commandments to his apostles, or to those whom he chose to be his apostles, by the Holy Ghost, or by his holy and divine spirit. Wi. — The power to preach, to baptize, to remit sins, and generally the whole commission and charge of the government of his Church after him in his name, and with his authority; which government was given them, together with the Holy Ghost, to assist them therein for ever. B.

Ver. 3. Appearing, &c. Why did he not appear to all, but only to his disciples?

Because to many of them, who did not know the mystery, he would have seemed a phantom. For if the disciples themselves were diffident, and terrified, and required to touch him with their hands, how would others have been affected? But we know from their miracles, the truth of the resurrection, which is made evident to all succeeding generations. Perhaps the apostles did not perform miracles. How then was the world converted? This is a fact which cannot be denied, and that it should have been brought about by twelve poor illiterate fishermen, without miracles, would be the greatest of all miracles, far beyond the reach of all human means. S. Chrys. hom. i. c. 1. on Acts. — "And speaking of things pertaining to the kingdom of God," as we read in the Greek, and in the Protestant version, that is, pertaining to the Church, which is the kingdom of God, *ta peri tes basileias tou theou*, which plainly makes for unwritten tradition. Estius.

Ver. 4. And eating with them.[1] This is a literal translation from the vulgar Latin. But the Prot. translation from some Greek copies, would have it, And being assembled together, he commanded them, &c. Mr. Bois defends the Latin Vulg. and even by the authority of S. Chrys. who doubtless understood the Greek text, as well as any one, and who takes the Greek word here to signify eating: for he observes that the apostles elsewhere prove Christ's resurrection by his eating and drinking with them. Acts x. 4. S. Jer. also says, the derivation of the Greek word, is from eating salt together. Wi.

Ver. 5. Baptized with the Holy Ghost, that is, cleansed, and sanctified by the plentiful graces he shall pour upon you. Wi.

Ver. 6-7. Wilt thou at this time restore again the kingdom of Israel? Some of them, as S. Chrys. observes, had still their thoughts upon a temporal kingdom of the Messias. Christ, to divert them from such imaginations, tells them, their business is to be witnesses of his doctrine and miracles, particularly of his resurrection, even unto the utmost bounds of the earth, to all the nations of the world. Wi.

Ver. 9. He was raised up. Raised himself up, and ascended, &c. Wi.

Ver. 10. Behold two men, that is, two angels, stood by them in white apparel.

Wi.

Ver. 11. So shall he come, as you have seen him going. This word going, says S. Chrys. sufficiently intimates, that he ascended by his own power: for so will he come by his own power to judge the world. **Wi.** — Jesus Christ shall come on the last day, in the same body, in the same majesty, to judge the living and the dead. This he had likewise promised, in more than one place of the gospel, speaking of the vengeance, which he will exercise on the city of Jerusalem. **S.**

Jerom, S. Hilary, and many other ancients, have believed that the Son of God will appear again on Mount Olivet, and that all people shall be assembled to judgment. S. Jerom. super Joel iii. 2. S. Hilary, super Matt. xxiv. 32. — And that same body, which thus ascended to heaven, and which will thus descend, is given us in the blessed Sacrament. "O miracle! exclaims S. Chrysostom, He that sitteth with his Father above, is at the same time handled by men below.

Jesus Christ ascending to heaven, both hath his flesh with him above, and hath left it with us below. Elias being taken up, left his disciple, Eliseus, his mantle and double spirit, but the Son of Man ascending, left his own flesh for us." L. iii. de Sacerd. hom. 2. ad pop. Ant. hom. de divit. et paup. — Sulpicius Severus, and S. Paulinus, assure us, that the marks of the feet of our Saviour were imprinted in the place off which he rose to heaven; and S. Aug. informs us, that many in his time went to Judea, to venerate these sacred marks. **Ven.**

Bede testifies the same in the eighth age. In the time of Constantine the great, the empress Helen built a church on the place. **Calmet.**

Ver. 12. Sabbath-day's journey. It cannot now be precisely determined what this distance was, but it is most probable, that it was about a mile. On particular occasions, it perhaps was allowed to exceed a little. **Calmet.**

Ver. 13-14. Into an upper room, to be more retired in prayer. There they were persevering with one mind in prayer. These few words denote to us three dispositions to receive the Holy Ghost. 1. Prayer. 2. Perseverance in it. 3. To be of one mind, perfectly united in charity, and the love of one another. Wi. — This is the last mention that is made in Scripture of the blessed Virgin Mary. She lived the rest of her time with the Christians (as here she is particularly named and noted amongst them) and especially with S. John, the apostle, to whom our Lord recommended her. S. John xix 26. 27. She undoubtedly communicated to the evangelists many circumstances relative to the actions, words, and mysteries of her divine Son.

Ver. 15. Peter, rising up, &c. Peter, says S. Chrys.[2] on this place, who was prince, or chief of the apostolical college, who had authority over them all, who by his place and dignity, might, without them, have chosen, and appointed a new apostle to succeed Judas, (Christ having said to him, confirm thy brethren,) &c. yet he consults them. Wi. — Here Peter acts and ordains in virtue of his supremacy, and the other apostles agree to his appointment.

Ver. 18. Possessed a field. Judas is here said to have done, what was done by others, with the thirty pieces of money, the reward of his iniquity. And being hanged, that is, as S. Matt. says, (c. xxvii. 5.) having hanged himself, he burst asunder. The Greek has it, falling headlong,[3] as perhaps he did, by the judgment of God, from the place or tree where he hanged himself. Wi. — Judas did not possess the potter's field, but he furnished the price to buy it, giving back the thirty pieces of silver. Menochius. — We often say in common, that we have done what happens in consequence of any action of ours, though it was not in our first intention. Calmet.

Ver. 20. His bishoprick. The words were prophetically spoken in the Psalms, of the traitor Judas. Wi. — Let their habitation. In some MS. copies, in both Greek and Syriac, we read his. In the Psalms, the text was written against the Jews, the persecutors of Christ in general; but in this place, Peter applies it to Judas in particular. Estius in dif. loca.

Ver. 21. Came in, and went out among us. That is, conversed with us. Wi.

Ver. 25. To his own place of perdition, which he brought himself to. Wi.

Ver. 26. And he gave them lots, which they might lawfully do, when they knew that both of them were fit, and every way qualified for the office. Wi. — Lots.

This method of deciding the election of ministers by lots, is one of those extraordinary methods which was inspired by God; but can seldom or ever be imitated. Where both candidates appeared equally worthy, as in the present case, and human judgment cannot determine which is to be preferred, it cannot be said that it was wrong to decide it by lots. Thus were avoided any of the evil consequences which might have happened by one party being preferred before the other. S. Augustin observes, that in a doubtful case, where neither part is bad, to decide by lots is not in itself wrong. *Sors enim non aliquid mali est, sed res est in dubitatione humana divinam indicans voluntatem.* In Psalm xxx. A.

**[1] V. 4. sunalizomenos, A salis & mensæ communione. Some copies
sunaulizomenos.**

[2] V. 15. S. Chrys. om.g. tou chorou protos, &c.

[3] V. 18. Suspensus crepuit medius, prenes genomenos.

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ACTS 2

CHAPTER II.

Ver. 1. Altogether in one[1] place. The Greek signifies, were all of one mind. Wi.

Ver. 2. A sound, &c. Perhaps this was a kind of thunder, accompanied with a great wind, which filled with terror and awe the whole company, and disposed them to receive the gift of heaven with humility and fervour. This noise appears to have been heard over a great part of the city, and to have gathered together a great crowd, who came to learn the cause. This noise and wind were symbols of the divinity. It was thus also that formerly on Mount Sinai, thunder and lightning, the dark cloud, the smoking mountain, &c. marked the majesty of God. Calmet. — Jesus Christ, our Pasch, to answer perfectly the figure, was offered on the day of the great Jewish passover; so fifty days after, for accomplishing the like figure of the law given on Mount Sinai, He sent down the Holy Ghost on the day of their Pentecost, which meaneth fifty. But our feasts, as S. Augustin remarks, besides the remembrance of benefits past, contain great mysteries also of the life to come. Ep. cxix. c. 16.

Ver. 3. Tongues . . . of fire. The Hebrews use the name tongue, for almost any thing pointed. Thus they say, a tongue of the earth, for a promontory. Josue xv.

5. A fiery tongue for a flame in shape of a tongue. Isa. v. 24. The expression, therefore, in this place, may mean noting more than sparks, or rather flames, which appeared above all who were in the house. — Sed et Latinis quod extremum et acutum est lingua dicitur, quare scopulos summos & invios linguas dixit Cæsar. P. — By the fiery tongues is signified the efficacy of the apostles' preaching, and the gift of tongues bestowed upon them. M.

Ver. 4. Began to speak divers tongues. Perhaps the apostles spoke only their own tongue, and the miracle consisted in each one's understanding it as if they spoke it in his language. S. Greg. Nazianzen.

orat. xlv. — But S. Augustin and most others, understand the text literally; though the apostles had not this gift on all occasions, nor on all subjects, and therefore sometimes stood in need of interpreters. Vide S. Aug. in Psalm xvii. Expos. 2. and Serm. 188. —

The same Father observes, that the conversion of all nations to the Church, and their being united in one faith, all having one language or confession, is a perpetuation of the same miracle in the Church.

Ver. 14. But Peter standing up, &c. A wonderful change which the Holy Ghost, at his coming, in a moment wrought in the apostles, as we see in the person of S. Peter, who before, when questioned by a silly girl, denied his master, now he values not all the Sanhedrim of the Scribes, Pharisees, and magistrates; he boldly and publicly charges them with the murder of Jesus, their Lord, and their Christ. v. 36. Wi. — As the prince of the apostolic college, and head of the Church, under Jesus Christ, hence Peter speaks in the name of the other apostles also, gives an account of the miracle, and promulgates the evangelical law. M. — Newly replenished with all knowledge and fortitude, and full of the holy Spirit, he here maketh his first sermon. B.

Ver. 15. About nine in the morning. On festival days, the Jews did not eat till the morning devotions were finished, about mid-day. V.

Ver. 17. In the last days, or the latter days, meaning the time of the Messias, I will pour out my Spirit upon all flesh, that is, all persons. See Joel ii. 28. Wi.

Ver. 19. I will shew wonders, &c. These prodigies are commonly expounded of those that shall forerun the last day; or of the prognostics of the destruction of Jerusalem, which was a figure of the destruction of the world. Wi. — Blood, fire, &c. These prodigies were accomplished at our Saviour's death, or before the destruction of Jerusalem. We must not expect in these prophecies, where the descriptions are so grand, pathetic, and hyperbolical, to find that the accomplishment of them is literal, and precisely according to terms. The sun shall suffer an eclipse, the moon turn red, like blood, &c. Calmet.

Ver. 22-23. Jesus, . . . a man, who suffered as man, though he was both God and man. — Delivered by the determinate decree, or counsel; to wit, by that eternal decree, that the Son of God should become man. He mentions this decree, and foreknowledge of God, to signify that Christ suffered not by chance, nor unwillingly, but what God, and he as God, had decreed. Wi. — By the determinate, &c. God delivered up his Son; and his Son delivered up himself, for the love of us, and for the sake of our salvation: and so Christ's being delivered up was holy, and was God's own determination. But they who betrayed and crucified him, did wickedly, following therein their own malice, and the instigation of the devil; not the will and determination of God, who was by no means the author of their wickedness; though he permitted it; because he could, and did draw out of it so great a good, viz. the salvation of man. Ch.

Ver. 24. Having loosed the sorrows[2] of hell, &c. In the ordinary Greek copies, of death. As to the sense of this place, 1. It is certain Christ suffered the pains and pangs of a violent death. 2. That his soul suffered no pains after death, nor in any place called hell. 3. We believe, as in the Apostles' Creed, that his blessed soul descended into hell, that is, to that place in the inferior parts of the earth, (Ephes. iv. 9.) which we commonly call Limbus Patrum, not to suffer, but to free the souls of the just from thence. — As it was impossible he should be held there, either by death, or hell, his soul being always united to the divine person: and his rising again being foretold in the Psalms, in the words here cited. Wi. — Having overcome the grievous pains of death, and all the power of hell. Ch. — Not that Jesus suffered any thing after his death; that was impossible. But these pains were loosed in his regard, because he was preserved from them, as the bird is preserved from the nets of the fowlers, which are broken before it is taken in them. S. Aug. ep. ad. Olimp. xcv. —

Moreover he loosed others of those pains. Idem, l. xii, c. 13. de Gen. ad lit.

Ver. 27. Thou wilt not leave[3] my soul in hell. This is also the Prot. translation; and the manner in which Beza translates it, is both very

false and ridiculous, thou shalt not leave my carcass in the grave. For allowing that the Latin and Greek word, which is here translated hell, may signify sometimes, the grave; yet no excuse can be made for putting carcass, where the Greek, as well as Latin, signifies the soul. And for the doctrine of Christ's descending into hell, even the learned Dr. Pearson on the Creed, observes with Catholics, that the article of the creed, wherein we say, he descended into hell, cannot be the same as to say, his body descended into the grave, because in the foregoing words we profess that he was dead and buried. Wi. — Beza plainly confesseth that he translateth the text thus: Thou shalt not leave my carcass in the grave, against the doctrine of purgatory, and Christ's descending into hell, although he alloweth, that most of the ancient Fathers were in that error. Thus opposing himself to plain Scripture and to the ancient Fathers, perverting the former, and contemning the latter, to overthrow an article of the apostles' creed. He descended into hell. New Test. in 1556.

Ver. 31. Foreseeing he (David) spoke of the resurrection of Christ. S. Peter shews them that the prophetic words of the Psalm, agree not to David in person, he being dead, and his body having remained in the grave, without rising from the dead. Wi.

Ver. 33. He hath poured forth this, which we see, and hear, by the effects, by the noise, as it were of thunder, by our speaking languages, &c. Wi. — It does not appear that the holy Spirit was visible to the multitude, whom S. Peter addressed. But they perceived sensible marks of his presence, in the great noise, which had called them together, and the divers tongues spoken by illiterate men, who had never studied. A.

Ver. 37. They had compunction in their heart, with sorrow for their sins, especially against their Messias. Wi.

Ver. 38. Be baptized: believing and making profession to believe, and hope for salvation, by the merits of Jesus Christ. Thus you shall receive the gift of the Holy Ghost, the grace of God, and perhaps those other gifts of speaking with tongues, working miracles, &c. Wi. — The gift of the Holy Ghost. That is, justifying grace, which is infused in our hearts by the laver of regeneration.

The exterior gifts of the Holy Ghost, the gift of tongues, of miracles, prophecy,

&c. were, in the beginning of the Church, more regularly the consequences of confirmation or imposition of hands. Calmet.

Ver. 39. The promise is to you. The good tidings of salvation were first announced to the Jew, then to the Gentile; first to the domestics, then to the strangers, who are far off. It is rather singular, that S. Peter, after here so clearly shewing that the Gentiles are called to the faith, should afterwards have made such objections to go to baptize Cornelius, because he was a Gentile.

This can only be reconciled, by supposing, he did not know distinctly the time nor the manner of their vocation. Calmet.

Ver. 40. And with a great many other words did he testify and exhort them. S.

Luke only gives an abridgment of those exhortations, which S. Peter, and the apostles frequently gave to all the people. S. Peter, as S. Chrys. observes, and as we see in these Acts, was the mouth of all the rest. And on this first day of Pentecost, about three thousand were converted. Wi.

Ver. 42. In the communication of the breaking of bread, by which some understand their ordinary meals, and eating together; others, of the celestial bread of the holy Sacrament, *artou*, *panis illius*, *scilicet Eucharistiæ*. The Eucharist is called both by S. Luke and S. Paul, the breaking of bread. M. in v.

42. and 46. — In the Syriac, for *artou*, is a term that means Eucharist, both here and in Acts xx. as the learned Joannes Harlemius remarks in *Indice Biblicorum*.

— S. Luke also gives here some account of the manner of living of these first Christians. 1. They were together, united in perfect charity. 2. They were frequently in the temple, and praying together. 3. They had all possessions in common. 4. They went from house to house to convert

souls, taking the food they found with joy, and simplicity of heart, their number daily increasing. 5. S.

Luke says they were in favour, and esteemed by all the people. 6. The apostles did many prodigies and miracles, to confirm their doctrine, which struck others with great terror and horror for their past lives. Wi.

Ver. 44. This living in common is not a precept for all Christians, but a life of perfection and counsel, for such as are called to it by heaven. See S. Augustin in Psalm cxii. and ep. cix. the practice of which is a striking proof of the one true Church, which has come down from the apostles.

Ver. 46. In the temple. Although by the death of our Saviour, the ceremonies and sacrifices were abrogated, and the new alliance had succeeded to the old, still it was not in the design of God, that the faithful should separated themselves from the rest of the Jews, or entirely give up the observances of the law. They continued to observe them, as long as the utility of the Church required it, but they observed them not as Jews. Thus they avoided giving scandal to the weak, and driving them from submitting to the doctrines of the Church. They disposed them insensibly to a more pure and spiritual worship.

S. Chrys. in Act. hom. vii. — This was burying the synagogue with honour.

Ver. 47. More and more he added daily to the Church, as it is clearly expressed in the Greek, *prosetitheî te ekklesia*, that we may see the visible propagation and increase of the same. We may here, and throughout the whole book, observe a visible society of men joined in Christ, which visible society may be traced through ecclesiastical history, down to our days, and which will continue, in virtue of Christ's promise, to the end of time, as the point of union, by which the true disciples of Jesus Christ are to be connected together in one body, and one spirit; "one Lord, one faith, one baptism." Eph. iv. 5. This book can shew the true Church ever visible, and ever speaking with authority to all that do not willingly shut their eyes, as plainly as the gospel doth shew the true Christ. "Every where the Church proclaims

the truth; she is the candlestick, with the seven lamps (Exod. xxv.); bearing the light of Christ, eptamukos," says S. Irenæus; which light nothing can obscure. Hence S.

Chrysostom says, "sooner shall the sun be extinguished, than the Church be obscured;" eukolioteron ton elion sbesthenai, e ten ekklesian aphanisthenai.

[1] V. 1. Pariter in eodem loco. omothumadon epi to auto, concorditer.

[2] V. 24. Solutis doloribus Inferni. lusas tas odinas adou, though in the common Greek copies, thanatou. See S. Chrys. hom vi.

[3] V. 27. My soul in hell. Animam meam in Inferno, ten psuchen mou eis adou.

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ACTS 3

CHAPTER III.

Ver. 1. To the temple. Though the Jewish ceremonies were shortly to cease, yet it was not unlawful to follow them; and they went to the temple as a proper place for prayer. Wi. — The ninth hour, that is, about three in the afternoon. But we must here observe, that the Hebrews divided the light into twelve hours, and the dark into twelve hours; so that their hours would be of unequal length: longer in summer, shorter in winter. Menochius. — The custom of praying three times in the day, is ancient among the Jews. Daniel at Babylon opened his window on the side which looked towards the temple of Jerusalem, and three times a day bent his knees before the Lord. The ancient Fathers of the Church have strongly recommended this established custom of praying three times in the day, morning, noon, and evening. It is indeed not a precept, but a religious observation, to which she invites all her children. See S. Clem. of Alex. Constit. lib. vii. c. 24. Tertullian de Jejuniis, &c. — In Catholic countries, the toll of a bell at morning, noon, and evening, announces the time for the recital of the Angelus Domini, a short prayer, in honour of the incarnation. At these moments, all, however employed, whether at labour in the field, or at home, all cease from their employment, till they have recited the prayer. The repetition of this, and similar practices, cannot be too strongly recommended to Catholics of the present day. They are of singular advantage in recalling the soul, which is too easily dissipated and distracted, to God, her first beginning, and her last end. A.

Ver. 4. Look upon us. S. Peter said this to raise his attention and expectation, but the poor man thought of nothing but an alms. Wi.

Ver. 6. But what I have, I give thee. Though S. Luke told us, (c. ii. 43.) that the apostles did many miracles and prodigies, yet this is the first specified. In the name of Jesus of Nazareth, (known by that name, though of Bethlehem) arise, and walk. In the name of Jesus, lately nailed to a cross. Wi. — This is not the shadow of a great name, magni nominis umbra, but the truth of what it signifies, a Saviour. Not without reason is this name in the Canticles compared to oil, in its

three-fold properties, of affording light, food, and medicine. When preached, it enlightens; thought on, it feeds us; and called on, it assuages our grief. Whence has such a sudden light of faith spread over the world, but in preaching the name of Jesus? How did this light shine, and attract the eyes of all, when proceeding like lightning from the mouth of Peter, it strengthened the weakness of the lame man's feet, and enlightened the minds of many spiritually blind? Did he not then scatter fire, when he exclaimed, in the name of our Lord Jesus Christ, arise and walk? This name is food too. Are you not refreshed, as often as you recall it to your mind? What is as powerful in consoling the mind? What so soon repairs our wearied senses, and gives new vigour to our strength; encourages virtues, cherishes chaste affections? All food is dry to me, if not seasoned with this oil; insipid, unless sprinkled with this salt. If you write, I relish it not, unless I read the name of Jesus. If you read, or speak, I take no pleasure in it, unless I hear the name of Jesus. Jesus is honey in the mouth, music to the ear, but ecstasy to the heart. This is also my medicine. Are you sad? let Jesus enter your heart, and thence ascend upon your tongue. And behold, at the rising of this star, every cloud will retire, and serenity return. Do you fall into a crime, or run on the brink of despair: call on this name of life, and you shall be restored to life, &c. S. Bernard, Serm. xv.

super Cant. propè medium.

Ver. 11. As he held Peter and John. That is, kept close by them, and with them, out of joy and gratitude. Wi.

Ver. 12. Peter seeing, made answer to the people. This is the second sermon, that is related, which, as S. Chrys. observes, was spoken publicly in the temple. — Why look you upon us? S. Peter, at the beginning takes care to give the glory to God. Wi.

Ver. 13. Who does not admire, in this second discourse of S. Peter, as well as in his first, the prudence and discretion, with which he blames the Jews? He reproaches them, but with such mildness, as not to offend them, and dispenses to them truths in proportion to their capacity to bear them; after the example of his master and Saviour, he sweetens

the bitterness of the truth, by furnishing them with an excuse. They sinned through ignorance. Calmet.

Ver. 14-15. The just one, and the holy one, even the author of life you killed: he that is the just one promised, the Messias, the Son of God, and true God. Wi.

Ver. 17. You did it through ignorance, but such as could not excuse the chief of you. Wi.

Ver. 20. The times of refreshment. The time of eternal rest and happiness, &c.

— These words, you may be saved, must be understood, to make the sense complete. Wi.

Ver. 21. Whom heaven indeed must receive, as also in the Prot. translation not contain: nor can any argument be drawn from hence, that Christ's body cannot be truly at the same time in the holy Sacrament, especially after a different manner. The true sense of these words is, that heaven is the place of Christ's abode, till the day of judgment, and that it was in vain for them to think that he would come to take possession of any temporal kingdom. Wi. — The restitution of all things. Jesus remains in heaven, till his second coming to judge the living and the dead. That is the great day, when every thing shall be finally settled, and restored to its proper order. He shall avenge the injuries done to God; restore peace to the afflicted just men of the earth, and justice to their persecutors. He shall exalt his Church, and himself receive the homage of adoration, from every tribe of men. Calmet. — See 2 Peter iii. 13. which text, together with what we read in this place, joins inseparably the last coming of Jesus Christ, with the universal re-establishment promised in both these passages, and completely excludes the Millennium, which some erroneously expect to take place between the accomplishment of the first and second of these events. See Bossuet's reflexions on the 20th ch. of the Apocalypse, where the errors of many Protestant writers, especially of Dodwell, are refuted.

To shew that the error of the Millennium cannot be assigned as a general cause which impelled the primitive Christians to martyrdom, it will suffice to produce this decisive passage of S. Justin, who after Papias, was the first supporter of that system: speaking to Tryphon concerning this temporal kingdom, which Christ was to enjoy here below, in the re-established Jerusalem with the saints risen from the dead, for a thousand years, he says:

"I have already confessed that many others, with myself, were of this opinion; .

.. but there are many others, and persons of sound faith, and exemplary conduct, who reject this opinion." In dialog. cum Tryph. n. 84. — Clement of Alexandria, S. Cyprian, and Origen, lay down principles diametrically opposite to this system. It has also been expressly combated by Caius, and S. Denis of Alexandria, one of the greatest luminaries of the third century, as we learn from Eusebius, and S. Jerom.

Ver. 22. Moses said. He brings them this testimony of Moses concerning the Messias, to shew the punishment they deserve for not receiving him. Wi.

Ver. 23. Which will not hear that prophet. S. Peter's argument is this. If disobedience to the ordinances of God by the voice of Moses, was punishable with death, how much more severe will be the punishment of those, who refuse obedience to the doctrines of Jesus, to whom all the prophets bore testimony, and whom the apostles then preached. How different is this system of submission to the teaching of the prophets, and apostles, from that libertinism, which undermines the whole fabric of religion, by taking away from the Church the power of commanding, and from the disciple the necessity of obeying. By what wonderful and progressive shades of light was the prediction of this great prophet made to man! From the fall of Adam, it was predicted, that the seed of the woman would crush the serpent's head. Many ages after, God manifested that from Abraham's loins the Redeemer should spring, "in whom all nations should be blessed." The promise is renewed to Isaac, and that he is to spring from his son, but not from Esau, but from

Jacob; and of the twelve sons of Jacob, the posterity of Juda is to have the privilege of bestowing a Messias to the world, and the token of its accomplishment is,

"the failure of the sceptre in the posterity of Juda." After a long series of events, and of ages, an humble shepherd is chosen in the tribe of Juda: he is led to the throne; and to this man, David, it is repeated, that from him the Messias shall spring, and that his kingdom shall have no end. The oracle is so explicit in the psalms of that king, and in the writings of successive prophets, that it not only expresses the race, the tribe, the family, but also the character of the mother, the place of his birth, the precise period of the event, the ministry, the power, the dignity, the circumstances of his death, the change of the covenant, and conversion of the world. The particular prophecies, in their accomplishment, were a visible earnest to the Jews of the accomplishment of the prophecies relative to the Messias. Hence Pascal very justly remarks: "The prophets mingle particular prophecies with those of the Messias; that the prophecies regarding the Messias may not be without proof, and that the particular prophecies may not be without effect." *Pensées*. xv. — These oracles, which during a period of four thousand years, have been delivered to the world, and which have been completely and visibly fulfilled, still exist in books, scrupulously preserved by the greatest enemies of Christ, and of his holy religion, and satisfactorily demonstrate Jesus Christ to be the great prophet, and the Christian religion to be the new covenant, which had been announced so many ages before, in so many different manners.

Ver. 25-26. You are the children . . . to you first God raising up his Son. He gives them encouragement, that not only the promise of sending the Messias was made to them, but that he came, and is to be preached to them: and that the blessings of his coming are first offered to them. Wi.

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ACTS 4

CHAPTER IV.

Ver. 1. The officer[1] (of the guard) of the temple: lit. the magistrate of the temple. But this magistrate, by the Greek, was an officer over soldiers; we may presume, over those who were to guard the temple. Wi.

Ver. 2. The resurrection. This vexed particularly the Sadducees, who denied the resurrection: and they had great power among the Jews. Wi.

Ver. 4. Five thousand. Not that hereby is meant the whole number of the believers, but five thousand, by this miracle and preaching, were added to those that believed before. Wi. — Here again we remark the visible increase of the Catholic Church, by the preaching of the word.

Ver. 5. Their rulers, &c. The chief of them, and Annas, the high priest; perhaps he had lately succeeded Caiphas, high priest of the year before. Wi.

Ver. 7. By what authority? Is it by your own authority, or that of some other, you have healed this lame man? They wished to know if it was a true miracle, or the effects of some secret magic or enchantment. The knowledge of this kind of affairs belonged to them. It was their duty to repress the attempts of false prophets, seducers, and magicians. But they might easily discover that the apostles were far removed from any thing of this kind. The simple narration of the fact was enough to acquit them. Calmet.

Ver. 10. Name of our Lord Jesus. From this, S. Chrysostom takes occasion to make several pathetic exhortations against swearing and profaning this adorable name. What profit do you propose to yourselves by abusing this name? Is it to gain credit to your discourse? So you will tell me; but, believe me, you are mistaken: if people saw you respected oaths, and were afraid to make free with them, then they would believe you. Not when you give them to understand that you undervalue them, by your frequent abuse of them. Break then so

profane a custom. It will cost you neither money nor labour to do so: you are not required to part with any gratification for this purpose. Use only at the beginning a little diligence, and you will easily overcome so idle a practice.

Wish, and it is done. S. Chrys. super Act. sparsim. A. — Whom you crucified.

S. Peter, without fear or apprehension, openly and boldly tells them of their heinous crime: that Christ is the head corner stone, which they had rejected, as Christ himself had told them, (Matt. xii. 10.) and that there is no other name under heaven given to men to be saved by. Wi.

Ver. 13. The constancy of Peter and John, surprised the council very much.

They admired their knowledge of the Scriptures, seeing them men without learning or letters,[2] and (as they are called idiots) they could not find how to contradict the fact, the man that was healed, being there present. Wi. — Here, with the Jewish people, you may admire the constancy, wisdom, and learning of the apostles, after the coming of the Holy Ghost, who, before that event, were simple, unlettered, and timorous men. See v. 19; and again, C. v. 29.

Ver. 16. What shall we do to these men? They were perplexed, says S. Chrys.

and in greater fear than the apostles. They saw they could do nothing but threaten and charge them to speak no more of Jesus. Wi.

Ver. 19. But Peter and John stopped their mouths, by asking them, if it was reasonable for them to hearken to men rather than to God. For we, say they, (v.

20.) cannot but speak the things which we have seen and heard. Wi.

Ver. 20. We have seen and heard. From these words, S. Chrysostom makes some important remarks on the conduct of Christians. On

returning from the theatre, or any public meeting, each can relate what he has seen and heard.

This is the fruit they reap from attending at public places of amusement; and would to God it were merely pleasure unmixed with poison. But on returning from Church, where they have been for instruction, they remember nothing, speak of nothing they have seen or heard. All is silence. Not even a thought is turned on what has been performed. Hom. x. in Act. — It is a curious fact, which the apologists for the innocence of modern plays would do well to attend to, that the theatre has always been avoided by the good and the virtuous of every age. When one of the ancient Fathers was exorcising a female demoniac, who had been possessed at the theatre, and bade the devil to depart; No, replied he, I had a right to take possession of her, for I found her in my own house. A.

Ver. 21. Threatening them. Here commences the history of the first persecution of religious opinion, which the passions of men have continued, and swelled to such a frightful length. But on this, as on all other occasions, it has defeated its own purpose, by adding firmness and constancy to the persecuted. Truth is not to be overpowered by violence. In vain have the kings and princes of the earth risen up against the Lord, and against his Christ. — When will men learn, that charity is the principle of conversion! — That is an unheard-of kind of preaching, said the great Pope, S. Gregory, which exacts belief by stripes. He was on this occasion reprehending the false zeal of certain indiscreet Christians at Rome, who were for compelling the Jews to become converts. A.

— The amiable Fenelon, in a letter to Prince Charles, the son of our James the Second, says: "No human power can force the impenetrable intrenchments of the human mind. Compulsion never persuades—it only makes hypocrites.

When kings interfere in matters of religion, they do not protect it; they enslave it. Give civil liberty to all; not by approving all religions, as indifferent, but, by permitting in others, what God permits."

Ver. 23. Being let go, they came to their own[3] company, relating with simplicity all that had happened.

Ver. 24. With one accord. With one mind, as in the Greek, and with one voice, being inspired by the Holy Ghost, they fell to prayer. Wi.

Ver. 30. That thou stretch forth thy hand.[4] Lit. in this that thou stretch forth thy hand to cures, &c. They pray to God, that he would continue to confirm their preaching by miracles. Wi.

Ver. 31. The place was shaken. Much in the same manner, as at the first coming of the Holy Ghost. — They were all filled with the Holy Ghost. Their hearts were inflamed and excited by a new motion of grace. Wi.

Ver. 32. All things were common. Happy would it be for society, if the rich of the present day were to imitate, in some degree, this charity of the first disciples, by distributing to those that want. Both would hereby become more happy; nor would the rich derive less pleasure from such actions, than the poor. S. Chrys. hom. xi. in Acts. — That cold and fatal word, mine, and thine, which has caused so many misfortunes and wars, was banished from among them. Id. hom. de S. Philogon. — Some take this to be the origin of a monastic life: but according to the Fathers, it is rather its progress and increase; for it began in the family of Jesus Christ. The apostles, indeed, may be said to institute here that common life, which they led under Christ, our Lord, and of which Peter speaks: behold, we have left all. This life, by S. Augustin and others, is called apostolic, and there among all, wives are particularly specified. Cajetan thinks no vow was required: S. Augustin is of a different sentiment. Serm. x. de diversis & alibi.

Ver. 33. And great grace was in them all. All of them were present, were replenished with extraordinary graces of charity, zeal, &c. Wi.

Ver. 36-37. Joseph . . . surnamed Barnabas, the son of consolation, &c. He seems to be mentioned as the first that sold all he had, and brought the price, and laid it at the feet of the apostles. Wi. — There was at that time a great number of Jews established in this city. V.

Ver. 37. Sold it, &c. It is probable, that the faithful of Palestine disposed of all their property, because they knew that presently Judea would be delivered up to its enemies, and they would be obliged to fly, to avoid the persecution of their countrymen, as well as of strangers. D. Thomas ad Galatas. xi. — At the feet of the apostles, out of respect. Thus, the Sunamitess fell down and embraced Eliseus's feet. Many that asked favours of Christ, fell down at his feet, and Mary kissed his feet. Such are signs of reverence paid both to Christ, and to other sacred persons, prophets, apostles, popes. See in S. Jerom, how the people of Jerusalem flocked together to the venerable bishop Epiphanius, in Cyprus, presenting their children for his blessing, kissing his feet, plucking the hem of his garment, so that he could not move for the throng. S. Jer. Ep.

lxi. c. 4. contr. error. Jovin.

[1] V. 1. An officer of the guard of the temple. Magistratus templi, strategos tou ierou.

[2] V. 13. Sine literis, agrammateis. Idiotæ, idiotai, plebeii.

[3] V. 23. Ad suos, pros tous idious.

[4] V. 30. In eo quod extendas, en to ekteinein, by stretching forth, &c.

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ACTS 5

CHAPTER V.

Ver. 1. It is believed by many of the Fathers, that the resolution which the faithful made of selling their property, and laying the price at the feet of the apostles, implied a vow of reserving nothing for themselves, but giving all to the community; and that the crime of Ananias and Saphira consisted in the violation of this vow; on which account they regarded them as sacrilegious, and plunderers of sacred things. See S. Basil, Serm. i. de instit. Monac. S.

Cyprian, lib. i. ad Quir. &c. — For, without this supposition, we cannot, as Menochius justly remarks, account for the sudden and severe punishment inflicted on the offending parties.

Ver. 2. By fraud kept part.[1] Ananias, and his wife Saphira, had made a promise or vow, to put into the common stock the price of what they had to sell. When they had sold the field, they resolved by mutual consent to keep for their private use part of the money, and to bring in the rest, as if they had received no more. The whole price being promised, and by that means consecrated to God, S. Aug. calls it a sacrilegious fraud, and S. Chrys. a theft of what was already made sacred to God. Wi.

Ver. 3. Why hath Satan tempted thy heart?[2] The present Greek copies, filled thy heart. Wi.

Ver. 4. Did it not remain to thee? That is, no one forced thee to make such a promise. — And being sold, was it not in thy power, and at thy free disposal, before such a promise? but promises and vows must be kept. Thou hast not lied to men, but to God, by lying to the Holy Ghost. Wi. — Thou hast not lied to men, only and principally, but to God also; for he had also lied to Peter, and the other apostles. Menochius. — "If it displeased God," says S. Augustin, "to withdraw part of the money they had vowed to God, how is he angry, when chastity is vowed and not performed! . . . let not such persons think to be condemned to corporal death, but to everlasting fire." Serm. x. de diversis. —

S. Gregory, on t his same subject, says: "Ananias had vowed money to God, which afterwards, overcome by diabolical persuasion, he withdrew; but with what death he was punished, thou knowest. See, then, what judgment thou art to expect, for withdrawing, not money, but thyself, from Almighty God." l. i. ep.

33.

Ver. 5. Ananias . . . fell down and gave up the ghost. S. Aug. says,[3] this severe judgment was to strike a terror of such dissembling fraudulent dealings into the new Church. It was also to shew that S. Peter, and the apostles, had the gift of prophecy. Wi. — Origen thinks his death was occasioned by the sudden fright and shame, with which he was seized. Pliny relates a similar accident in the sudden death of Diodorus Dialecticus, lib. vii. cap. 53. —

Menochius and Cornelius a Lapide think, that God struck him interiorly, as Peter spoke. . . . There are likewise different opinions among the Fathers, respecting the salvation of Ananias and Saphira. Some are of opinion, that as their fault was great, they died, and perished in their sin. but the ideas we are fond to cherish of the infinite mercy of God, would rather incline us to say, with S. Augustin, "I can believe that God spared them after this life, for his mercy is great. . . . They were stricken with the scourge of death, that they might not be subject to eternal punishment." S. Aug. Serm. cxlviii. olim. 10. et in Parmen. — S. Benedict also, in the 57th chapter of his rule, insinuates, that their death was only corporal. A. — It is not unreasonable, that the first violators of laws, should be punished with severity. It was thus that the Almighty treated Adam, the adorers of the golden calf, the first who broke the sabbath-day, &c. to prevent the effects of bad example. Calmet.

Ver. 7. Not knowing. Because no one durst tell her; so much did they honour, fear, and obey S. Peter. S. Chrys. hom. xii. — She came in; Peter did not call her, but waited, to afford her an opportunity of repenting. Œcumenius.

Ver. 8. Yea, for so much. That is, for the same sum as Ananias mentioned. This the wife said, not knowing what had before happened to her husband. Wi.

Ver. 12. Solomon's porch. This was outside of the temple, open to all, Jews and Gentiles, pure and impure. They assembled here, because it was a large place, where they could speak to many assembled. Had it been within the temple, the priests would have interrupted them, and not have wanted pretexts to silence them. Calmet.

Ver. 13. Of the rest, no one durst join himself to them. That is, none of those that did not believe: yet the people praised them, and the number of the faithful increased. Wi.

Ver. 15. On . . . couches, meaner beds for the poorer sort. — That Peter's shadow, &c. Thus was partly fulfilled what Christ had foretold, (Jo. xiv. 12.) that his disciples should do even greater miracles than he had done. Wi. — S.

Ambrose compares with these miracles wrought by S. Peter's shadow, those which the linen cloths, that had touched the relics of the holy martyrs, also wrought. Epis. liv. Si inanis quædam species vacuæ imaginis habere potuit in se vim salutis, quanto plus de corpore meruerunt attrahere salubritatis sacris impressa membris vincula passionis? If the empty appearance of an unsubstantial shadow possessed the power of giving health, how much more efficacy must the chains of the martyrs have drawn from the holy members, which they bound? — In appendice operum. S. Aug. serm. cciii. — St Augustin, speaking of the miracle performed by the saints now reigning in heaven, says:

"If the shadow of Peter's body could afford help, how much more now the fulness of his power? And if then a certain little wind of him, passing by, did profit them that humbly asked, how much more the grace of him, now being permanent and remaining?" Serm. xxxix. de sanctis.

Ver. 26. Then went the magistrate;[4] which by the Greek was a military officer.

But he did not bind them like prisoners, for fear of a tumult, but desired them to go along with them to the sanhedrim. Wi. — Without

violence. They persuaded them to appear willingly before the sanhedrim, thinking, perhaps, moreover, that they could not bind them, whom the walls of the prison could not confine. The apostles here, and on all other occasions, shew the most astonishing examples of patience, constancy, and obedience to the laws of the country. Menochius. — O Jews! who do you shut your eyes against the light?

why so blindly mad? You say the apostles took Christ from the tomb. Tell me, then, who stole the apostles from under your locks and bolts? Who conveyed them from your prison through the midst of your guards, without alarming them? Shall the evidence of the miracle serve only to make you the less open to conviction? Ven. Bede. D. Carthus.

Ver. 28. Commanding, we commanded you. That is, charged you severely. —

You have a mind to bring the blood of this man upon us. You will make us pass for guilty of the murder of the Messiah. Wi.

Ver. 29. Peter answered boldly, We ought to obey God, rather than men. And withal adds, that God had raised from death Jesus, the Prince and Saviour of mankind, by whose merits all might find repentance, and forgiveness of their sins; that they were witnesses of his resurrection, &c. Wi.

Ver. 33. They were cut to the heart;[5] exasperated to fury and madness, and were for killing them. Wi.

Ver. 34. Gamaliel. He that had been S. Paul's master, according to S. Chrys.

advised them to forbear, and do nothing rashly. Meddle not with these men; lit.

go from them.[6] For, saith he, if this be the work of men only, it will soon fall to nothing; but if it be from God, you cannot hinder it, and you will only make yourselves guilty, by resisting the designs of God. They consented to him, so far as not to put them to death; but they

made them be scourged, which they rejoiced at; and they dismissed them with reiterated threats. Wi. — Gamaliel was the master of S. Paul, Barnabas, Stephen, and others, and favoured the Christians. S. Clement and Ven. Bede think he was then a Christian, but concealed his conversion at the instigation of the apostles, that he might have an opportunity of defending Christ in the council. He afterwards professed his faith publicly, and was canonized with his son Abibas. See Baronius, 3d of Aug.

Tirinus.

Ver. 39. Time, and the evident success of Christ's Church, prove it to be of God. No violence of the Jews, no persecution of heathen princes, no attempts of domestic adversaries, heretics, schismatics, or evil livers, have been able to prevail against it. Men of superior abilities have made violent attacks against it; their memory, and that of their disciples, has either been buried and forgotten, or liveth only in malediction and infamy. Let, then, no Catholic be dispirited, because modern heresies continue; Arian and other heresies have continued much longer, have been more powerfully supported by temporal power, and yet have come to nothing. The Catholic religion was the first, and it will be the last religion.

Ver. 41. Rejoicing. The joy of the apostles on the present occasion, is one of the greatest of miracles. Only the yoke of Jesus could make this sweet. But so the faithful servants of God have always found it. In tribulation, they abounded in inward peace and joy, which made them insensible of their exterior sufferings. A.

[1] V. 2. Defraudavit, enosphisato. Intervertit aliquid de pretio. S. Aug. serm.

xxvii. de verbis apostoli. Sacrilegii damnatur, & fraudis. See S. Chrys. hom xii.

in Acta.

[2] V. 3. Tentavit. In all Greek copies at present, eplerosen. But S. Epiphan.

Hær. lix. p. 500. reads epeirasen.

[3] V. 5. See S. Aug. l. iii. cont. Parmen. c. i. p. 56. tom. 9. nov. Ed.

[4] V. 26. Magistratus, o strategos.

[5] V. 33. Dissecabantur. dieprionto; which Arias Montanus translates furebant.

[6] V. 34. Discedite ab istis. apostete.

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ACTS 6

CHAPTER VI.

Ver 1. Of the Grecians against the Hebrews.[1] By the Grecians are many times understood the heathens or pagans, as Acts xiv. 1. xviii. 4., &c., but here by Grecians (which some translate Hellenists or Grecists) we may understand those new converted Christians, who had been Jews before, but who had been born in places where the Greek tongue was spoken; as by the Hebrews, we may understand those converted to the Christian faith, who were of the Jewish race, born, and bred in those places, where they spoke not Greek, but Syriac, which was then the language of the Jews. This difference is grounded on the Greek text. — Their widows were neglected; that is, they seemed less regarded, or less favoured in the daily distributions, than such as were of the Jewish race, and spoke the language of the Jews, as it was then spoken in Palestine. Wi. — They were most probably both of Jewish origin, and received their different appellations according to the language they spoke. The former were also frequently called Hellenists. Calmet. — It is not certain in what the Greek widows were despised. Some imagine, that a preference was given to their rivals, in the distribution of offices, that they were appointed to the meaner charges, and oppressed with too much labour. But it is most natural to suppose, that the complaints regarded the alms that were distributed, and that the necessities of both parties were not supplied, without the appearance of partiality. Menochius. — For c. iv. we read neither was there any one among them that wanted; and distribution was made to every man, according as he had need; and the multitude of believers had but one heart and one soul. But nothing in human institutions is so good, as not to require occasional reform, owing either to the wickedness or negligence of man. E. in dif. loc.

Ver. 2. And serve tables. The apostles did not judge it proper for them to be so much employed in managing that common stock, out of which every one, as they stood in need, were supplied, as to meat, and all other necessities: this took up too much of their time, which might be better employed in preaching,

&c. Wi. — Word of God. The most essential duty of an apostle and bishop, is to announce the word of God. S. Paul would not even baptize, lest it should be a prejudice to the performance of this great duty, for which he had been sent.

Many think, that this ministry of the tables, here signifies, not only the distribution of corporal nourishment, but the dispensing of the holy Eucharist.

As sacred and divine as was this latter duty, the apostles preferred before it, their obligation of preaching. Calmet.

Ver. 3. Look ye out among you seven men, and men of a good repute and character, full of the Holy Ghost. Wi. — Diverse circumstances prove, that they were chosen to be about the altar also. They were to be full of the Holy Ghost and wisdom: they received the imposition of the apostles' hands, and in them S. Paul requireth, in a manner, the same conditions as in bishops; all which would not have been necessary for any secular stewardship. See Acts xiii. 3.

Immediately after their ordination, they preached, baptized, disputed, as we see in S. Stephen, &c. &c. Hence S. Ignatius: "it is ours to please by all means the deacons, who are for the ministry of Jesus Christ; for they are not servitors of meat and drink, but ministers of the Church of God. For what are deacons but imitators or followers of Christ, ministering to bishops, as Christ to his Father, and working unto him a clean and immaculate work, even as S.

Stephen to S. James? Ep. ad Tral.

Ver. 5. By the names of these seven, it would appear, that they were all Greeks.

The reason of this, most probably, is to silence more effectually all future murmurs, by giving to the aggrieved party protectors of their own nation.

Tirinus. — The history of Stephen occurs hereafter. Philip, in the 8th chapter, is called an evangelist, that is, a preacher of the gospel. By Eusebius, Tertullian, and others, he is called an apostle, that is, an apostolic man. See Lives of the Saints, and Rom. Martyrology, June 6. — S. Jerom says, his tomb, and that of his four daughters, the prophetesses, were to be seen at Cæsarea, in Palestine. Ep. ad Eustoch. — Of the rest, except Nicolas, nothing certain is known: their acts have perished. Nicolas, as appears from the text, was a proselyte, first to Judaism, then to Christianity. S. Epiphanius, and many others, accuse him of being, by his incontinency, the author, or at least the occasion of the impure sects of Nicoalites and Gnostics. Clement of Alexandria, and S. Augustin, acquit him of this, and attribute the above heresies to an abuse of some expressions, which he uttered in his simplicity, and which were susceptible of a good and bad sense. See Baronius and Tillemont.

Ver. 6. And they, that is, the apostles, laid, or imposed hands upon them. These deacons, therefore, were designed and ordained for a sacred ministry, and not only to manage the common stock, and temporals of the faithful. This is proved, 1. By the qualifications required in such men, who were to be full of the Holy Ghost. 2. This is evident from their ecclesiastical functions mentioned in this book of the Acts, and in the epistles of S. Paul, and by the ancient Fathers. S. Stephen and S. Philip immediately preached the gospel, as we find in this, and the 8th chapter; they baptized those that were converted. In the first ages they assisted the bishops and priests at their divine office, and distributed the sacred chalice, or cup of the holy Eucharist. They succeeded as it were, the Levites of the old law. And in the chief Churches, the deacons, or the archdeacons in the first ages, had the chief administration of the ecclesiastical revenues, as we read of S. Laurence, at Rome. Wi. — Imposed hands upon them. Notwithstanding the opinions of some, that these deacons were only the dispensers of corporal food, and therefore very different from the ministers of the altar, who now bear that name, it must nevertheless be observed, that the most ancient Fathers, SS. Justin, Irenæus, &c. have acknowledged in them the two-fold character, and always style them the ministers of the mysteries of God. At the commencement of

Christianity, the faithful generally received the holy Eucharist after a repast, which they took together, in imitation of our Saviour, who instituted the Sacrament after supper. Now the deacons, who presided over the first tables, after having distributed the corporeal food to the assembly, ministered also the food of life, which they received from the hand of the bishop. Thus were they ministers of both the common and sacred tables. Afterwards, they had assistants called sub-deacons, and as among the Gentile converts, there did not exist that community of goods, as at Jerusalem, their chief employment became to serve the bishop in the oblation of the holy sacrifice. Calmet.

Ver. 9. Called of the Libertines.[2] That is, of the synagogue of those, whose fathers had been made slaves under Pompey, and the Romans, but who had again been restored to their liberty, and had been made free. There were other synagogues for the Jews of Cyrene, of Alexandria, &c. No doubt but S.

Stephen had converted many of them; and the chiefs of the synagogues, not being able to dispute with him, or to answer the spirit of wisdom, which directed him, they suborned witnesses. Wi.

Ver. 11. Who should say, that they heard him speaking words of blasphemy against Moses, and against God, against the law and the temple: that Jesus would destroy the temple. These accusations were forged; for the apostles themselves still frequented the temple, and Jesus came to fulfil the law, as to its moral precepts. Wi.

Ver. 13. It was true that Jesus would destroy the place, and change their traditions, yet they were false witnesses, because they deposed, that Stephen had made these assertions, which he had not, purposely to excite the Jews to rise up against him, and put him to death. Besides, had Stephen spoken what was advanced against him, they still would have been false witnesses, for the words were in fact words of truth, which these suborned men called, words of blasphemy. See v. 11.

Ver. 15. Saw his face, as it were the face of an angel. All in the council, or sanhedrim, saw an extraordinary and charming brightness in the countenance of Stephen, which struck them with admiration and fear.

Wi. — Angel. His face shone with a wonderful brightness, an emblem of his interior perfection. In this he was like Moses, whose countenance was so bright, that the Jews could not steadfastly behold it. By this the beholders had an opportunity of being converted, had they so wished, or were rendered inexcusable for their neglect.

It is also a testimony of the great sanctity of the deacon. This same miracle is not recorded to have happened to any other but Moses, and our Lord at his transfiguration. D. Dion. Carthus. — Although this appearance, in an inferior degree, has been not unfrequently observed in the constant and cheerful countenance of the martyrs before their persecutors, and of privileged saints, whilst they were happily employed in their intimate communications with heaven.

[1] V. 1. Græcorum, elleniston, not ellenon. See also Acts ix. 29. and xi. v. 20.

See Legh Critica Sacra.

[2] V. 9. Libertinorum, Libertinon, which Greek word is taken from the Latin. S.

Chrys. hom. xv. says, apeleutheroi outo kalountai, &c.

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ACTS 7

CHAPTER VII.

Ver. 1. Are these things so? The high priest speaks after this mild manner, being either terrified, or charmed with his angelical countenance. S. Stephen's design in this discourse, was to shew them, first, that he was falsely accused of speaking either against Moses, or the law, for which he shews so great a veneration. 2. He puts them in mind, that the true worship of God may subsist without a temple, as it did in the time of Abraham, and the patriarchs, before the law was given, or the temple built. 3. That as their forefathers had been rebellious to Moses, and disobedient to the prophets, whom they many times persecuted even to death, so they had lately resisted, persecuted, and crucified their Messias. Wi.

Ver. 5. Not the pace of a foot; not so much as a foot of land, that is, to dwell in, though he bought there a place to bury in. Gen. xxiii. 9. Wi.

Ver. 6. For four hundred years, counting from the birth of Isaac, which was twenty-five years after the call and promises made to Abraham. It is certain the Israelites were not four hundred years in Egypt. Wi. — Four hundred. These words are taken from the fifteenth chapter of Genesis, in which Moses mentions the same number of years. This calculation is made from the entry of Abraham into Chanaan, to the departure of the Israelites out of Egypt. Strictly, the Israelites did not remain in Egypt more than two hundred and fifteen years.

Ver. 7. The nation which they shall serve, I will judge. The meaning is, that God would afflict the Egyptians with divers plagues, or visible punishments, before they dismissed the Israelites. Wi.

Ver. 8. The covenant, or the testament,[1] and alliance of circumcision, by which the Israelites should be known to be the elect people of God. Wi. —

Literally, he gave them the alliance of circumcision; he made with him an alliance, of which circumcision was the seal. V.

Ver. 10. Gave him favour and wisdom in the sight of Pharaο. Some understand divine graces, and gifts of prophecy, and the like: others, that he made him find favour in the sight of king Pharaο, who appointed him to be governor of Egypt. Wi.

Ver. 16. Which Abraham bought . . . of the sons of Hemor, the son of Sichem.

This purchase made by Abraham must be different from the purchase of a field made afterwards by Jacob. Gen. xxxiii. 19. See a Lapide, the author of the Analysis, dissert. 23. P. Alleman, &c. Wi. — Abraham bought. There must be an error of the copyist in this verse. Either the word Abraham ought to be omitted, or changed into Jacob. For it is plain, from Gen. xxxiii. 19. that the latter bought the land from the sons of Hemor. The Hebrew says, he bought it for one hundred kesitha, which some translate pieces of silver; others, lambs. As for Abraham, and Jacob, they were buried in the cavern of Mambre, which Abraham had purchased from the children of Heth. Gen. xxiii. Calmet. — It is supposed that originally the name of Jacob was given, abridged JAB, and that the first letter having disappeared, the two remaining letters were taken by misprision, for the abridgment of the name of Abraham. Hemor was the father of Sichem, and here the Greek text simply calls him Hemor of Sichem. V.

Ver. 19. Dealing craftily, circumventing craftily, afflicting, and endeavouring to extirpate the race of the Israelites. Wi.

Ver. 20. Moses . . . was acceptable to God.[2] Greatly favoured both with gifts of nature and grace. Some expound it, was extremely fair or beautiful. Wi.

Ver. 21. Philo believes that the princess feigned him to be her own child; Moses denied that he was, and would not take advantage of this adoption.

Heb. xi. 24.

Ver. 22. In words and in deeds. Moses was persuasive and powerful in reasoning; but had an impediment in his speech, as we know from Exod. iv. 10.

and vi. 12. He possessed, moreover, strength, energy, and grandeur, in his discourse. Of this we have abundant proofs in his books. He is inimitable in narrating, as often as he writes laws, composes canticles, or makes harangues. He is simple, clear, sublime, vehement, concise, prolix, and rapid, in turns, as the nature of his subject requires. He was likewise powerful in work. All his conduct was wise, virtuous, enlightened, as well in affairs of policy, as in war. He was an able captain, before he put himself at the head of the Israelites. Calmet. — Josephus assures us that he became a great conqueror.

Ver. 29. Moses fled upon this word; because he perceived the murder he had committed was become public, though he thought it to be secret. Menochius.

He fled, to avoid the anger of the king, into Madian, where during his sojourning, he had two sons of Sephora, whom he married there. V. — Moses of Moyses, in the Egyptian dialect, means, saved from water. He slew the Egyptian by particular inspiration of God, as a prelude to his delivering the people from oppression and bondage. v. 25. supra. — But such particular and extraordinary examples are not to be imitated. Ch. — He was inspired to stand up, as the Egyptian law required, in defence of the innocent. S. Thom. ii. 2. q.

60.

Ver. 30. In a flame of fire, in a bush.[3] Lit. in the fire of a flame of the bush. The sense must be, that the bush seemed on fire, and in a flame, and yet was not consumed. Wi.

Ver. 33. Loose the shoes. This was a method of testifying respect among the eastern nations. The Mahometans do not wear their shoes in their mosques.

The Jewish priests served in the temple with their shoes off. The angel who appeared to Josue ordered him also to take off his shoes. Jos. v. 16. If the apparition of an angel, or of God himself, could make the place and ground holy so as to deserve external signs of respect, and veneration from Moses; how much more the corporal birth, abode, and miracles of the Son of God in Jewry, and the blessed Sacrament, must make that country, and all Catholic chapels and altars, holy? Is it not then the height of blindness to tax with superstition, the reverence Christians pay to things or places, rendered holy by the presence, or wonderful operations of God.

Ver. 35. Moses, whom they refused. Lit. denied. So have you rejected, and denied Jesus, of whom Moses prophesied, when he said that God would raise up to them a prophet like to himself, and commanded them to hear him. Wi. —

Redeemer. In the Greek Lutroten; Protestant version, Deliverer; though the learned Polus, in his Synopsis Criticorum, on this place, says, "that no greater injury is done to God, by calling Moses a Redeemer, in this place, than by calling him a Mediator, in Gal. iii. 19. He is called a Redeemer, says this learned Protestant commentator, in as much as he led forth, and preserved the people of God safe by the blood of a lamb, and thus exhibited a figure of the true redemption, through the blood of Christ." We all own that Jesus Christ, as having paid the ransom of our delivery with his own blood, is, strictly speaking, our only true Redeemer, and Advocate with his Father, who

asks and obtains all things immediately by his own merit; but this does not exclude the prayers of the saints, both alive and dead. Did not the apostles pray for the people, and desire the people to pray for them?

"Our Lord Jesus Christ still intercedes for us, and all the martyrs that are with him, pray for us: nor will their intercession cease, till we cease our groanings," says S. Augustin, in Ps.

lxxxv. in fine.

Ver. 38. This is he who was in the Church[4] in the wilderness, after God had by him delivered their Fathers out of their slavery in Egypt. — An angel spoke to him on Mount Sinai. By this S. Stephen owns that the law was given by an angel to Moses: and also shews how falsely he was accused to have spoken against Moses, or against the law.

Ver. 39. Whom our Fathers would not obey, murmuring, and rebelling from time to time. And in their hearts turned back into Egypt, as they shewed, by wishing themselves there again. Wi.

Ver. 40. Saying to Aaron, make us gods: forcing him, in a manner, to make them the golden calf, while Moses was receiving the law from God. Wi.

Ver. 42. And God turned. Turned as it were from them, punishing them, by permitting them to serve the host of heaven, the sun, moon, and stars. Wi.

Ver. 43. And you, that is, your forefathers, took unto you the tabernacle of Moloch. He reproaches the Jews with their idolatry and worship of different false gods, from time to time, notwithstanding God's comminations by the prophets, of which he puts them in mind by these words, and I will translate you beyond Babylon. The prophet Amos, c. v, v. 27. out of whom S. Stephen takes this citation, says, beyond Damascus, but the sense is the same, being a prediction, that the ten tribes of Israel should be carried away captives beyond Damascus by the Assyrians, and even beyond Babylon into Media, Persia, &c.

Wi.

Ver. 44. The tabernacle of the testimony, in which was the ark of the covenant, as they were made by Moses, which were moved from place to place with the Israelites in the wilderness; and which Jesus, or Josue, brought with the people, into the possessions of the Gentiles, that is, into the land of Chanaan, which had been before possessed by the Gentiles. — This tabernacle, in which was kept the ark, remained with the Israelites till the time of David, or rather of Solomon, who built the temple. **Wi.**

Ver. 48. But the most High dwelleth not in houses made by hands. God is every where, nor is his presence confined to the temple, which was already once destroyed; and what if it be destroyed again, as Christ foretold? God must still be adored, worshipped and served, as he was before the temple was first built, which was only by Solomon. **Wi.** — Dwelleth not in houses. That is, so as to stand in need of earthly dwellings, or to be contained or circumscribed by them. Though otherwise, by his immense divinity, he is in our houses, and every where else; and Christ in his humanity dwelt in houses: and is now on our altars. **Ch.** — It is not so much for God, as for ourselves, that we build temples, and it is a pure effect of his goodness and mercy, that he permits us to build them to him. Places consecrated in a particular manner to his service, where he gives the most sensible marks of his presence, are of assistance to us, when we render our homage, address our vows, and offer our prayers to the Deity. **S.** Stephen's design in this part of his discourse, is to prove that the true religion may subsist without the temple; therefore, that he could not be guilty of blasphemy, supposing he had even used the words which the malice of the Jews put into his mouth, that Jesus of Nazareth would destroy this place. **Chap. vi. 14.**

Ver. 51. Ye stiff-necked, and uncircumcised in heart. **S.** Stephen, inspired by the Holy Ghost, knowing he should die a martyr, boldly reproaches them for persecuting the prophets, for putting to death the

just one, that is, the Messiah, foretold by the prophets. Wi. — Observe the holy indignation of S.

Stephen at the obduracy of the incredulous Jews!

Ver. 54. They were cut to the heart: exasperated even to rage and madness.

See c. v, v. 33. gnashing their teeth with indignation. Wi.

Ver. 55. This is the comfort of all martyrs. B. — This the support of every Christian under the severest trials of either mind or body: this the sweetener of every burthen and cross.

Ver. 56. Stopped their ears, crying out, blasphemy: and they stoned him to death. He praying for them, and saying, Lord Jesus, receive my spirit, in imitation of his Lord and Master, our Saviour Christ. And[5] reposed in the Lord. Lit. slept. In most Greek copies, are now wanting, in the Lord; but it is no doubt the sense. Wi. — Rushed in violently upon him. This proceeding, without any sentence, or form of law, was altogether irregular; and never used in the better times of the Jewish government. This was called, judgment of zeal, and only allowed in one instance, viz. when any one came to draw the people to idolatry. Afterwards, this kind of proceeding was extended to other crimes. See Deut. xiii. 6. Num. xxiv. 1 Mac. xi. 24, &c.

Ver. 58. Invoking. See with what arms S. Stephen defended himself against the fury of his enemies. He puts on charity for a breast-plate, and by that came off victorious. By his love of God, he resisted the enraged Jews; by the love he bore his neighbour, he prayed for those that stoned him. Through charity, he admonished them of their errors, in order to their amendment; through charity, he besought the divine goodness not to punish their crimes against him.

Leaning on charity, he overcame the cruelty of Saul, and merited to have him a companion in heaven, who had been his chief persecutor on earth. S.

Fulgentius, Serm. de S. Steph. — We here again see the powerful intercession of the saints; "for," says S. Augustin, "if Stephen had not thus prayed, the Church would not have to glory in a S. Paul. Si Stephanus non sic orasset, Ecclesia Paulum non haberet." Serm. i. de S. Steph.

[1] V. 8. Testamentum, ten diatheken. See Heb. ix. 16.

[2] V. 20. Gratus Deo, asteios to theo. Acceptable to God. It may also signify, beautiful in the sight of God, that is, in the style of the Scriptures, very beautiful.

[3] V. 30. In igne flammæ rubi, en phlogi puros batou. In flamma ignis rubi.

[4] V. 38. In the assembly. Lit. in Ecclesia, en te ekklesia.

[5] V. 56. Obdormivit in Domino, ekoimethe.

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ACTS 8

CHAPTER VIII.

Ver. 1. Were dispersed. During this great persecution of the Church, those who could not conceal themselves, were dispersed into different countries. Thus did the Almighty make use of the malice of his enemies, to the greater exaltation and glory of his own name. For those who fled, carried with them the light of the gospel, wherever they went. Tirinus. — They were burning torches, which communicated of their holy fire to every place, in which they were scattered. S. Aug. Serm. cxvi. — Thus was the gospel disseminated from Jerusalem into all Judea and Samaria. — And Samaria. Though our Saviour in his life time had forbid them to preach to the Samaritans, (Matt. x. 5.) they now knew that the time of that precept was past. Wi.

Ver. 2. Took care. In an ancient work, which gives the history of the finding of S. Stephen's body, generally considered authentic, and printed at the end of the 7th vol. of S. Augustin's works, we find the following account. "Stephen having been stoned without the northern gate, lay there without burial one day and a night, according to the order of the Jewish rulers, that his body might become a prey to birds and beasts, but God did not suffer either to touch it."

— "Then I, Gamaliel, compassionating these servants of Jesus Christ, and desiring to have some share in the faith and religion of this holy man, sent among the Jews some Christians who feared God, dwelling at Jerusalem, to take away privately the body, and bring it in my chariot to my country house, where it was deposited in my tomb towards the east, and we mourned over it for forty days," &c. It is an injury to pray for a martyr, who ought to assist us by his prayers. S. Aug. Serm. xvii. — We see great devotion used in burying his body, and four centuries afterwards, at the finding and translating thereof.

Very many miracles were performed on that occasion, as S. Augustin witnesses in his work de Civitate Dei. l. xxii. c. 8. and Serm. de S. Steph. T. viii.

Ver. 10. This man is the power of God, which is called (that is, which is truly) great. Simon pretended to be God, and the great God. See S. Iræn. l. i. c. 20.

Ver. 11. He had bewitched them with his sorceries,[1] or magic: he had put them out of their wits, turned their heads, charmed them, stupefied them. Wi.

Ver. 13. Simon himself believed. That is, pretended to believe, that he might obtain the power of speaking tongues, and working miracles, which was frequently imparted to the faithful at baptism. Menochius. — He was filled with pride and presumption, says S. Aug. He wished to imitate the prodigies of the apostles, but loved not their justice, nor the truth they preached. He entered into the Church, and desired baptism, not to obtain the grace of justification, but to have an occasion of extolling himself. He wished to walk in wonders above himself. In Psalm cxxx.

Ver. 15. The Holy Ghost, which the apostles came to give the Samaritan Neophytes, was not the spirit of grace, of justice, and of sanctity, for that they had received at baptism; but the spirit of strength, to confess with confidence and freedom the name of Jesus, and the supernatural and miraculous graces, usually at that time granted to the faithful, by the imposition of hands. Philip did not administer the sacrament, because he could not; he was not a bishop.

Hence now in the Church, we see only the chief pastors do it, præcipuos et non alios videmus hoc facere. See S. Chrysost. hom. xviii. in Acta. — There is no mention here, it is true, of unction, but the most venerable antiquity clearly specifies it. S. Cyprian, in the third age, says: "it is moreover necessary, that he who has been baptized, should be anointed, that having received the chrism, that is, the unction, he may be the anointed of God." Ep. lxx. — In the next age, S. Pacianus writes: "Do you say that this (the power of remitting sins) was granted only to the apostles? Then I say, that they alone could baptize, and give the Holy Spirit, for to them alone was the command of doing it given. If, therefore, the right of conferring baptism, and of anointing, descended

to their successors, to them also has come the power of binding and loosing." Ep. i. ad Sym. Bibl. Max. T. iv. p. 307.

Ver. 17. They received the Holy Ghost. Not but that they had received the grace of the Holy Ghost at their baptism; but not that plentitude of grace, and those gifts, which they received from bishops in the sacrament of confirmation. This sacrament, as S. Chrys. observes,[2] S. Philip, the deacon, had not power to give. Wi.

Ver. 18. Simon . . . offered them money. From hence it is called the sin of simony, to but, sell, or give money for benefices, and spiritual things. It was vanity that made Simon desire this power. Wi. — Hence to give or receive money in exchange, or as a price for any spiritual good whatever, is justly esteemed sinful. It is called simony, from the name of the person, who was first engaged in this sin. A. — Simon acts the part of a tempter to the apostles, and wishes to draw them into prevarication, by offering money for what was above all price, and of what they were not the proprietors, but the dispensers.

S. Clement. Rom.

Ver. 20. May thy money perish with thee; or go with thee to perdition. This was a prophecy, says S. Chrys. of S. Peter who saw him incorrigible, and that he would not repent. Wi.

Ver. 21. Nor lot in this matter. Lit. in this saying. Wi.

Ver. 22. That perhaps this thought of thy heart may be forgiven thee. The word perhaps, as the interpreters commonly observe on this and other places, many times does not imply any doubt or uncertainty. There could be no doubt, says S. Chrys. only as to his repenting: if he repented, it is certain he would find remission of his sins. Wi. — S. Augustin (ep. cviii.) understands the text, metanoeson apo, &c. of penance done for heinous offences in the primitive Church, and teaches us to translate it thus, as it is in the Vulg. both here and 2

Cor. xii. 21. Apoc. ix. 21. and adds, that very good men do daily penance for venial sins, by fasting, prayer, and alms.

Ver. 23. In the gall of bitterness. In the bitter gall of hypocrisy, in the bonds, fetters, and chains of sin and iniquity. Wi.

Ver. 24. Pray . . . for me. Instead of following the advice of S. Peter, he begs them to pray, not that God would touch his heart, and give him repentance; but that the evils might not fall upon him. In this he is a true model of false penitents, who hate not the sin, but fear the punishment, which is the consequence of it. He afterwards left the East, and went to Rome, under the reign of Claudius. SS. Justin, Irenæus, and others say, the senate adored him as a divinity. Having undertaken to fly in the air, in the presence of the emperor and senate, when he had raised himself to a certain height, he was brought down by the prayers of SS. Peter and Paul, and died a few days after, of the wounds he received by the fall. Calmet. — See also Euseb. Theod. S. Aug. &c.

Ver. 26. This is desert. In construction, whether we regard the Latin or Greek, to be desert, may either agree to the way leading to Gaza, or the city itself, which formerly had been almost destroyed. Wi. — To the site of old Gaza, which was then a desert; above which was built the new Gaza, nearer the sea.

V. — Beza frequently makes very free with S. Luke, and in his annotations, an.

1556, says the text is wrong; it cannot be so.

Ver. 27. An eunuch. It is likely a proselyte converted to the Jewish religion. He shews his zeal and devotion, says S. Chrys. not only by coming to Jerusalem, but by reading the prophets in his chariot. Wi.

Ver. 31. How can I, unless some one shew me,[3] or be a guide to me, as in the Greek. Let every one, and especially the unlearned, take good notice of these words, not to wrest the Scriptures to his own perdition. To follow his own private judgment, or his private spirit, is to make choice of a blind and incompetent guide, as to the sense of the Scriptures, and the mysteries of faith. See the preface to the gospel of S. John. Wi. — It appears this eunuch was not one of those, who are now so commonly seen, who think the Scripture is every where plain, and the sense open to every body. Such would do much better to acknowledge, that they stand in need of a guide. Grotius, hic. — S.

Jerom, in his letter to Paulinus, printed at the head of the Latin Bibles, shews the necessity of an interpreter. The apostles themselves could not understand the Scriptures till Christ gave them the knowledge; tunc aperuit illis sensum ut intelligerent scripturas. Lu. xxiv. 45.

Ver. 32-33. As a sheep, or a lamb, &c. The eunuch, by divine Providence, was now reading the 53d chap. of Isaias, which is of Christ, and his sufferings. —

In humility his judgment was taken away. The sense seems to be, that Christ having humbled himself, so as to undergo an unjust judgment, or condemnation to die on the cross, hath been again raised from the

dead, and delivered from that judgment by his glorious resurrection, and ascension. Wi.

Ver. 36. Here is water. This shews, that baptism is to be given with water. Wi.

Ver. 37. If thou believest, &c. The Scripture many times mentions one disposition, when others no less necessary are supposed, as here a sorrow for sins, a firm hope, love of God, &c. Wi. — Faith is thus seen to be a necessary predisposition in the adult, for the reception of baptism. They must answer for themselves; but infants are baptized in the faith of the Church. Their sponsors, who receive them from the font, answer for them. D. Diony. Carthus. — And as the defilement was not personal, but that of others, so are they purified by the faith of others.

Ver. 38. We are not to suppose that in the administration of the sacraments in the primitive Church, nothing more was done than what we read, totidem litteris, in the Scripture. S. Augustin answers this, when he says: "insomuch that he saith, Philip baptized him, he would have it understood, that all things were done, which though in the Scripture, for brevity sake, they are not mentioned, yet by order of tradition we know were to be done."

**[1] V. 11. Dementasset, exestakenai autous. So v. 15. Stupens
admirabatur, the same word, existato.**

[2] V. 17. S. Chrys. hom. xviii. oude gar eichen exousian.

**[3] V. 31. Et quomodo possum, nisi aliquis ostenderit mihi? ean me tis
odegese me.**

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ACTS 9

CHAPTER IX.

Ver. 4. Why dost thou persecute me? My disciples, my brothers, and my friends. The head speaks for the members, and by a figure of speech, calls them itself. S. Aug. in Ps. xxx. — Here Jesus Christ identifies himself with his Church, as on a former occasion, when he said: he that heareth you, heareth me; and he that despiseth you, despiseth me. Lu. x. 16.

Ver. 5. To kick against the goad. Others translate against the pricks; others, against the sting. The metaphor is taken from oxen kicking, when pricked to go forward. Wi.

Ver. 7. There it shall be told thee, &c. The Almighty having established a Church, and ministry, the depositories of his doctrines, does not, even on this extraordinary occasion, transgress his own laws; but sends him to the ministers of religion, that instruction may be imparted through them, as through its proper channel. This observation is worthy the notice of the self-inspired of the present day, who pretend to receive their light direct from heaven. Nothing can be more opposite to the spirit of the gospel than such delusion. A. — Hear the great S. Augustin: "Paul, though with the divine and heavenly voice prostrated and instructed, yet was sent to a man to receive the sacraments, and to be joined to the Church." De Doct. Chris. l. i. in præm. —

Hearing, &c. This may be reconciled with what is said in the 22d chap. by supposing they heard only S. Paul speak, or heard only a confused noise, which they could not understand. Calmet.

Ver. 8. And his eyes being open, either by himself, or by others, he saw nothing. See the circumstances related again, c. xxii. and xxvi. Wi.

Ver. 9. Three days. During the time, he neither eat nor drank, to testify his sorrow for his past conduct. He likewise spent the time in prayer, to prepare himself for the reception of grace. S. Chrys. hom. xix.

Ver. 12. And he saw a man, &c. This verse, which is by way of a parenthesis, contains the words of the historian, S. Luke, telling us what S. Paul saw in a vision, and what the Spirit at the same time revealed to Ananias. Wi. — This verse is a parenthesis. It contains not the words of Christ to Ananias, but S.

Luke here relates what was shewn to Paul, at the time Ananias entered. This vision was shewn to him, that he might know Ananias was sent by God.

Menochius.

Ver. 15. A vessel of election. A chosen elect vessel, and minister of the gospel.

Wi. — Skeous ekloges, an organ, or instrument. Thus Polybius uses the word, speaking of Damocles, ode en uperetikon skeuos, he was an excellent and choice character.

Ver. 17. Laying his hands on him. This imposition of hands, made use of on different occasions, was to pray that he might receive his sight, as well as the grace of the Holy Ghost, which God sometimes gave to persons not yet baptized, as to Cornelius. Acts x. 44. Wi. — This imposition of hands, was not the same as that, by which the faithful were confirmed, or ordained ministers, but a ceremony commonly used by the apostles to restore health to the sick. If Saul, in consequence, receives the Holy Ghost, it was an extraordinary miraculous event, which was not an unfrequent circumstance in the infancy of Christianity. The Almighty, who establishes the laws of grace, can dispense with them himself whenever he pleases. Calmet.

Ver. 23. When many days were passed. By the account S. Paul gives of himself, (Gal. c. i.) soon after his conversion he went into Arabia, and about three years after he might come to Damascus. Then it seems to have happened that they were for killing him, for becoming a Christian; and the brethren saved his life, by conveying him down the walls of the town in a basket. After this, he went to Jerusalem, where the disciples knew little of him, and were afraid of him, till S. Barnabas introduced him to the apostles, and gave an account of his conversion. Wi. — Many days. That is, three years. For Saul went for a time from Damascus to Arabia. Gal. i. 17. and 18. It was on his return from thence, that the Jews conspired against his life, as is here related.

Tirinus.

Ver. 27. Brought him to the apostles Peter and James. See Gal. i. 18. and 19.

Ver. 29. He spoke also to the Gentiles,[1] and disputed with the Grecians, or Hellenists. See c. vi. v. 1. By the Gentiles, many understand those who had been Gentiles, and were become proselytes or converts to the Jewish religion, and not those who still remained Gentiles. And by the Greeks, or Hellenists, they understand Jews, who had lived in places where they spoke Greek, or Hellenists, they understand Jews, who had lived in places where they spoke Greek, not Syriac, whom S. Paul endeavoured to convert to the Christian faith.

Wi.

Ver. 31. The Church visibly proceedeth still with much comfort and patience; she is perfected by persecution, and by means of the promised infallible protection, she has ever proved herself invulnerable to all the envenomed shafts of her adversaries.

Ver. 35. Saron, or Assaron, is a mountain and city mentioned by Josue, xii. 18.

From it all the plain from Cæsarea of Palestine to Joppe, is called Saron. It is a rich fertile country. Tirinus.

Ver. 36. Tabitha, in Syriac, means the same as Dorcas in Greek, that is, a wild goat. V. — See here the powerful effects of good works, and alms-deeds; they reach even to the next life. B. — Hence that of the wise man, alms free from death.

Ver. 37. Washed. This custom of washing the dead was observed among the Greeks, Romans, Hebrews, and most other nations. It is still practised in monasteries, and formerly was observed with much ceremony. S. Chrysostom observes, that our Saviour's body was washed and embalmed. The same custom is mentioned in Homer and Virgil:

Corpusque lavant frigentis, et unguunt. — And again, Date, vulnera lymphis abluam. — Æneid. iv.

— Tertullian, in his Apology, testifies, that the Christians performed that office to the dead. It was a proof of their respect for the image of God impressed upon his creature, and for the character of Christian, which these persons have borne during their lives. It was likewise a sign of the confidence they had in a future resurrection.

Ver. 39. Chiton was the under garment, Imation the upper.

Ver. 40. And having put them all out, not to disturb him while he prayed. — Sat up, raised herself a little: and Peter taking her by the hand, lifted her quite up, and calling in the company, presented her to them alive and well. Wi.

Ver. 41. Raising the dead to life can only be the work of God. This woman was raised to life for the comfort of the faithful, and the conversion of others. She herself might likewise have an opportunity of acquiring greater merit, otherwise the repose of another life is preferable to a return to the miseries of this world. D. Dion. Carthus.

Ver. 43. In the Greek is added: instructing the new converts, and fortifying them in the faith they had just embraced.

[1] V. 29. Loquebatur quoque Gentibus, & disputabat cum Græcis. In almost all Greek copies, there is nothing for Gentibus, and we only read, he spoke and disputed with the Grecians, or Hellenists; pros tous Ellenistas. See c. vi. v. 1.

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ACTS 10

CHAPTER X.

Ver. 1. A cohort, with the Romans, was a body of infantry 500 strong. There were ten cohorts in each legion. There were, generally speaking, two centurions appointed to the command of each cohort. V.

Ver. 2. A religious man, and one that feared God. He was not a Jew, yet believed in one God. — Always, that is, frequently praying, and giving alms. In the Rheims Testament we find this note: "Hereby it appeareth, that such works as are done before justification, though they suffice not to salvation, yet are acceptable preparatives for the grace of justification, and such as move God to mercy. . . . though all such preparative works come also of grace." These Douay divines did not hold with the Quenellists that a true faith, or the habit of faith, must needs be the first grace. Wi. — Cornelius religiously observed the law of nature, and the principal points of the Jewish moral law, though he did not profess Judaism. Calmet. — He was an admirable example of virtue before his knowledge of Christianity. He feared God, and brought up his family in the same holy fear. He was leader of the first band, and consequently had the eagle, the Roman ensign, carried before him. Four hundred men were under his command. Tirinus. — "His former goodness could no longer avail him, unless he were, by the bond of Christian society and peace, incorporated with the Church; he is therefore ordered to send unto Peter, that by him he may learn Christ, by him he may be baptized." S. Aug. l. i. de bap. c. 8. — Alms.

Nothing is more efficacious than the alms of a man, whose hands have not been defiled by injustice. It is a clear stream, refreshing in the heat of day, and imparting verdure to every plant that is near it. It is a fountain springing to eternal life. It is a tree, whose branches reach even to heaven, and which produces its eternal fruit in abundance, when death has removed from you all that is temporal. Waste not, then, your treasures in selfish gratifications, the fruit of which is sorrow; but feed the poor, and the hungry. Plant and sow in their hands, and your produce will be great; no soil is more fertile. S. Chrys.

hic. hom. xxii.

Ver. 3. He saw in a vision manifestly. An angel appearing visibly to him. Wi.

Ver. 9. Stated hours for prayer were appointed both in the old and new law. Of this S. Cyprian writes: "In celebrating their prayers, we find that the three children of Daniel observed the third, sixth, and ninth hour. Thus afterwards, at the third hour, the Holy Ghost descended upon the apostles, fulfilling the grace of our Lord's promise: at the sixth hour, Peter going up to the higher room of the house, was both by voice and sign from God instructed, that all nations should be admitted to the grace of salvation, of which he before doubted; and our Lord being crucified at the sixth hour, at the ninth washed away our sins by his blood. But to us, besides the seasons observed of old, the set times of praying are increased; for we must pray in the morning early, that the resurrection of our Lord may be celebrated by morning prayer; in the morning early will I stand before Thee, early in the morning wilt thou hear my voice. Ps. v. Towards the evening also, when the sun departeth, we must of necessity pray again." De Orat. Dom. No. 15. S. Jerom, writing to Eustochia, a virgin, and a religious, (ep. 22.) says, "though the apostle bid us to pray always, and, to holy persons, their very sleep is prayer; yet we must have distinct hours for prayer, that if perhaps we be otherwise occupied, the very time may admonish us of our duty. The third, sixth, ninth hour, morning early, and evening, no man can be ignorant of."

Ver. 10. There came upon him an ecstasy[1] of mind. This is the true sense by the Greek. I have never yet eaten any unclean thing. This seems to have happened, an. 35. Till then the apostles followed the ceremonies of the law of Moses. It may seem strange that even S. Peter should not know that the ceremonial precepts of the law were to be abolished. It may be answered, that S. Peter and they, were only ignorant of the time, when they were to be laid aside; and so S. Chrysostom says, that the conversion of Cornelius, with all its

circumstances, was to convince the Jews, rather than the apostles, that those ceremonies were no longer obligatory. Wi.

Ver. 15. God hath purified. Not that the Almighty had already sanctified the Gentiles; but he had called them, that they might become so. He had thrown down the wall of separation, which had stood between Jew and Gentile; he had made one fold to contain all the sheep under one shepherd. Jesus Christ, by his blood, had generally reconciled all mankind to his Father. In this sense all were pure; that is, all had a right, as all were called, to partake of the merits of the Son of God. All had a right to communicate in the truths of the gospel, and in the sacraments, which were the appointed channels, through which the graces and merits of Jesus Christ were applied. Calmet. — Here, then, God first announced to Peter, that the time was come to preach to the Gentiles unto salvation, no less than to the Jews; with full freedom to eat all meats, without respect to the prohibition of some made in the old law. B.

Ver. 25. Cornelius . . . worshipped.[2] Some think Cornelius might look upon S.

Peter as more than a man, and offer to him divine worship: but by prostrating, he might only intend to pay such honour to him, as is paid to persons eminent in dignity, especially according to the custom of the eastern people. Wi.

Ver. 26. S. Chrysostom (hom. xxi in Act.) thinketh Peter refused this homage through humility, because this falling down, proskunein, is frequently used in Scripture towards men. S. Jerom (adv. Vigil. c. ii.) holds the contrary sentiment.

Ver. 28. Abominable a thing. The Jews extended their aversion to the Gentiles to an unnatural length; hence the frequent accusations of the latter, that they were a nation the enemies of mankind. Josephus defends his nation against the imputation. He allows that Moses forbids them to admit strangers into their solemnities, and exercises of religion, but not to refuse any thing which common humanity demands of all. Jos. lib. ii. con. App.

Ver. 35. In every nation, &c. That is to say, not only Jews, but Gentiles also, of what nation soever, are acceptable to God, if they fear him, and work justice.

But then true faith is always to be presupposed, without which, (saith S. Paul, Heb. xi. 6.) it is impossible to please God. Beware then of the error of those, who would infer from this passage, that men of all religions may be pleasing to God. For since none but the true religion can be from God, all other religions must be from the father of lies; and therefore highly displeasing to the God of truth. Ch. — He that feareth him, and worketh justice. So he calls the prayers, alms-deeds, and charitable works of this Gentile Cornelius. Wi.

Ver. 36. God sent the word.[3] By this word, some understand the eternal Word, the Son of God; but by the next verse, we may rather expound it of the word of the gospel preached. Jesus Christ . . . he is Lord of all things. A proof of Christ's divinity. Wi.

Ver. 37. For it began, or its beginning was, &c.

Ver. 39. Whom they killed. At the very first, says[4] S. Chrys. the apostles preached Christ crucified, and tell them they had put to death on a cross the Lord of all things, the judge of the living and the dead. Wi. — We may here admire how wonderfully Peter adapts his discourse to the capacity of his hearers. When speaking to the Jews, he proves Jesus to be their Messias, from the testimony of their prophets. On the present occasion, he only just alludes to the prophets, but confirms his discourse by the testimony of the miracles which Jesus had wrought in public, and were known to all the world.

Calmet.

Ver. 40. Jesus Christ did not announce his resurrection, and other mysteries, to all at once, but to a chosen few, who were to be governors of the rest; teaching us thereby, that we have to learn our religion, and every thing necessary to salvation, from the Church of God, speaking to us by her ministers.

Ver. 42. The living and of the dead. This may be understood of the elect, who live by grace, and the reprobate, who are spiritually dead; or perhaps more literally, of those who shall be found living upon earth at the second coming of Christ, and of all who have died from the commencement of the world to the end of time. S. Aug. Enchirid.

Ver. 44. The Holy Ghost fell upon all them, and made his coming known in some visible manner and exterior signs, as on the day of Pentecost. The Christians who had come with S. Peter, who before had been Jews, were astonished to see that such extraordinary gifts of the Holy Ghost were given to uncircumcised Gentiles. Wi.

Ver. 47. Can any man forbid water? &c. Or doubt that these, on whom the Holy Ghost hath descended, may be made members of the Christian Church, by baptism, as Christ ordained? Wi. — Such may be the grace of God occasionally towards men, and such their great charity and contrition, that they may have remission, justification, and sanctification, before the external sacraments of baptism, confirmation, and penance be received; as we see in this example: where, at Peter's preaching, they all received the Holy Ghost before any sacrament. But here we also learn one necessary lesson, that such, notwithstanding, must needs receive the sacraments appointed by Christ, which whosoever contemneth, can never be justified. S. Aug. sup. Levit. q. 84.

T. 4.

[1] V. 10. Mentis excessus, epepesen ep auton ekstasis.

**[2] V. 25. Procidens ad pedes ejus adoravit, peson epi tous podas
prosekunesen. The same word is often used for a civil worship.**

[3] V. 36. ton logon, verbum, but in the next verse for verbum, rema.

**[4] V. 39. S. Chrys. hom. xxiii, vides eos nunquam occultare crucem,
oras autous oudamou kruptontas ton stauron.**

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ACTS 11

CHAPTER XI.

Ver. 2. Disputed against him. S. Epiphanius makes Cerinthus, who was the next heresiarch to Simon Magus, the author of this dispute. He likewise says it was he, who excited the Jews against S. Paul, (Acts xxi.) and that the first Council of Jerusalem was convened to condemn him. S. Epiph. hæres. 28. c. ii.

Ver. 3. And didst eat with them. The Jews looked upon it as a thing altogether abominable, for them to eat with uncircumcised Gentiles; but S. Peter satisfied them, or silenced them by a plain and sincere recital of his vision, and of what happened at the house of Cornelius. Wi.

Ver. 18. They held their peace, and glorified God, that the gate of salvation was also opened to the Gentiles. Wi.

Ver. 20. Some of them, at Antioch, spoke also to the Grecians:[1] by which many understand, to the Gentiles, though in most Greek copies we read, to the Hellenists. Wi.

Ver. 24. Multitude was added, as before, (c. x.) a few were added to the visible Church. Ever since Christ's ascension, this Church has been notoriously seen.

Of her ministers, their preaching has been open, their sacraments visible, their discipline visible, their persecutions visible, their wonderful increase visible, and their manifestly divine protection visible, and known to all the world.

Whilst all that have separated themselves by schism from this venerable body, have fallen into discredit, and most into complete oblivion. The Catholic Church was the first, and it will be the last.

Ver. 25. To seek Saul, who had retired for a while, to his native city, Tarsus.

These two remained at Antioch about a year, during which time they reaped a plentiful harvest.

Ver. 26. At Antioch the disciples were first named Christians, when S. Paul and S. Barnabas were preaching there. Before that, they were called the disciples of Jesus, and sometimes Nazarenes, (see Acts xxiv. 5.) or perhaps Galileans.

This honourable name of Christians, distinguished them from Gentiles and Jews, and from all heretical sects, who generally had some name from the authors of such sects, as Simonites, Cerinthians, Nicolaites, &c. Of which see S. Epiphanius. The faithful had also after some time the name of Catholics, being taught in the apostles' creed to believe in the Catholic Church. And S.

Augustin, in several places, takes notice, that no heretics could ever get themselves called by this name; nor can they to this present. See S. Aug. de util. credendi. c. viii. de vera relig. c. vii. cont. epis. fundam. c. iv. Whosoever is of the true faith of Christ, may justly say, Christian is my name, Catholic my surname: a greater honour, and a greater advantage, than to be of any royal family. Wi. — The faithful disciples, believers, &c. as before they were called, now received the name of Christians. It is not certain whether they took the name themselves, or it was given them out of disrespect, by the pagans.

Galileans was a term of reproach likewise given to the Christians. S. Peter, in his first epistle, uses the appellation of Christians; but it does not appear that S. Paul ever did in any of his writings. Calmet, Tirinus, &c. — The name of Christian should be common to all the faithful, and all other new names of sectaries abhorred. "If you hear," says S. Jer. any where such as are said to be of Christ, "not to have their name from Christ, but from some other, as Marcionites, Valentinians, (as now also Lutherans, Calvinists, &c. &c. &c. &c.) know that they belong not to the Church of Christ, but to the synagogue of Antichrist." S. Pacianus, in his letter to Sympronian, says, when heresies had arisen, and endeavoured by diverse names to tear the dove of the Lord and Queen in pieces, the faithful required their surname: hence they who before were called Christians, are now surnamed also Catholics.

Christian is my name and Catholic my surname. By this term Catholic, the apostles, in their creed, have distinguished the one true visible Church from all and every other congregation, sect, or party. This mark is so self-evident, that S. Augustin hesitates not to say: "In the lap of the Church the very name Catholic keepeth me." Cont. ep. fund. c. iv. — Again, in his book on the utility of believing, he says: "if after these troubles of mind you still are tossed and vexed, and wish for peace, follow the way of Catholic discipline, which from Christ himself, by the apostles, hath proceeded even unto us, and shall proceed from hence to the latest posterity." 1 Tim. iii. 15.

Ver. 29. Who dwell in Judea. Most of the faithful in Jerusalem, who wished to live perfect lives, had sold their possessions, and placed the price in the hands of the apostles; and many others, who had not voluntarily relinquished their property, had probably lost most of it in the persecutions. Hence arose the particular distress of the brethren in Jerusalem, to relieve which the Gentiles made collections. It was meet, that they who had been made partakers of their spiritual goods, should now in time of need administer to them of their temporal substance. De Dion. Carth. — Imitate the alms of these primitive Christians, and make to yourselves provision against another life. Oh how many are now clothed in silks, and abound in pleasures, but are naked and void of every thing, that will bear examination on the day of judgment! S.

Chrys. hom. xxvi. in Act.

Ver. 30. Sending it to the ancients;[2] elders, &c. In this and diverse other places, are not to be understood such as were elder in age, but such as had offices and dignities, and by divine authority, and who with a due subordination were to govern the Church: so that by this word, were signified apostles, bishops, and priests. But of this more hereafter. Wi. — The ancients or priests, seniors, presbuterous. This is the first place in the New Testament, where priests are mentioned. Some interpreters think, that by this word, ancients, are meant the apostles; but this is not likely. The apostles must at that time have been dispersed over all the world. Others think it was some of the older deacons, who had charge of the alms. We like the opinion of those who think it means priests, subordinate to the apostles, who had the charge of governing the faithful, in their absence. Thus the Christian Church will appear modelled after the form of the synagogue. First, the bishop, who presides, corresponding to the head of the synagogue; the priests, to the ancients, who sat on the right and left of the chief; and the deacons, to the disciples of the Scribes, who studied the law. It must be allowed that many passages occur in Scripture, which it seems necessary to explain of priests of the second rank.

S. Paul, (1 Tim. v. 1. 17. 19.) S. James (v. 14.) orders the priests to be called to anoint the sick man, which cannot be explained of bishops, as there was only one in each town. It must nevertheless be observed, that this same word ancient, or priest, is often used in Scripture, and primitive writings, to designate a bishop. Calmet.

[1] V. 20. Ad Græcos, pros tous ellenistas, and in some MSS. ellenas.

[2] V. 30. Ad seniores, pros tous presbuteros. This Greek word presbuteros, in our Latin Vulg. is sometimes translated presbyter, sometimes senior, sometimes major natu, and is commonly put to signify bishops, or priests, as shall be seen hereafter.

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ACTS 12

CHAPTER XII.

Ver. 1. Herod. Agrippa, made king by the emperor Caius. See Jos. vi. 18. Antiq.

c. viii. and l. xix. c. 5. put to death James the great, brother to John. Wi. — This man was the same as Agrippa, by which name he is most commonly known.

He was brother to the famous Herodias, who was the cause of S. John the Baptist's decollation, (Calmet) and son-in-law of Herod the Great, by his father Aristobulus. V.

Ver. 2. S. James the elder, brother of S. John, the evangelist.

Ver. 3. The days of the azymes. By this we may know about the time when S.

James was executed. Peter was to be reserved till after the Pasch, because it was not usual for the Jews to put any one to a violent death on a festival day.

They would not damp the joy of the solemnity by such actions. Menoch.
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Nothing can be more illiberal, nothing more unfounded, and unjust, than the accusation advanced by the translators of the Bible dedicated to King James.

In their preface they say, that the Catholics keep the words, azymes, holocaust, pasch, &c. in their version, purposely "to darken the sense, that since they must needs translate the Bible, yet by the language thereof, it may be kept from being understood." See the splendid Oxford edit. an. 1770. — So far from this, we open the window, to let in the light; we break the shell, that the kernel may be eaten: we put aside the curtain, that a sight may be had into the holy place; we remove the cover of the well, that the good and humble may get to the water of life.

If we retain certain words in the original tongue, it is for the same reason as our adversaries retain others, such as Amen, Sabaoth, Alleluia, Jehova, &c.

Ver. 4. To four files of soldiers.[1] To four times four soldiers, or to sixteen soldiers, each band or file consisting of four.

Ver. 6. With these two chains, according to the Roman custom, S. Peter must have been fastened to the two soldiers, that guarded him. Yet Peter slept secure, trusting in that Providence which sleepeth not.

Ver. 7. An Angel. This was probably his Angel guardian. It has always been the constant belief of the Church, that each individual is put under the protection of a tutelar Angel. A. — S. Bernard, on these words of the psalm, he has given his Angels charge over thee, thus expresses himself: Wonderful condescension! and truly great love! He has given his Angels charge over thee, to guard thee in all thy ways. What is man, O God, that thou shouldst thus be mindful of him, or the son of man, that thou shouldst look upon him!

What reverence, devotion, and confidence, should this word inspire in us!

Reverence their presence, be grateful for their good will; have confidence in their protection; walk with circumspection; your Angel is present. In every abode, in every place, respect his presence. Let us love them too, destined to be in future our co-heirs; in the mean time, our guardians and patrons. What have we to fear under such guides? They cannot be overcome nor seduced; much less can they lead us astray. They are faithful, they are prudent, they are powerful. Why do we fear? Let us follow them; let us stick close to them; and we shall dwell under the protection of the God of heaven. If a grievous temptation urges; if great tribulation hangs over you; call upon your leader your helper in opportunities, in tribulations; call upon him, and say, save us, or we perish, &c. S. Bern. Serm. in Psalm. Qui. habitat. — A light shined in the room. To Peter only; not to the rest. Wi.

Ver. 11. Peter coming to himself. Being now sensible that all was true. Wi.

Ver. 12. And considering or reflecting, what was best to be done. Wi.

Ver. 15. Thou art mad, or talkest idly. — Then said they, it is his Angel. It seems ridiculous to translate here a messenger. Does a messenger speak with the very voice of him that sends him? S. Chrys.[2] and others on this place observe, that they believed that every one, at least of the faithful, hath a good Angel. Wi. — "If proper Angels," saith S. Chrysostom, (T. iii. hom. 7. in laud.

Paul.) "be deputed by our Lord to such as have only charge of their own existence, (as Israel said, Gen. xlviii. 16. the Angel that delivereth me from all evils, bless these boys) much more are super-human spirits at hand to help those unto whom the charge and burden of the world is committed." Such persons as can believe that God permits evil spirits to tempt us, can find no difficulty surely in believing that the same good, just, and merciful Creator will permit good spirits to guide, protect, and assist us. Repeated proofs of both are found in holy writ. The learned Protestant commentator, Polus, on this text, says: *Hujusmodi visis assueverat eo tempore Ecclesia, quæ etiam novit fideles præsidio angelorum esse circumseptos.* The Church at that period had been accustomed to similar apparitions, nor is she ignorant that the faithful are secured by the protection of Angels. T. iv. p. 1494.

Ver. 17. He went into another place. Did not think fit to stay in the city of Jerusalem. S. Chrys. takes notice, that upon another occasion, when he was delivered by an Angel out of prison, he went boldly the next day, and preached in the temple. c. v. 19. but there he was ordered by an Angel so to do; now to stay without such orders, would have been rashly to expose himself, and in a manner tempting God. Wi. — Peter retired to another place, that he might not rashly expose himself to future danger. It is not just to depend on supernatural assistance, when human means are adequate to the effect. S. Chrys. hom.

xxvi. — S. Peter desires they will announce his miraculous deliverance to James, the then bishop of Jerusalem, and to the Christians, that they

might see the effect of their prayers for him. S. James had, beyond a doubt, ordered general supplications to be made by all the brethren for S. Peter. B.

Ver. 19. Should be led[3] away to punishment or death, according to the sense both of the Latin and Greek text. Wi.

Ver. 20. In the Greek, he was preparing to make war against them. These applied not to agriculture, but drew their support from Judea, Samaria, and Galilee. V.

Ver. 23. Struck him. Josephus relates, that when Herod saw he must die, he replied to the flatteries of the people, "See, he whom you call a god, is snatched out of life, in spite of himself. The necessity of suffering death proves the falsity of your words; but we must submit to the will of God."

Antiquit. lib. xvii. c. 9. et de Bello. lib. i. c. 21. — Princes may take warning from this example, not to take delight in the praises and flatteries of their subjects, so as to forget themselves to be men, and the God of heaven to be the supreme Lord of all, to whose just tribunal princes and subjects are equally amenable. A. — Eaten up by worms. A visible judgment of God, for his pride and vanity. Wi.

Ver. 25. Returned from Jerusalem, to Antioch, the capital of Syria. Wi. — This John Mark, the companion of SS. Paul and Barnabas, was not the evangelist who bore that name; but a cousin of Barnabas, son of Mary, in whose house the apostles generally assembled at Jerusalem. Calmet.

[1] V. 4. Quatuor quaternionibus, tessarsi tetradiois stratioton.

[2] V. 15. It is his Angel. S. Chrys. on these words, hom. xxvi. Ex hoc verum est quod unusquisque Angelum habet; alethes oti ekastos Aggelon echei.

[3] V. 19. Jussit eos duci, apachthenai.

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ACTS 13

CHAPTER XIII.

Ver. 1. Manahen . . . foster-brother to Herod, or nursed with the same milk. Wi.

— It would appear from his having been brought up with Herod, that he was of noble parentage. He is likewise believed to have been one of the seventy-two disciples. The Latins keep his feast on the 24th of May. Calmet.

Ver. 2. As they were ministering to the Lord.[1] Mr. N. and some others translate, offering up sacrifice. There are indeed good grounds to take this to be the true sense, as the Rhemish translators observed, who notwithstanding only put ministering, lest, (said they) we should seem to turn it in favour of our own cause, since neither the Latin nor Greek word signifies of itself to sacrifice, but any public ministry in the service of God; so the S. Chrys. says, when they were preaching. Wi. — Separate me. Though Paul and Barnabas are here chosen by the Holy Ghost for the ministry, yet they were to be ordained, consecrated, and admitted by men; which loudly condemns all those modish and disordered spirits, that challenge and usurp the office of preaching, and other sacred and ecclesiastical functions, without any appointment from the Church. B. — Consider, says S. Chrysostom, by whom they are ordained: by Lucius, of Cyrene, and Manahen, rather than by the Spirit. The less honourable these persons are, the more signal is the grace of God."

Ver. 3. Fasting and prayer, imposing their hands upon them. By which is clearly expressed, the manner in which the ministers of God were, and are still ordained bishops, priests, deacons in the Church. Wi. — Interpreters are much divided in opinion, whether this imposition of hands be a mere deputation to a certain employment, or the sacramental ceremony, by which orders are conferred. SS. Chrysostom, Leo, &c. are of the latter opinion; nor does it any where appear that S. Paul was bishop before this. Arator, sub-deacon of the Church of Rome, who dedicated in the year 544 his version of the Acts of the

Apostles into heroic verse to Pope Virgilius, attributes this imposition of hands to S. Peter:

————Quem mox sacravit euntem

Imposita Petrus ille manu, cui sermo magistri

Omnia posse dedit.————

— See his printed poems in 4to. Venice, an. 1502. Arator was sent in quality of ambassador from Athalaric to the emperor Justinian. — Following the practice of the apostles, the Church of God ordains a solemn and general fast on the four public times for ordination, the ember days, as a necessary preparation for so great a work, and this S. Leo calls also an apostolical tradition. See S.

Leo, serm. ix. de jejun. and ep. lxxxi. c. 1. and serm. iii. and iv. de jejun. 7.

mensis.— Nor was this fasting a fasting from sin, as some ridiculously affirm, for such fasting was a universal obligation: nor was it left to each one's discretion, as certain heretics maintained. Vide S. Aug. hæres. liii.

Ver. 5. In the synagogues of the Jews, preaching first the gospel to them. Wi.

Ver. 6. A magician . . . whose name was Bar-jesu, son of Jesus, or Josue. In Arabic, Elymas is the same as magician. This man did all he could to dissuade the proconsul, Sergius Paulus, from embracing the Christian faith. Wi. —

Salamina was the capital of the island of Cyprus, and at the eastern extremity, as Paphos was at the western. A. D. 45.

Ver. 9. Then Saul, who also is Paul. This is the first time we find the apostle called Paul. Some, therefore, think it was given him when he converted this proconsul, Sergius Paulus. Others, that Saul being a

Hebrew word, the Greeks, or rather the Romans, turned it into Paul. Wi. — This is the first place in which this apostle is called Paul. He took this name out of respect to the illustrious convert he had made in the person of the proconsul, the governor of the island. Menochius. — Or, more probably, his former name, by a small change, was modelled into Paulus, which was a sound more adapted to a Roman ear.

He begins to bear this name only, when he enters on his mission to the Gentiles. Calmet.

Ver. 10. Son of the devil. Sharp language, when grounded on truth, may be used against those who hinder the conversion of others. S. Chrys. says, he was struck with this blindness only for a time, to make him enter into himself, and be converted. Wi.

Ver. 14. Antioch. Many cities in Asia Minor bore this name. It is related that Seleucus Nicanor built many, and called them by this name, in honour of his father Antiochus. Tirinus. — Pamphylia and Pisidia were two provinces in Asia Minor. — The sabbath-day. Some not only understand, but even translate, the first day of the week: but here is rather meant the Jewish sabbath, as S. Paul went into their synagogues. And in this his first sermon to them, which S. Luke has set down, he speaks nothing that could offend or exasperate the Jews, but honourably of them, to gain them to the Christian faith; he commends in particular David, whose Son they knew the Messiah was to be: and of whom he tells them, that God had given them their Saviour, Jesus. He mentions this high eulogium, which God gave of David, Ps. lxxxviii. 21. that he was a man according to God's heart, who in all things should fulfil his will, that is, as to the true worship of God; though he fell into some sins, of which he repented, and did penance. Wi.

Ver. 19. These seven nations are the Chanaanites, the Hethites, the Hevites, the Pherezites, the Gergesites, the Jebusites, and the Amorrhites. Jos. iii. 10. and alibi.

Ver. 20. Chronology only gives about 350 years from the entrance into the land of promise to the end of Samuel's judicial government, who was the last of the judges. V.

Ver. 24, &c. He then brings the testimony, which John the Baptist gave of Jesus, as it is likely many of them had heard of John, and of the great esteem that all the people had of his virtue and sanctity. He tells them that salvation was offered and sent them by Jesus, against whom the chief of the Jews at Jerusalem obtained of Pilate a sentence, that he should be crucified; but that God raised him up from the dead the third day. And we, says he, publish to you this promise, the Messias, promised to our forefathers.

Ver. 33. He then shews them that Jesus was their Messias, and the Son of God, begotten of his Father from eternity, who rose from the dead, and he applies these words, (Ps. ii. 7.) to prove Christ's resurrection, thou art my son, this day have I begotten thee. It is true, these words regard chiefly the eternal generation of Christ, as they are applied by S. Paul, (Heb. v. 5.) but the resurrection was a necessary consequence of his divinity, since death could have no power over him. S. Paul here also proves Christ's resurrection by the following predictions. **Wi.** — Second psalm. The oldest copy reads, first psalm.

The difference is merely in words; for the division of the psalter at present is very different from what it formerly was: sometimes a single psalm of ours being divided into many, and many of our divisions making only one, according to the Hebrews. The latter are not even now agreed among themselves on the same division of the psalms. **Calmet.** — Some suppose, that what we call the first psalm was originally looked upon as a preface to the psalter; others, that our first and second psalms united in one. **Mat. Polus.**

Ver. 34. I will give you the holy things of David sure. These are the words of the prophet Isaias, lv. v. 3. According to the Sept. the sense is, I will faithfully fulfil the promises I made to David. **Ch.**

Ver. 35. In another place also he saith, (Ps. xv. 10.) thou wilt not suffer thy holy one to see corruption. That is, Christ's body to be corrupted in the grave. See the words of S. Peter, Acts c. ii. 27. **Wi.**

Ver. 36. After he had served in his generation. That is, in his life-time, saw corruption, or was corrupted in the grave. **Wi.**

Ver. 37-38. Justified. That your sins being forgiven by the merits of Christ, you may be truly just in the sight of God. Wi.

Ver. 39. The law of Moses was then imperfect. I shew you its completion, by preaching to you Christ, whom it foretold. You would violate the law of Moses by opposing the new law, to which he leads you. Tirinus.

Ver. 40. See then that you reject not this divine Saviour, lest what has been denounced by the prophets fall upon your incredulous heads: I will abandon the holy place which I entrusted to you; I will cease to look upon you as my people; I will transfer my kingdom to the Gentiles. V.

Ver. 41. Ye despisers[2] of the favours offered you, behold, wonder, &c. This citation is out of Habacuc, (c. i. v. 5.) according to the Sept. The prophet, by these words, foretold to the Jews in his time the evils that would come upon them in their captivity in Chaldea, but S. Paul here applies them at least to the miseries that the incredulous Jews would incur, if they obstinately refused to believe in Christ. Wi.

Ver. 44. The whole city. Not only Jews, but a great many Gentiles, which exasperated the envious Jews. Wi.

Ver. 48. As many as were pre-ordained to eternal life,[3] by the free election, and special mercies, and providence of God. Wi. — Some understand this as if it meant, predisposed by their docility, to receive the word of life. But the Fathers unanimously understand it literally of predestination, which is defined by S. Thomas, serm. i. qu. 23. a. 1. "The disposition of God, by which he prepares, what he will himself perform, according to his infallible foreknowledge." In other words, it is the manner in which God conducts a reasonable creature to its proper destiny, which is eternal life. In this mystery of the Catholic faith, which cannot be clearly explained to human understanding, because it is a mystery, there are nevertheless several points, which we know for certain. 1st. Though it is certain, that this decree of the Almighty is infallible, and must have its effect, yet it is far removed from the blasphemy of Calvinists, who pretend that it destroys free-

will, and therefore removes all motives of exertion to good works. 2d. For it is a point of Catholic faith, that this foreknowledge of the Almighty no ways interferes with man's liberty, but leaves him still a perfectly free agent, and therefore responsible for his actions. 3d. It is likewise decreed by the Council of Trent, that no one can certainly know that he is of the number of the predestined, without a special revelation to that effect. These are the most essential points, which it concerns us to know of this doctrine. As to the consequences which may be drawn from these positions, it were better for us to submit our understandings to the obedience of faith, than entangle ourselves in a maze of abstruse errors, far removed from our comprehension. Would that this sober line of conduct were pursued by many moderns, who at present talk and write so much on this subject, and to such little purpose. How excellently well does the great genius of the Latin Church, S. Augustin, say: *Melius est dubitare de occultis, quam litigare de occultis!* How much wiser and better is it to confess our ignorance on mysteries, than idly to dispute on mysteries! l. viii. de Gen. ad litt. c. 5.

Ver. 51. Shaking off the dust, &c. See the Annotations, Matt. x. 14.

[1] V. 2. Ministrantibus illis, leitourgounton de auton. Erasmus translates, Sacrificantibus, but St. Chrysostom, toutesti keruttonton, prædicantibus.

[2] V. 41. Habac. i. 5. In the Latin text, and according to the Hebrew, aspice in Gentibus: but in the Sept. and Greek here, idete kataphronetai.

[3] V. 48. Præordinati, tetagmenoi, on which S. Chrys. says, toutesti aphorismenoi, prædefiniti.

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ACTS 14

CHAPTER XIV.

Ver. 1. And of the Greeks. Which is here put for the Gentiles. Wi.

Ver. 2. The unbelieving Jews stirred up, &c. It would hence appear, that the former were not very scrupulous in the means they took to oppose the gospel.

They, who would have been dreadfully scandalized to have spoken to a Gentile for any good purpose, are not very nice in having intercourse with them to irritate them against the apostles. Such is the general conduct of men whose religion is vain. That sacred name is used for a pretext to authorize the most unwarrantable actions. A.

Ver. 3. To the word of his grace. That is, of the gospel, and the law of grace. Wi.

Ver. 8. Perceiving that he had. It does not appear that S. Paul had any previous conversation with the man he healed on this occasion, or demanded from him any testimony of his faith. But he saw that he had faith, perhaps by inspiration, or by the confidence and eagerness the lame man may have shewn in his countenance and actions. Calmet, &c.

Ver. 11. And they called Barnabas, Jupiter. Perhaps because he was of taller and finer stature; for, according to Nicephorus (hist. ii. 37.) S. Paul was very low in size, and much bent; hence S. Chrysostom says of him, tricubitalis est,

& cœlos transcendit, though not more than three cubits high, he yet transcends the heavens, and hence for his eloquence, he was called Mercury.

Jupiter was said to take Mercury with him, as may be seen in Amphitryone Plauti.

Ver. 12. Garlands. These might be for the victims, as they generally were crowned, or had gilded horns.

Victima labe carens, præstantissima forma,

Sistitur ante aras, vittis præsignis et auro.—Ovid.

— Or they might be for the two pretended gods, as it was usual to crown their statues. Pliny, lib. xvi. c. 4. — The priests likewise themselves, who sacrificed, wore crowns. Virgil. Æneid ii.

Ver. 14. We also are mortals. The enraptured people wished to pay divine homage, thoein, to the apostles, and therefore they indignantly reject the proffered honours. The Catholic Church has but one external sacrifice, and this she offereth to God only, and "neither to Peter nor to Paul, saith S.

Augustin, though the priest that sacrificeth, standeth over their bodies, and offereth in their memories." l. viii. de Civit. Dei. c. 27.

Ver. 15. Suffered all nations to walk in their own way. Lit. dismissed all nations, suffering them to run on in their idolatry, and other sins, not favouring them with a written law, as he did the Jews, &c. Wi.

Ver. 16. He left not himself without testimony. Inasmuch as the Gentiles had always the light of reason, and such lights, that by the created things of this world, and from the visible effects of God's providence, they might have come to the knowledge of the true God, the creator of all things. See Rom. c. i. Wi. —

God did not leave himself without testimony among the Gentiles. He did not leave them without the means of discovering the way which led to him. They had the law of nature engraved in their hearts, the knowledge of good and evil,

&c. Menochius. — Therefore they were inexcusable, if they did not know him.

The invisible things of God, his eternal divinity might have been known to them from the consideration of the visible creation. Rom. i. 20.

Ver. 21. Through many tribulations. Our daily offences require the paternal chastisement of the Almighty. The concupiscence of the flesh too, which wills against the spirit, must be subdued by punishment. Wo then to you, lovers of this world, who wish to pass your lives without tribulation, enemies of the cross. Senseless creatures, is the disciple above his master? Did it not become Christ first to suffer, and thus to enter into his glory? and shall we pretend to enter by any other means? &c. H. Denis. Carthus.

Ver. 22. When they had ordained for them priests.[1] The Prot. translation, following the grammatical etymology of the Greek word presbyter, always puts elders. Yet they of the Church of England allow, and maintain, that by this Greek word in this, and many other places, are signified the ministers of God, known by the name of bishops or priests, according to the ecclesiastical use of the same word. It is evident that here are not meant elders, as to age and years. Nay, though we adhere to the grammatical signification, we should rather translate priests, since the English word priest, as well as the French word prêtre, come from presbyter. But of this word more hereafter. We may also take notice, that the Calvinists here translate, ordained by election, pretending by the derivation of the Greek word, that church ministers were only chosen, and deputed by the votes and suffrages of people; and not by any ordination, or consecration by a bishop; nor by any character or sacrament of order. But their argument from this Greek word is frivolous, and groundless, as hath been shewn by Mr. Bois on this verse, by Mr. Legh in his Critica Sacra, &c. Wi. — We see from this text, 1st, that SS. Paul and Barnabas were bishops, having authority to confer holy orders: 2d. that there was even then a difference betwixt bishops and priests, though the name in the primitive Church was often used indifferently; 3d. that fasting and praying were constant preparatives for holy orders. B.

Ver. 24. This Antioch was a sea-port in Pamphylia. V.

Ver. 25. From whence they had been delivered, up to their ministry, and their apostolical mission by the grace of God; that is, where they had been first chosen by the direction of the Spirit of God, ordained priests

and bishops, and had received power, and graces to discharge their offices of apostles. Wi.

Ver. 27. No little time. It is not precisely known how long he remained there, nor what he did. S. Luke relates nothing of what happened from the 46th year of Christ to the 51st, in which the Council of Jerusalem was held. It is probable S. Paul spent that time carrying the gospel among the neighbouring provinces.

Calmet.

**[1] V. 22. Cum constituissent presbyteros, cheirotonesantes
presbuterous. Mr.**

**Bois on this verse: Si usum loquendi potius quam syllabas ipsas, quibus
inhærere sæpè parum tutum est, respicias, cheirotonein, nihil aliud
declarat, quam constituere, creare, ordinare. See Mr. Legh, in thesauro
linguæ græcæ.**

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ACTS 15

CHAPTER XV.

Ver. 1. Unless you be circumcised. Many who had been converted from Judaism, held that none, not even converted from paganism, could be saved, unless they were circumcised, and observed the other ceremonies of the law of Moses. Wi. — See Gal. v. 2.

Ver. 2. To the apostles and priests,[1] where we find again presbyters in Greek, meaning bishops and priests. Wi. — Paul . . . should go to . . . Jerusalem. We learn from Gal. ii. 2. 4. that S. Paul undertook this journey in consequence of a divine revelation, and was accompanied by Barnabas and Titus, the latter of whom he would not suffer to be circumcised. Such confidence had he in the rectitude of the opinion he defended. From the example of S. Paul and S.

Barnabas, apostles, and men full of the Spirit of God, we learn, that as often as any contest arises about faith, recourse should be had to the supreme visible authority established by Jesus Christ, to have all differences adjusted. This is the order of divine Providence with regard to the Church; without it truth and unity could not be preserved; without it, the Church of God would be more defective and inefficient than any human government. Tell the Church: and if he will not hear the Church, let him be to thee as the heathen and the publican.

Matt. xviii. 17.

Ver. 7. Former days. Lit. in the days of old; that is, at the conversion of Cornelius, many years ago, about the year 35; and it was now 51. Wi. — S.

Peter at the head of the Council, spoke first; S. James as Bishop of Jerusalem, spoke next, and all, as S. Jerom says, came into the sentence of Peter. Ep.

lxxxix. ad S. Aug. c. 2.

Ver. 10. Why tempt you God, by calling in question what he hath sufficiently attested, and approved, and by being incredulous to his promises of giving salvation to the Gentiles, and to all nations. Wi.

Ver. 11. In the historical sense he is speaking of the prosperity of the house of Juda, in the reign of Ezechias, or their return from captivity. But in this respect, it is certain that the prophecy never had its entire accomplishment. The passage in the text is cited from the Septuagint. The Hebrew is, "I will raise up the house of David . . . that it may possess all the nations," &c. Now it is true that the nations never were subject to the house of David, or known by the name of the people of God; but by their vocation to the gospel, as S. James explains it. Calmet.

Ver. 18. To the Lord was known his own work. He bringeth it to pass, as he hath decreed, though his decrees are to us unknown. Wi.

Ver. 19. Wherefore I judge, and join my judgment with Peter. S. Chrys. thinks that James had a special authority in the Council, as bishop of Jerusalem, and because of the great veneration, which those zealous for the Jewish law had for him: but his power was certainly inferior to that of S. Peter, who was head of all, as S. Chrys. teacheth, hom. iii. on the Acts.

Ver. 20. Things strangled and from blood. In these prohibitions, the Church indulged the particular feelings of the Jews, that the bond of union between them and the Gentiles might be more closely united; the latter in these two instances giving way to the prejudices of the former, who in their turn gave up much, by submitting to the abolition of the ceremonial law of Moses. This prohibition was of course only temporary, and to cease with the reasons, which gave rise to it. Menochius. — The Jews had such a horror of blood, that they considered those who eat it as defiled, and violators of the law of nature.

The Lord had in effect from the beginning forbidden the use of blood to Noe, (Gen. ix. 4.) which he likewise reported in the strongest terms in Leviticus viii.

26. By this we see the great authority of God's Church, and Councils which may make permanent or temporary decrees, such as are fitting for the state of the times or peoples, without any express Scripture at all, and by this authoritative exaction, things become of strict obligation, which previous to it, were in themselves indifferent. B.

Ver. 21. For Moses . . . hath in every city. Not only the Jews, but the Christians converted from Judaism, still followed the ceremonies of the law of Moses. Wi.

— Let not the Jews complain, that we abandon Moses, and destroy the law by this regulation. No: it shall subsist for ever in a more perfect state, read in the synagogue, and revered by the Church. Calmet. — Others give a different explanation of this verse. Let the Jews, say they, follow Moses, and hear him in their assemblies; we have other laws, and enjoy other privileges. Tirinus.

Ver. 23. The brethren of the Gentiles. Hence we see, that the letter, with the decree of the Council, only regarded those converts, who had been Gentiles; neither are they forbidden to use the Jewish ceremonies, but a declaration is made, that they have no obligation to follow the said ceremonies and precepts, as it will appear by other places. Wi.

Ver. 24. Some who went out from us, from Jerusalem, and pretended to speak our mind, and in our name, but we gave them no such commission. **Wi.** — A proper description of heretics, schismatics, and seditious preachers, who go out from their own superiors, and pretend to teach and preach without any mission, *et quomodo prædicabunt nisi mittantur*; how can they preach, unless they are sent? **Rom. x. 15.**

Ver. 28. It hath seemed good to the Holy Ghost, and to us. To us in these matters, wherein by the promises of Christ, we are directed by the Holy Ghost, the spirit of truth, &c. — Than these necessary things. Necessary at this juncture, and always, if we except that order of abstaining from blood, and things strangled, which was not a perpetual, unchangeable precept, but to last only for a time, as **S. Chrys.** observes. **Wi.** — This is the first general council held in the Church, and the model of all succeeding ones. In it the apostles, in a commanding and authoritative manner, laid down the law, which was to be the guide of the faithful, knowing they had a right to impose any regulations in the Church, and that they could not employ this authority but to good purposes, directed as they were by the unerring spirit of truth, which Christ had promised (**Matt. xxviii. 20.**) should remain with his Church for ever. Hence it would appear that we have no more ground refusing obedience to the voice of the Church at present, than at her first establishment: and that those who will not hear the Church now, speaking in her Councils, would with as little ceremony have opposed the apostles on this occasion, had they lived at the time. By what spirit of seduction has been introduced, and spread, to such an alarming extent, the opinion, that Christianity (the very leading feature of which is to hear and to obey) authorizes unrestricted liberty? Is then authority an unmeaning word? **A.**

Ver. 29. From blood, and from things strangled. The use of these things, though of their own nature indifferent, were here prohibited, to bring the Jews more easily to admit of the society of the Gentiles; and to exercise the latter in obedience. But this prohibition was but temporary, and has long since ceased to oblige; more especially in the western churches. **Ch.** — See note on v. 20.

supra.

Ver. 31. We may here briefly remark, that the controversy was finally adjusted by the decree of the Council. 2dly, That all, not only the Gentiles, but the abettors and masters of the former dissension, experienced great consolation in the promulgation of the decision, receiving it as the resolve not of mere mortal men, but of the Holy Ghost. It hath seemed good to the Holy Ghost and to us.

Ver. 32. Judas and Silas, being prophets, that is, preachers, as the word prophet, is divers times taken. Wi. — Not only such were called prophets, as had the gift of predicting future events, but such moreover as had the gift of interpreting Scripture, and of speaking of the things of God. V.

Ver. 39. There was a dissension,[2] or dispute, with reasoning, and arguing upon the matter. S. Paul represented to S. Barnabas, that he was not for having John Mark to be their companion, because he had before left them, but S. Barnabas was for having with them his kinsman Mark; and the dispute was such, that upon it S. Paul and Barnabas separated; which gave occasion to the preaching of the gospel in more places. See S. Chrys. hom. xxxiii. — The fault in this contention lay with S. Barnabas; ο Paulos to dikaion, ο Barnabas to philanthropon: Paul sought what was just; Barnabas what was pleasing to nature. The Greeks, moreover, remark, that this severity of Paul was of service in strengthening the too pliant character of Mark, and as such he is saluted by Paul. Col. iv. 10. They separated, as formerly Abraham and Lot, without prejudice to their friendship. Gen. xiii. 9. Mat. Polus synop. criticorum, fol. 4. p.

1528.

[1] V. 2. presbuterous; presbyteros. For the same Greek word we sometimes find in the vulgar Latin, presbyteros, sometimes seniores, sometimes majores natu: yet it is generally a word of dignity in the ministry of Christ, signifying those who were afterwards known by the name of bishops or priests. When mention is made of presbuteros, or seniores, of the old law, I have translated elders: but where the ministers of the new law are understood, when in the Latin we have presbyteri, I have put priests; when majores natu or seniores, I have put in English seniors, bishops or priests, being to be understood.

[2] V. 39. Dissentio, paroxusmos, acris disceptatio. See. S. Chrys.

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ACTS 16

CHAPTER XVI.

Ver. 3. Circumcised him. Not to obstruct the conversion of the Jews; and because it was still lawful to observe the Jewish ceremonies, though the obligation of keeping the old law had ceased. Wi. — This S. Paul did in order to gain the Jews, and make Timothy acceptable to them. Tirinus. — To the Jew, says he, (1 Cor. ix. 20.) I became a Jew, that I might gain the Jews. If he refused to circumcise Titus, in order to vindicate the Christian's independence of the Mosaic ceremonies; he now submits to the observance of them, to shew there is nothing of itself bad in them, and that they might without crime be practised, till time by degrees had abolished them. S. Aug. ep. lxxxii. ad S. Hieronymum.

Ver. 4. Here, as well as in the last verse of the former chapter, we see S. Paul ordering the new converts, wherever he went, to receive, as their rule of conduct, the ordinances of the apostles and priests assembled in Jerusalem.

Ver. 6. They were forbidden by the Holy Ghost, to go, and preach at that time in the Lesser Asia, perhaps because their preaching in Macedonia was more necessary; or because S. John was to be sent into Asia. Wi. — Forbidden.

Why? Because they were not yet prepared to receive the gospel; or, perhaps, these provinces were reserved for S. John, as Bithynia was for S. Luke.

Menochius. — S. Leo compares this question to many others respecting the inscrutable judgments of God. Why did not the Son of God come into the world many ages before? Why did he suffer so many to die in ignorance? Why are there yet so many in infidelity? Why, in one family, does one believe and is converted, while another remains in darkness, and crime? Who shall account for the exercise he pleases to make of his rigour, or his mercy, when all were justly victims of the former? S. Leo de vocat. Gentium. lib. ii. c. 2.

Ver. 7. The spirit of Jesus permitted them not. It is the same spirit, which just before was called the Holy Ghost: for the Holy Ghost is the spirit of Jesus, as proceeding from the Son as well as from the Father. Wi.

Ver. 9. A vision, &c. The tutelar angel of the province, according to most interpreters, under the form of a Macedonian, who implored S. Paul in behalf of the province he guarded.

Ver. 10. We. This change in the narration from the third, to the first person, we sought, &c. is remarkable. It is hence inferred, that S. Luke, the author of this book, joined S. Paul at Troas, and became his inseparable companion. Calmet.

— It is, however, probable, that as the narrative in the first person changes again at the end of this chapter, and is not resumed, till the fifth verse of the 20th chap. that S. Luke was absent on some mission during the time that elapsed between this and their sailing from Philippi, as mentioned hereafter.

Chap. xx. v. 6. Tirinus.

Ver. 13. There was prayer.[1] The Greek word signifies either prayer itself, or an oratory, or place to pray in. Wi. — Not every prayer is here understood, but that which was joined in the celebration of the sacred mysteries. Estius in diffic.

loca. See 1 Cor. vii. and Acts vi.

Ver. 16. A pythonical spirit. A spirit pretending to divination, to tell secrets, and things to come. See 2 Kings xxviii. Isaias viii. 19. Wi. — A divining spirit, which pretended to foretell things to come. It is strictly forbidden every where throughout the old law to have any dealings with persons of this description.

Deut. xviii. 10. Levit. xx. ult. &c. Hence it would appear that these superstitions were of early practice among mankind. It is lamentable that the present age is still credulous enough to believe in such impostures. The ignorance of mankind, it appears, has always been made a source of emolument to the designing. A.

Ver. 17. These men are the servants of the most high God. Evil spirits in possessed people, are sometimes forced to tell the truth. Wi.

Ver. 18. Observe here that the servants of God have a power granted them of controlling wicked spirits, according to the promise of our Lord, Luke ix. and x. Hence the seventy disciples, returning, said: Lord, even the devils are subject to us in thy name. Est. in diffic. loc.

Ver. 20. Jews. This was the name the first Christians went by among the pagans. Indeed our Saviour's being born of that nation, and his disciples adoring the same God, and following the same morality and Scriptures as the Jews, were sufficient reasons to make them confounded. When Suetonius relates that Claudius banished the Jews from Rome, he means the Christians.

Calmet.

Ver. 21. There was a standing decree of the senate, which forbade the introduction of any new divinity, without the formal consent of the senate. V.

Ver. 24. Made their feet fast in the stocks. By the Latin and Greek text, they made them fast with wood. Wi.

Ver. 26. All the doors were opened. This made the jailer conclude the prisoners had made their escape. And he being answerable for them, and expecting to be put to death, was for stabbing himself. Wi.

Ver. 33. Was baptized, being first told what he was to believe, and do. Wi. —

Hence Catholics draw a very plausible argument for the baptism of infants, as it is very probable there were some infants in the family. See Estius in diffic.

loc.

Ver. 35. Sent the serjeants,[2] vergers, or such like officers. Wi.

Ver. 37. Romans. S. Paul inherited his right of citizenship from his father; it does not appear how Silas obtained it, perhaps by purchase. There is no proof that Silas was a freeman of Rome. D. Dion. Carthus. — It was forbidden by the Porcian and Sempronian laws, for a Roman citizen to be scourged, unless he was likewise convicted of a capital crime. Cicero pro Rabirio. Facinus est vinciri civem Romanum: scelus verberari. Id. cont. Verrem. The Romans were always very jealous of the dignity of their city. We cannot but admire S. Paul's astonishing desire of suffering for the name of Jesus, in concealing a circumstance, the very naming of which would have saved him the cruel scourging he suffered. If he now refuses to go out of the prison privately, it is to vindicate his honour, and to avert the scandal, which the new converts would naturally feel, in seeing their master treated as a criminal. He exemplified in this instance S. Augustin's principal; "Our lives are necessary for ourselves, but our reputation for others." A. — Estius declares, that Silas was also a Roman citizen, and that from this circumstance he probably received a Roman name, as Paul did. For in other parts of Scripture we find him styled Silvanus, (2 Cor. i. 19.) and at the commencement of both the epistles to the Thessalonians. — Not so; but let them come, &c. S. Paul patiently submitted himself to be whipped in a most disgraceful and cruel manner, which he could easily have prevented or put a stop to, by saying, I am a Roman citizen. Afterwards, when they were for setting him at liberty, he claims his privilege, he puts all the magistrates in a fright; they run to ask him pardon, and entreat him with all civility to leave the town, which he does not think fit to do, till he visited his brethren and friends. Wi.

[1] V. 13. Oratio, proseuche, preces, oratio & Oratorium.

[2] V. 35. Lictores, rabduchous, vergers, rod-bearers.

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ACTS 17

CHAPTER XVII.

Ver. 2. It was customary with S. Paul to open the Scriptures first to the Jews, (Acts xiii. 46.) and to argue with them from the law and the prophets. Acts xxviii. 23. S. Paul made use of the same passages of Scripture to convince the Jews, as Jesus Christ did on a similar occasion. Mat. Polus.

Ver. 3. That the Christ was to suffer. The suffering of Christ was the great stumbling-block to the Jews, which S. Paul now attempted to remove, by shewing them from the Scripture, that this was one of the necessary characters of the Messias, contained in the prophets. All the other marks were likewise accomplished in Christ. D. Dion. Carth. — And that this is Jesus Christ, whom I preach to you. The transition from an oblique to a direct mode of speech is very common, especially in the holy Scriptures.

Ver. 4. And some of them, that is, of the Jews, in whose synagogue he preached, believed, and of those that^[1] worshipped God, that is, of those who adored the only true God, though they had not submitted themselves to circumcision, and to the ceremonies of the Jewish law, and of the Gentiles, that is, of such as till that time had been heathens, and idolaters; so that here three sorts of persons were converted by S. Paul: 1. Jews; 2. worshippers of the true God that were not Jews; and 3. Gentiles. In this book of the Acts, mention is several times made of worshippers, to wit, of God, by which many understand Jewish proselytes: but as they neither were Jews already, nor perhaps ever designed to become Jews, we may distinguish two sorts of the Jewish proselytes. Some were proselytes to the Jewish religion, by a submission to circumcision, and to all the precepts and ceremonies of the Mosaic laws. These are also by some called proselytes of the covenant, being as much Jews as they who had been always so. Others are called proselytes of the gate, or proselytes to the God of the Jews, but not to the religion of the Jews. Of such seems to have been Cornelius, the centurion. Acts x. Lydia, Acts xvi. 14. and Titus Justus, Acts xviii. 7. Such also seems to have been the eunuch of Candace, the queen of the

Ethiopians, Acts viii. Naaman, the Syrian, after he was cured of his leprosy, (4 Kings v. 17.) and many others, that lived in Judea, and in other countries. These, therefore, are called worshippers, meaning of the true God, though they embraced not the legal precepts and ceremonies of the Jews. See Monsr. Heure's Dictionary. Wi.

Ver. 6. Who disturb the city,[2] put it in an uproar. In the ordinary Greek copies, for the city, we read the whole world. Wi.

Ver. 7. Another king. These Jews suppress, with great artifice, their true cause of vexation against the apostles, and change a mere question of religion into one of temporal policy. The accusation of raising up a new power in opposition to Cæsar's, had been sufficiently refuted and disavowed before Pilate by the author of our religion, and was therefore too gross to be repeated now. My kingdom, says our blessed Saviour, is not of this world. There is no necessary connection between spiritual and temporal power. It is thus that the abettors of persecution are never at a loss for pretexts, when necessary. Mad zeal is not scrupulously nice in the choice of arguments. A.

Ver. 10. Synagogue. In flying from the face of persecution in due season, S.

Paul imitated the instruction and example of his master. When his labours are unsuccessful in one place, he renews them in another, and wherever he is, his object is always the same, to announce the truth to the Jews first, then to the Gentiles. D. Carthus.

Ver. 11. These were more noble than those of Thessalonica. According to the common exposition, the sense is, that these of Berœa, were of a more noble and generous disposition of mind, not carried away with envy and malice, like those of Thessalonica. — Searching the Scriptures, or those places of the prophets by which S. Paul proved that Jesus was the Messiah, who was to suffer death, &c. Wi. — Daily searching the Scriptures, &c. The sheep are not hereby made judges of their pastors, the people of the priests, and lay men and women of S. Paul's doctrine. The Berœans did not read the Old Testament (and the New was not then published) to dispute with the apostles, or to sanction

his doctrines: but it was a great comfort and confirmation to the Jews that had the Scriptures, to find, even as S. Paul said, that Christ was God, crucified, risen, and ascended to heaven; which by his expounding they understood, and never before, though they read them, and heard them read every sabbath. So it is a great comfort to a Catholic to see in the Scriptures the clear passages that prove the truth of his tenets, and shew the grounds for his hopes. But this by no means authorizes him to be judge of the true pastors of the Church, whom he is commanded by Jesus Christ to hear and obey, and from whom they are to learn the genuine sense of the Scriptures.

Ver. 16. Lactanius ridicules the folly of idolatry in a neat strain of irony, which he introduces by the following verses from Lucilius: *Ut pueri infantes credunt signa omnia athena*

Vivere et esse homines; sic isti omnia ficta

Vera putant, &c.

— The poet compares these fools to children. I think them worse; for the latter only take the statues for men, they for gods. Age causes the error of the one, folly of the other. These soon cease to be deceived, but the folly of those lasts and increases always. Lact. de fals. Relig. lib. i.

Ver. 18. Epicurean and Stoic philosophers. The former of these philosophers held as their doctrine, that the Almighty did not interfere by his providence in the government of the world; that the soul did not subsist after the body; and consequently, that there was no future state of retribution. The latter denied that man had liberty of action, and maintained, that all things happened by destiny and fatal necessity. These were the two opposite sects S. Paul had to contend with. Calmet. — The Stoics believed in the immortality of the soul, and came the nearest to the Christian religion: but both Stoics and Epicureans, with all pagan philosophers, denied the resurrection of bodies; hence S.

Augustin says, the faith of a resurrection is peculiar to Christians. Estius. —

What is it that this babblers[3] would say? A word of contempt, which some translate, this prattler. It is thought to be a metaphor from birds picking up little seeds, or the like, for their food; and to signify, that S. Paul had picked up words and sentences without any solid meaning. Wi.

Ver. 19. To the Areopagus. In this place sat the Athenian judges: but some think that by this word may be here signified, some large hall or court, joining to the Areopagus, where all sorts of people met. Wi. — The Areopagus was the supreme and most famous tribunal of all Greece, before which all great causes were tried. The persons who composed it were much renowned for their wisdom. Cicero, and many other Romans, were ambitious of the honour of being an Areopagite; but the power of Athens being now much diminished, this court had sunk in importance, and was now not much more than the shadow of a great name. Calmet.

Ver. 22. Over-religious.[4] Or very superstitious. To be superstitious, or given to superstition, is commonly taken for a vain and groundless religious worship, but it is also sometimes used in a good sense. And perhaps S. Paul, in the beginning of his speech to so many men of learning, does not so openly blame them for being vainly and foolishly superstitious, but by their inscription, to the unknown[5] God, he takes notice how nice and exact they pretended to be, in not omitting to pay some kind of homage to any god, or gods of all other nations, whom they might not know. For some interpreters think, that by this altar they designed to worship every god of any nation, who was not come to their knowledge: or to worship that great God hinted at in the writings of Plato: or as others conjecture, that God of the Jews, of whom they might have heard such wonders, and whose name the Jews themselves said to be unknown and ineffable. However, from this inscription S. Paul takes an occasion, with wonderful dexterity, with sublime reflections, and with that solid eloquence, of which he was master, and which he employed, as often as it was necessary, to inform them, and instruct them, concerning the works of the one true God, of whom they had little knowledge, by their own fault: that this one true God made the world, and all things in it: that from one man he raised all

mankind: that his presence is not confined to temples made by the hands of men, being every where, and in all creatures, preserving them every moment: that in him we live, move, and have our being, or subsist: that it is he, who hath determined the time, limits, or bounds of every empire, and kingdom, and of every man's life: that this true God, who made, preserves, and governs all things in heaven and on earth, cannot be like to gold, silver, or any thing made by the art, or fancy of men. He puts them in mind that according even to one of their own heathen poets, Aratus, men themselves are the offspring of God, being blessed with a being and knowledge above all other creatures in this world: who by the light of reason ought to seek God, and by considering the visible effects of Providence over the world, and the creatures in it, might come to the knowledge of this one God, the author of all, at least to an imperfect knowledge of him, as men find out things by feeling, or as it were, groping in the dark. He then adds, (v. 30.) that having, as it were, overlooked, and permitted men for many ages to run on in this ignorance and blindness, in punishment of their sins, (this their ignorance of one true God, the author of all things, being wilful and inexcusable) now the same true God hath been pleased to announce to all men, that henceforward they acknowledge, and worship him, that they repent, and do penance for their sins. Wi.

Ver. 23. It may be asked, why they had not implicit faith, worshipping the true, though unknown, God?[5] 1st. because the worship of the true God can never exist with the worship of idols; 2d. because an explicit faith in God is required of all; 3d. because it is repugnant to implicit faith, to admit any thing contrary to it, as comparing this unknown God with the pagan idols; for God to be at all, must be one. Lucan towards the end of his 2d book, hath these words:

———Et dedita sacris

Incerti Judæa Dei.

— What, therefore, you improperly worship, that I preach to you, and instruct you in the true worship, far different from what you pay to your strange gods.

Ver. 24. God . . . dwelleth not in temples. He who is infinite cannot be confined to space; nor stand in need of what human hands can furnish. Temples are not for God, but for man. It is the latter who derives assistance from them. The same may be observed of all exterior acts of worship. They are serviceable, inasmuch as they proceed from, or powerfully assist, interior devotion, by the impressions which exterior objects leave upon the soul. The reciprocal action of one upon the other, in our present state of existence, is great and inevitable.

A. See c. vii. sup. v. 48. — God, indeed, dwelleth in the temple, yes, and in the soul of the just man, but he is not confined there, as the idols were to their temples. Hence the prayer of Solomon at the consecration of the temple: if heaven, and the heaven of heavens cannot contain thy immensity, how much less this house, which I have erected? God dwelleth there, then, to receive the prayers and sacrifices of the faithful, but not as though he needed any thing.

See v. 25. — God is not contained in temples; so as to need them for his dwelling, or any other uses, as the heathens imagined. Yet by his omnipresence, he is both there and every where. Ch.

Ver. 27. Feel after him. Si forte attrectent eum, ei arage pselapheseian. It signifies palpare quasi in tenebris. Wi.

Ver. 28. S. Paul here cites Aratus, a Greek poet, and his own countryman, a native of Cilicia.

Ver. 29. Cherubim, with extended wings, were ordered by God to be made, and placed over the propitiatory; (Exod. xxxvii. 7.) the brazen serpent is declared by Jesus Christ himself to have been a figure of him; therefore to blame the universally received practice of the Catholic Church, with regard to pictures and images, betrays either great prevention, or great ignorance. S. Gregory says: "What writing does for readers, that a picture does for the ignorant; for in it they see what they ought to follow, and in it they read, who know no letters." And he sharply rebukes Serenus's indiscreet zeal for removing pictures, instead of teaching the people what use may be made of them. l. ix.

ep. 9.

Ver. 30. Overlooked. Despiciens, uperidon. It may either signify looking down on the ignorant world, and so taking pity of it; or rather that God having overlooked, and permitted mankind to go on so long in their sins, now invites them to repentance, by sending Jesus, their Saviour and Redeemer. See the Analysis, dissert. xxxiv. Wi.

Ver. 31. Because he hath appointed a day for judging all men with equity, by the man, to wit, Christ Jesus, a man, and also his true Son, whom he has appointed to be their judge; and by raising him (Jesus) from the dead, he hath made it credible, and given sufficient proofs of this truth, that every one shall rise from death. Wi.

Ver. 32. When they heard of the resurrection of the dead. This seemed so impossible, even to the philosophers among them, that some of them presently laughed, and made a jest of it. Others said, we will hear thee on this another time, and some believed. Wi.

Ver. 34. Dionysius the Areopagite. This illustrious convert was made the first bishop of Athens. The martyrologies say, S. Paul raised him to that dignity. It is the same person, who, observing the convulsions of nature, which paid homage, as it were, to its God, expiring upon the cross, and not knowing the cause, is said to have exclaimed: Either the universe is falling to ruin, or the God of nature must be suffering. It appears from his writings, that he was, previous to his conversion, of the Platonic school. Ven. Bede was mistaken in supposing that he was afterwards the bishop of Corinth, of that name, who so successfully employed his pen for the good of the Church. This Dionysius lived a whole century after the Areopagite. Estius.

[1] V. 4. De colentibus Gentilibusque. In the common Greek copies, there is no and, but only of the worshipping Gentiles, ton de sebomenon elleuon, but in other copies, kai ellenon.

[2] V. 6. Qui urbem concitant, in the common Greek copies, oikoumenen, orbem: so that this difference might happen in the Latin, by the change of one letter only of urbem, for orbem: but some Greek MSS. have ten polin, civitatem.

[3] V. 18. Semini-verbius, o spermologos, the critics derive it from legein spermata, colligere semina.

[4] V. 22. Superstitiosiores, deisidaimonosteros, from deido, timeo, and daimon. Deisidaimonia is sometimes taken in a good sense for religio, as also superstitio in Latin. See Budæus, and Plutarch apud Scapulam. See also Suidas.

[5] V. 23. Ignoto Deo, agnosto theo. See Corn. a Lapide.

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ACTS 18

CHAPTER XVIII.

Ver. 3. Critics are divided in their opinions about the nature of S. Paul's employment: but it is generally supposed to be making tents of skins, such as were formerly used by travellers and soldiers. Tirinus. — Hence the expression, *esse sub pellibus*. The apostle submitted to this labour, that he might be no burden to those to whom he preached the gospel. S. Aug. tract. in Joan. — The Jews, with their characteristic good sense, in matters of this kind, made it the first duty of parents, to teach their children some trade, by which they might gain their livelihood. To neglect this was supposed to be equivalent to teaching them to steal. Hence their learned men were likewise practitioners in some laborious trade. They were ignorant of the distinction between low, and honourable professions, which refinement and vanity have introduced among us. Every employment was honourable, which was conducive to the good of their neighbour, and compatible with virtue and modesty; and the more so, in proportion as the wants of mankind made it more necessary. See Fleury's Manners of the Israelites. *Passim*.

Ver. 4. Introducing the name of the Lord Jesus. These words are found in few Greek copies, and so are omitted in the Protestant translation. *Wi*.

Ver. 5. No further mention is made of Silas in these Acts. Some martyrologists think he died in Macedonia by martyrdom. He is honoured in the Church as a saint, and sometimes, as well as S. Barnabas, obtains the title of apostle.

Calmet. See annotations, c. xvi. v. 37.

Ver. 6. Shaking his garments. See Matt. x. 14. Your blood be upon your own heads: that is, you are guilty of your own perdition: we have discharged our duty by preaching to you. *Wi*.

Ver. 12. This Gallio was brother to the great Seneca, Nero's preceptor, as that author himself assures us. *Præf. lib. v. Quæs. Natur*. He was

called Annæus Novatus, but took the name of Gallio by adoption, and was made proconsul by his brother's interest, whose honours and disgraces he equally participated.

Being condemned to death by Nero, he laid violent hands upon himself. It is probable S. Paul became acquainted with Seneca. S. Jerom and S. Augustin say, many letters passed between them, which are not now extant. Tirinus. See also Eusebius. An. Christi 66.

Ver 17. Beat him. It is uncertain whether the Jews themselves beat Sosthenes, being vexed at him, for not managing well the cause; or whether he was struck by the attendants of the proconsul, to force him away, when he would not desist, nor retire. See the Analysis, dissert. xxxv. Wi.

Ver. 18. Shorn, &c. It was customary among the Jews to make vows of abstaining from all inebriating liquor, not to cut their hair for a limited time, &c.

This was the vow of the Nazarites, mentioned Num. vi. 18. Acts xxii. 24. S. Paul had probably taken upon himself some obligation of this kind; perhaps in condescension to the Jews, who were yet weak in faith. The time being now expired, he cut his hair as before. It was lawful for converts to observe these legal ceremonies, till the gospel was perfectly established, provided they did not place their hopes of salvation in them, or believe that the faith and grace of Christ were ineffectual without them. D. Carthus. — For he had a vow, that is, Paul, not Aquila. This seems to have been such a vow, as those called Nazarenes, used to make, of abstaining from wine for a time, of not cutting their hair, and of making some offerings in the temple at Jerusalem. Wi.

Ver. 22. He went up. To Jerusalem is most probably understood, that being the chief object of S. Paul's journey. It seems rather extraordinary that S. Luke should have omitted the express mention of the city. But having told us his object was to be at Jerusalem, he perhaps thought it was enough to say, he went up. Calmet. — In Palestine, the expression, to go up, was sometimes taken for going up to Jerusalem. John vii. 8. 10. xii. 20. Acts xxiv. 11. And reciprocally in c.

xxiv. 1. to go down, is taken for going down from Jerusalem to Cæsarea. V. — Ibid. In the Scripture, when Antioch and Cæsarea are simply mentioned, Antioch, in Syria, and Cæsarea, in Palestine, are uniformly designated. — To Cæsarea, not in Cappadocia, but in Palestine, from whence he went up to Jerusalem, and then down to Antioch, in Syria. Wi.

Ver. 24. Apollo . . . one mighty in the Scriptures. Lit. powerful in the Scriptures, yet knew no baptism, but that of John. Wi. — When we consider the great harvest, and few labourers, and the small time that the apostles could give to any one place for instructions, we shall not be so much surprised, that this zealous convert should not yet be perfectly instructed in every doctrine of Christianity. This happened about twenty years after our Lord's ascension. He is the same person as is mentioned 1 Cor. iii. 7. A.

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ACTS 19

CHAPTER XIX.

Ver. 1. Disciples. These were apparently disciples of S. John the Baptist, who believed in Christ from his testimony, and had received no farther instruction, nor any baptism but John's. Calmet.

Ver. 2. S. Paul first inquires of them, if they have received the Holy Ghost by confirmation. Their answer is probably not to be interpreted with rigour; since they must have heard something of the holy Spirit, so often mentioned in the Old Testament, by whom the prophets are said to speak, &c. They meant, they did not know there was in the Church, any means of communicating this Spirit to the faithful. Idem.

Ver. 5. Baptized in the name of the Lord Jesus, so called to distinguish it from the baptism of John; and that of Christ was given in the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Ghost, according to the command of Christ himself. Wi.

Ver. 6. Imposed his hands on them, by which imposition of hands, was given the Holy Ghost in the sacrament of confirmation. Wi.

Ver. 12. Aprons. It is likely such as he used in working, cured diseases, and cast out devils. What wonder, then, if God work miracles by the relics of martyrs and saints, to testify the sanctity of his servants, and to encourage others both to give them a reasonable honour, and to imitate their lives? Wi. —

Thus was fulfilled the promise which Christ had made his disciples, viz. that they should perform greater miracles than he himself had done. S.

Chrysostom repeats more than once, that these clothes raised the dead, and that the apostles' shadow chased away all maladies, and triumphed over death. Perhaps the unprejudiced reader may observe in this verse some reason for paying due regard to the relics, or whatever has belonged to the saints.

Ver. 13. The Jewish exorcists. Among the Jews were some, who by calling upon the name of the true God, sometimes cast out evil spirits. But these sons of Sceva seeing S. Paul cast out devils, by calling upon the name of Jesus, thought fit to do the same, though they did not believe in Jesus Christ. And God punished them in this manner, as it is here related, at least two of them.

Wi. — It is uncertain whether the Jews really possessed the power of exorcising demoniacs. From the 12th chapter of S. Matthew, one would be inclined to the affirmative opinion, as our Saviour seems to mention it as a thing well attested. The Jews pretended they received their exorcisms from Solomon. On the other hand, neither the Old nor New Testament ever approve of this power in them nor is it any where mentioned in Scripture that Solomon was the author of any such things. The old law was particularly severe in condemning every kind of enchantment. It is certain, that they, in the time here spoken of, added much superstition and magic to these rites. Tirinus et alii. —

Josephus mentions remarkable instances of their power in exorcisms performed in his own presence, and in that of the emperor Vespasian, and his whole army. Lib. ii. c. 25. De Bello. — Extraordinary things might possibly be performed by magic and collusion between these impostors and the demons.

That this power of expelling devils, resides in the Church, every page of primitive ecclesiastical history, testifies. Scripture is also equally explicit on this subject. The exorcisms, says S. Cyprian, are the spiritual torments and scourges of the demons. Ep. ad Demetrium. — It was for this reason the Jews, on this occasion, used the name of Jesus; a name terrible to the infernal spirits, to add power to their imprecations. Tertullian urges facts of this power in the Christians, with much energy and eloquence, in his Apology. Prudentius has recorded the same, with equal elegance, in his verse —

———Torquetur Apollo

Nomine percussus Christi, nec fulmina verbi

Ferre potest. Agitant miserum verbera linguæ.

Ver. 18. Confessing and declaring their deeds, as penitents do in the sacrament of penance, and not only in general declaring or confessing themselves sinners. See Matt. iii. 6. Wi.

Ver. 19. Curious arts. By which are here meant books of divination and magic art, to which study the Ephesians were much addicted. The price of the books burnt, amounting to a great sum, even computing the 50,000 denarii, each of them at sevenpence half-penny English money. Wi. — The value of the books here destroyed might have amounted to £1000 sterling. The Christian emperors, Constantine the Great, Valentinian, Theodosius, Marcian, and Justinian, have made laws not less strict for destroying, than those the Church for proscribing, the use of wicked books, where danger is likely to ensue. The danger of reading them is set forth by Eusebius, l. vii. c. 6; by S. Augtin, l. iii.

de bap. c. 14; by S. Gregory, l. v. ep. 64. — Such baneful productions should be destroyed; for although they may possibly produce no bad effect during the life of the present possessors, no one can pretend to say into what hands they will afterwards fall, nor what evil they may hereafter occasion.

Ver. 21. I must also see Rome. It is what S. Paul earnestly desired, and what the Spirit now revealed to him. See Rom. i. Wi.

Ver. 23. About the way of the Lord; that is, about Christian faith, and religion.

Wi. — A great source of these troubles that ensued, was the preaching the gospel.

Ver. 24. Who made silver temples for Diana.[1] Perhaps figures of Diana's temple in silver; or boxes and shrines, in which was the statue or figure of Diana. Wi.

Ver. 27. In danger of being vilified, and Diana of losing her reputation. They ought to have reflected, says S. Chrys. (hom. xlii.) that if such a

poor man, as Paul, could destroy the worship, and the majesty of this great goddess, whom, as they say, all the world adored, how much greater and worthy of adoration must the God be, by whose power Paul could do this? Wi.

Ver. 28. Great is Diana of the Ephesians. This they shouted out without intermission for about two hours, though the greatest part knew not why they had met together. A true representation of an unthinking rash mob. Wi.

Ver. 31. Some also of the rulers of Asia. They are called friends to S. Paul, but it is uncertain whether they were Christians, or others, who favoured him, and wished him well. Wi.

Ver. 35. The town-clerk, &c. Lit. the scribe, or the recorder of the city.

Jupiter's offspring.[2] His daughter, according to the poets. The Greek text seems to signify a statue, or figure of Diana, which was pretended to have fallen from heaven, and from Jupiter. Wi. — Is a worshipper. Neokoron ousan; the word Neokoros is found in this sense in the Arundelian marbles, and more frequently on ancient coins and inscriptions. Its derivation is from neos, a temple, and kore, a virgin, or rather korein, to cleanse and decorate; as if this city were especially destined to ornament the Diana of Ephesus, which the people supposed came to them not by the work of man, but a present from heaven.

Ver. 37. Nor of blasphemy against your goddess. S. Chrys. takes notice, that to calm the people, he says more than was true. Wi.

[1] V. 24. Ædes argenteas, naous argurous.

**[2] V. 35. Jovisque prolis, kai tou diopetous. Simulachri a cælo dilapsi.
See Suidas.**

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ACTS 20

CHAPTER XX.

Ver. 6. We. From the change of the narration to the first person again, it would appear S. Luke had rejoined the apostle. This writer modestly omits the reason of his accompanying S. Paul, who tells us it was at his own request, (2 Cor. viii.

19.) that no suspicion might be entertained that he applied improperly the money, which he was commissioned to carry to the distressed brethren in Jerusalem. Tirinus.

Ver. 7. On the first day of the week.[1] The interpreters generally take notice with S. Chrys. that the Christians, even at this time, must have changed the sabbath into the first day of the week, as all Christians now keep it. Which change (even as to the manner of keeping one of God's ten commandments) was made by the Church. — To break bread, meaning the blessed sacrament, as it is commonly expounded. Wi. — S. Paul did here break bread on a Sunday, as it is broken in the sacrament of the body of Christ, and delivered a discourse to the people, both before and after the celebration of the divine mysteries. S. Aug. ep. lxxxvi. ad Casulanum. Ven. Bede in xx. Act.

Ver. 10. His soul is in him. He was taken up dead. v. 9. These words then of S.

Paul, may either signify that now he is again alive, or will be in a very short time, as when Christ said, (Matt. ix. 24.) The girl is not dead, but asleep. Wi.

Ver. 12. Alive. This accident, which gave occasion to a great miracle, was ordained by the particular providence of God, in order to confirm the preaching of S. Paul, and to fix more deeply in the hearts of his disciples the words of their dear Master, who was just going to leave them. Admire likewise the apostle's solicitude for his neighbour's salvation, in prolonging his instructions through the whole night, which preceded his departure. D.

Carthus.

Ver. 17. He called the ancients of the Church. We might translate the bishops, as the very same persons in the 28th verse are called bishops. Wi.

Ver. 19. With all humility; that is, of heart, or mind, as the Greek word signifies.

He knew, says S. Chrys. how necessary this virtue of humility was for the ministers of the gospel. — With tears of charity and compassion, under temptations, trials, and persecutions. Wi.

Ver. 20. I have kept back, &c. I have discovered to you every thing which can be useful to your salvation. Neither fear, nor any human considerations, have prevailed over me to disguise or suppress the truths, which might be serviceable to you. This is the model of a good pastor. Full of doctrine, and of zeal, he communicates what God puts into his heart, and charity inspires him to speak, with abundance, with discretion, without jealousy, without fear. A good shepherd, S. Bernard used to say, has always bread in his scrip, and his dog in his keeping. The dog is his zeal, which must be chained, governed and moderated. His scrip, full of bread, is his mind, filled with all knowledge, which he is always in the state of dispensing as food to his flock.

Ver. 22. Bound in the spirit, led by inspiration of the Holy Ghost. Wi. —

Chained, and forced, as it were, by the Holy Spirit, who offers me a sweet violence; or I am so strongly persuaded of the chains, which await me at Jerusalem, that I already feel myself bound in idea. Calmet. — I now go to Jerusalem for the fourth time, attracted by the Holy Ghost, who is the author and governor of all my actions, that where I have shewn myself the greatest enemy of the Church, there I may suffer tribulations in defence of the same Church, and for Christ, her divine spouse. Tirinus.

Ver. 23. In every city. There were in every city Christian prophets, who foretold to Paul the tribulations which awaited him. It appears, then, that the apostle did not know these things by immediate revelation made to himself, but by that made to the prophets. Of this we have a proof in the next chapter.

Ver. 24. Neither do I count my life (lit. my soul) more precious than myself, having consecrated all my endeavours, my thoughts, my life, my whole self, body and soul, to God's service. Wi.

Ver. 25. I know, &c. It appears sufficiently evident, from many parts of S. Paul's epistles, that he not only designed, but likewise, according to the opinion of most able critics, actually did revisit the churches of Asia. Of this occasion, then, he only expresses his belief, his conviction, that he should see them no more, judging it impossible for him to escape all the dangers that were prepared for him. Calmet. — All you. Although S. Paul might return again to the same place, he might truly say of so great an assembly, that all of them should not see him again. Wi.

Ver. 28. Take heed to yourselves, and to all the flock. The ministers of the gospel must in the first place take care of the salvation of their own souls: and in the next place of the salvation of their flock, of the souls committed to their care, and to the Church; especially such ministers of God as are bishops,[2]

placed, by divine institution, to govern the Church, or the churches under them. The word bishops, by its derivation, signifies overseers, or superintendants; but the signification is to be taken and expressed by the custom and ecclesiastical use of words. Wi.

Ver. 32. To the word of his grace, to the protection of God's grace, given to those that preach the gospel, and administer the sacraments instituted by Christ. — Who is able to build up, to finish that building, of which the foundation is laid by my preaching. Wi.

Ver. 34. These hands have furnished, by labouring to maintain myself, &c. Wi.

Ver. 35. It is more blessed to give than to receive. We find not these words of Christ in the gospels. S. Paul might have them from the apostles. Wi. —

Among the many excellent good things our dear Lord said, and which are not mentioned in the gospel, this is one: "it is a more blessed thing to give, than to receive;" which did men justly weigh, they would be more ready to give alms, were it only for their own account. Thrice happy then are they who assist their indigent neighbour to the utmost of their power, and for the pure love of God!

A.

Ver. 37. They kissed him. These marks of tenderness are dictated by nature, and have always been used between friends, who were separating from each other, or who meet after a long absence. The Scripture furnishes us with numberless examples of it. Calmet. — He likewise prayed, as he usually did, when he bade his last farewell. See his last adieus with the Tyrians, (c. xxi. 5.

6.) where they all kneeled down to pray on the shore. This is also reasonable, and becoming a Christian. It is a sign of communion and mutual charity, and implores a prosperous voyage for those who were departing, whilst those who remained, cherish in their mind the remembrance of the virtues of their absent friend. Menochius. — The mind of man cannot conceive a finer subject for the painter than this melting separation. After the discourse, we see S. Paul falling on his knees, and praying with them all for the last time; an general burst of tears takes place, when they are told that they are to see their father's face no more; they fall upon his neck and kiss him; and with hearts full of grief and gratitude, they accompany him on his way to the very ship which is to transport their father, friend, and benefactor, to other souls, who wanted the charitable assistance of the man of God.

[1] V. 7. Una Sabbati; that is prima sabbati, en te mia ton sabbaton. S. Chrys.

says hom. mg. kuriake en, erat dies Dominica.

[2] V. 28. Episcopos, episkopous, from episkopein, or episkeptesthai, diligenter inspicere, &c.

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ACTS 21

CHAPTER XXI.

Ver. 1. Coos and Rhodes are islands in the Archipelago.

Ver. 3. Cyprus, an island in the Mediterranean, to the east of Patara and Rhodes.

Ver. 4. Not go up to Jerusalem. S. Paul says in the foregoing chapter that he was pressed by the Holy Ghost to go to Jerusalem; and do these prophets now advise him to stay away, and disobey the inspiration? No: their dissuasion was not the effect of inspiration, but the expression of their tenderness and affection for him, which made them fear what they saw he was going to endure. D. Carthus. — Hence S. Paul disregarded their entreaties, as well as the imminent dangers that every where stared him in the face. See his heroic answer to the melting entreaties of the faithful of Cæsarea, and their final acquiescence: "the will of the Lord be done." Infr. v. 14.

Ver. 8. Philip, the evangelist, so called from his preaching the gospel, though he was one of the seven, that is, of the seven deacons. Wi.

Ver. 9. Prophecy. It is supposed that these daughters of S. Philip had made a vow of virginity, or at least remained in that state out of a motive of religion. S.

Jerom thinks in reward of this they were gifted with a prophetic spirit. Lib. i. c.

24. cont. Jov. — Others think that by prophesying is meant interpreting the Scriptures, or singing the praises of God. Estius.

Ver. 18. To James, the bishop of Jerusalem, where all the seniors, that is, the bishops and priests, had assembled. Wi.

Ver. 20. How many thousands. In the Greek, how many ten thousands. Wi.

Ver. 21. To forsake Moses. In the Greek, to depart or apostatize from Moses and the law. This is more than was true. For S. Paul circumcised Timothy, (c.

xvi.) and did not absolutely hinder converts who had been Jews, from practising the Jewish ceremonies. Wi. — There is a manifest falsity in this accusation against S. Paul. He had never commanded or advised the Jews, to whom he had preached, to renounce the law, abandon the ceremonies of Moses, or reject the ancient customs of the nation. He had never hindered any one from following in this respect the bias of his inclinations. He had indeed defended the liberty of the converts from these ceremonies; he had taught that Christ had taken away the necessity of this yoke; but he left them at liberty still to carry it if they pleased. Calmet. — For these things were not then to be sought after as necessary, nor yet to be condemned as sacrilegious. The law of Moses at that time was dead, but not deadly. S. Aug. ep. lxxxii. — These considerations will sufficiently explain the apostle's motive for submitting on this occasion to one of their ceremonies. He became all to all, that he might gain all to Christ. A.

Ver. 23. Who have a vow upon them. On which account they will have sacrifices offered for them in the temple. Wi.

Ver. 24. Bestow on them. It was thought a merit among the Jews to bear the expenses of any vow which another had made. They thus became partakers of it; in the same manner as at present those, who have not the courage to forsake the world by solemn vows, seek to have some share in the merits of those who do forsake it, by contributing part of their substance to their support. Calmet.

Ver. 30. The doors were shut, lest the temple should be profaned by Gentiles entering into it. Wi. — The temple was an asylum, but not for those men who were justly pursued. Hence the Jews looking upon Paul as a blasphemer, they did not think they violated this asylum by forcibly removing Paul from the temple; but lest he might return, they fastened the entrance-gates.

Ver. 33. Two chains, for his hands and feet; or perhaps one chain was put on each hand, which was likewise tied to a soldier on each side of him, who led him. This was the Roman custom of binding prisoners. See Seneca, ep. v. et lib. de tranquil. animi. x. See supra xii. 6, 7.

Ver. 34. Into the castle.[1] Neither the Latin nor the Greek word signifies a castle, but rather a camp, or a place walled, or with a trench about it. It is true, we may here understand the tower, called Antonia; but within its court might be tents for soldiers, where there was so great a number: for we see that Lysias could send away 470 with S. Paul, besides those that might stay behind. Wi.

Ver. 37. Canst thou speak Greek? We cannot doubt but S. Paul had in Greek spoke already to the tribune: upon which he said, dost thou speak Greek? and then asked him, if he were not that seditious Egyptian, who had headed so many murderers? Wi.

Ver. 38. This Egyptian coming to Jerusalem, and professing himself to be a prophet, had persuaded the people to accompany him to Mount Olivet, pretending he would throw down the walls of the city only by a word. Felix, the Roman governor, attacked the deluded multitude, and killed 400. The leader escaped, and was heard of no more. This was in the 13th year of Claudius, about three years before S. Paul's apprehension. Menochius. — These rebels are called murderers, Sikarioi, Sicarii, from Sica, a small dagger, which they concealed under their cloak. Some of them were the retainers of Judas Galilæus; other Hessæans, who fought with the greatest animosity against the Romans, and suffered the most cruel death, sooner than to acknowledge Cæsar for lord and master. Some again suppose that the word sikarioi is only a corruption of the words, oi karioi, Scriptuarii, a name given to the Esseni.

Consult. Jos. Antiq. xx. 7.

Ver. 39. I am indeed a Jew, by birth and education. Wi.

Ver. 40. He spoke in the dialect of the country, which was partly Hebrew and partly Syriac, but the Syriac greatly prevailed; and from the steps, epi tous anastathmous, which led to the fortress of Antonia. Here a Roman cohort was lodged; it was situated to the north-west, and joined the temple. The flight of steps was occupied by the lowest orders of the people. Thus Cicero ad Atticum: Gradus templorum ab infimâ plebe completi erant; and again, pro Cluentio: gradus concitatis hominibus narrat.

[1] V. 34. In castra, which in the plural number, is not a castle: neither doth parembole, which is in the Greek, signify a castle.

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ACTS 22

CHAPTER XXII.

Ver. 1. Hear ye the account.[1] In the Greek, to the apology, or defence. Wi. —

S. Paul, in this exordium, as also in Acts vii. 2. shews himself not ignorant of the art of pleading. He adds the name of Fathers, supposing there may be some of his hearers of senatorial dignity, and others deserving the title for their rank and age. Mat. Pol.

Ver. 3. The scholars sat much below their master; and the nearest the master were such as had made the greatest proficiency. Philo de Essenis.

Ver. 4. This way. That is, the Christian faith, which now I profess. Wi.

Ver. 5. As the high priest doth bear me witness. That is, as the letters which he gave me, bear witness. Wi.

Ver. 9. Heard not the voice. To reconcile this with c. ix. v. 7. where it is said that they heard the voice; it may be answered that they heard a noise, and a voice, but heard it not distinctly, nor so as to understand the words. Wi. — They heard not the voice of him who spoke to the apostle, but they heard the latter speak; (Acts ix. 7.) or perhaps they heard a noise, which they could not understand. They perhaps heard the voice of Paul answering, but not that of Christ complaining.

Ver. 14. Shouldst . . . see the Just One. Our Saviour appeared to S. Paul, as it is said; (c. ix. 7.) and he is divers times, both in the Prophets and in the Testament, called the Just One. Wi. — To see and hear the Just One; Him, who is just by excellence, that you also may prove a witness of his resurrection from the dead.

Ver. 16. Wash, &c. The contrition and charity of S. Paul had, no doubt, merited for him the remission of his sins at the moment of his conversion. Still were these effects to be attributed to the desire of the

sacrament of baptism, without which the council of Trent defines that the forgiveness of sins, and the punishment due to them, are not obtained. It likewise added a new degree of lustre to his innocence and purity. Tirinus. — Calling upon his name. In such manner, says S. Chrys. (hom. xlvii.) as we invoke the only true God; and as we invoke the saints, and pray to them, that they would pray for us. Wi.

Ver. 17. To Jerusalem . . . that I was in a trance. This might be when he went to Jerusalem, three years after his conversion, or at some other time. It might be in this ecstasy that he was wrapt to the third heaven, as he tells the Corinthians, 1 Cor. xv. 9. Wi.

Ver. 20. Of Stephen, thy witness. Or thy martyr, as the Greek word signifies. Wi.

Ver. 21. Hence we see that not only principals, but all that consent to the persecution of God's servants for the cause of religion, do highly offend; and this S. Paul mentions here, that the mercy of God may be more remarkably glorified in him hereby. B.

Ver. 22. This word. That is, until he told them that God had sent him to preach to the Gentiles, whom they could not bear to hear preferred before themselves.

Not that the Jews forbad preaching to the Gentiles; on the contrary, our Saviour reproached the Pharisees, that they would go over land and sea for the sake of making one proselyte. They were likewise enraged that S. Paul had not laid on the Gentiles the heavy yoke of the law. Calmet. — Hence they exclaim: take away this wicked man from amongst us, for it is a sin to let him live. V.

Ver. 23. Threw off their garments. Or pulling them open to shew themselves ready to stone him. Wi. — This is nicely descriptive of the fury of a populace, who, when unable to vent their rage in some more effectual way, indignantly throw into the air, and against the object of their indignation, such harmless trifles as dust, clothes, &c. Menochius.

Ver. 25. A Roman. That is, a Roman citizen, a freeman of Rome. Wi. — The apostle, on this occasion, not to injure the faith of some weak Christians, who might be scandalized at his public disgrace, prevents the scourging, which on another occasion he patiently submitted to. By the thongs he was probably bound to a pillar; (Tirinus) or being tied hand and foot, was stretched on the ground, with his face downwards. This was frequently done among the Romans. Calmet. — See also Gretser de cruce, l. i. c. 10; who declares that it was the Roman custom to bind to a stake or pillar, such as were condemned to be flogged.

Ver. 28. Civilitatem; that is, Civitatem, Græcè, politeian, the rights of citizenship. These privileges were granted by Antonius to the city of Tarsus.

Appianus civilium 5.

Ver. 29. The same law which forbad a Roman citizen to be scourged, forbad him also to be bound. S. Aug. lib. i. de Serm. Dni. c. 29. — It was under Claudius that the abuse of buying the freedom of Rome was introduced. At first the name of a Roman was esteemed much, and bought at a great price.

Now (such is the emptiness and vanity of titles) it is refused, and despised; nay, it is fled from, and reckoned disgraceful. Salvian. De Gubern. Dei, lib. v. —

If S. Paul, on this occasion, makes use of his privilege, it is not that he was unprepared, or afraid to die for Christ; but because it was lawful to use ordinary means to extricate himself from difficulties, and preserve himself for future services to religion. D. Dion. Carthus.

[1] V. 1. Quam reddo rationem, akousate . . . tes apologias.

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ACTS 23

CHAPTER XXIII.

Ver. 1. With an entire good conscience. With an upright sincerity. But S. Paul is far from excusing himself from all sin. He laments elsewhere his blind zeal in persecuting the Christians. See 1 Cor. xv. 9. Wi.

Ver. 3. God shall strike thee, thou whited wall.[1] These words are rather by way of a prophecy. Wi. — Whited wall. That is, hypocrite, for pretending to judge me according to law; whereas, against all sense of justice, thou strikest me before my condemnation; nay, even without giving me a hearing. The Fathers admire, on this occasion, the greatness of mind and freedom S. Paul exhibited, in reproving the great. Tirinus. — This expression was not the angry words of an irritated man, nor the effect of personal resentment, but the just freedom which insulted innocence may lawfully use in its own defence. A. — It was likewise a prophecy of what was going to happen. To those who do not consider it, it may seem a curse; but to others a prophecy, as it really was. S.

Aug. lib. i. cap. 19. de Verb. Dni. — For S. Chrysostom relates that the high priest, being thunderstruck by this answer, became speechless and half deaf; so that not being able to reply a single word, the bystanders did it for him.

Tirinus. — It was also, as Ven. Bede says, to shew that the Jewish priesthood was to be destroyed, as now the true priesthood of Christ was come and established. Bede in hunc locum.

Ver. 5. I knew not, &c. Some think S. Paul here speaks ironically, or to signify that now he could be no longer high priest, since the Mosaic law, with its rites and ceremonies, was abolished. But S. Chrys. rather judges that S. Paul, having been long absent from Jerusalem, might not know the person of the high priest, who was not now in the sanhedrim but in the place whither the tribune had called the council, and who did not appear with that habit, and those marks which distinguished him from others. Wi. — It seems rather surprising that S. Paul did not

know that he was the high priest. The place which he held in the council, one would suppose, would have been sufficient to have pointed him out. The apostle's absence from Jerusalem is perhaps a sufficient reason to account for his not knowing this circumstance; especially, as the order of succession to the priesthood was at that time much confused and irregular, determined by favour of the Roman emperor, or by purchase.

Calmet. — At all events, any difficulties we may now find in assigning a probable or true reason, are merely negative arguments; and therefore too futile to be an impeachment of the apostle's veracity. A. — S. Cyprian supposes that S. Paul, considering the mere shadow of the name of priest, which Ananias then held, said: I knew not, brethren, that he is high priest. Ep.

lxv. nu. 2. S. Chrysostom says, that the apostle here shews the wisdom of the serpent; but that in his preaching, teaching, and patience, he used the simplicity of the dove.

Ver. 6. I am a Pharisee, the son of Pharisees.[2] It may signify only a disciple of the Pharisees, though the common Greek copies have of a Pharisee. Wi. —

The address of the apostle in this is great. Knowing the different dispositions of his judges, he throws disunion into their councils, in order to draw himself from danger. Such innocent artifices are allowed in the defence of a just cause.

It is one of our Saviour's counsels, to use the prudence of the serpent. S.

Gregory, in his Morality, (lib. xxxiv. cap. 3. and 4.) and S. Thomas in his Sum.

Theol. (2. 2. quæst. 37. art. 2.) observe, that on similar occasions you may, without sin, cause divisions among the wicked; because their union being an evil, it is consequently a good thing that the enemies of peace and righteousness should be divided in sentiments and interests. It must, however, be acknowledged that this principle is very easily

stretched beyond its proper limits, and therefore ought not to be acted upon but with the greatest caution and prudence. Calmet. — S. Paul knew from divine revelation that he was to go to Rome; but this did not hinder the apostle from taking every prudent care of his own life; as we may see from the following chapter.

Ver. 7. There arose a dissension. By the Greek, a division, or schism among them, occasioned by S. Paul's declaring himself for the resurrection, which made the Pharisees favour him, and incensed the Sadducees. Wi.

Ver. 11. Be constant . . . so must thou bear witness also at Rome; and so needest not fear to be killed by them. Wi.

Ver. 12. Bound themselves. The Greek is, anathematized, that is, submitted themselves to a curse, if they did not kill Paul. It was a great imprecation, the violation of which would have been equivalent to renouncing their belief in God. See to what degree of iniquity this nation is come. When any good is in contemplation, none are found to undertake it; whilst all, even the priests too, are ready to concur in any wicked design. S. Chrys. in Act. hom. xlix. — To take an unlawful oath is one sin; but to keep it, is another and greater sin: as when Herod, to keep his oath, put to death John the Baptist. Matt. iv. 9.

Ver. 13. Forty men that had made this conspiracy,[3] and bound themselves with an impious curse, or imprecation upon themselves, if they did not kill him.

Wi.

Ver. 19. Taking him by the hand, with marks of affection and tenderness. It is probable that the tribune expected this young man was come to offer some ransom for Paul's liberty. Menochius.

Ver. 23. From the third hour of the night. If the tribune spoke with a regard to the twelve hours of the night, the third hour was three hours after sunset, and was about our nine o'clock at night; but if he meant the third watch of the night, that began at midnight. See Matt. xiv. 35. **Wi.**

Ver. 24. Felix. This man had been a slave of the emperor Claudius. The high priest, Jonathan, had procured him to be made governor of Judea. He governed the country with great cruelty and outrage; exercising the power of a king, says Tacitus, with all the insolence and meanness of a slave, who is neither restrained by fear nor shame. Tacitus, Hist. lib. v.

Ver. 25. This verse is omitted in the Greek. Antipatris was a pleasant city on the Mediterranean sea, situated at equal distance, about 24 miles, between Joppe and Cæsarea, on the way from Jerusalem to this latter city. Matt. Polus.

Ver. 27. I rescued . . . having understood that he is a Roman. This was not true, if we understand it of the first time he rescued him; but may be true, if meant of the second time. **Wi.**

Ver. 35. This was a palace erected by Herod the Great; in which the governors had taken up their habitation. **V.**

[1] V. 3. Pecutiet, tuptein se mellei, futurum erit ut te percutiat.

[2] V. 6. Filius Pharisæorum; and so divers of the best Greek MSS. pharisaion; but the common Greek, uios pharisaïou.

[3] V. 13. Devoverunt se, anathematisan.

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ACTS 24

CHAPTER XXIV.

Ver. 1. Ananias went down to Cæsarea, where Paul was then confined. This is the sense of the Greek.

Ver. 2. By thy provision,[1] Lit. thy providence, by thy prudence. Wi. — Though Felix governed Judea in the arbitrary manner mentioned in the note on the last chapter, he had nevertheless done some good, which is recorded to his honour. See Joseph. Ant. xx. 6. 11. and Bel. Jud. xii. But had this not been the case, a public orator seldom scruples to gain over the man by praises, whose judgment he seeks. S. Paul was not ignorant of this rule of rhetoric, though he refuses to imitate Tertullus by pressing flattery into his service, as we observe below, v. 10. and Acts xxii. 1. 3. See also the exordiums of Cicero pro Roscio, pro Milone, &c. &c.

Ver. 5. A pestilent,[2] or pernicious, and pestiferous man; Greek, one that is a plague. — Author, or ringleader of the seditious sect, &c. Wi.

Ver. 8. From him thou . . . mayest know. By the construction it is doubtful whether from Lysias, or from S. Paul. Wi. — Behold them here ready to support the heads of accusation I have brought forward, and which are moreover so self-evident, that the party accused will not dare to deny them. V.

Ver. 10. In the apostle's speech we observe nothing of the flattery, which characterized the opposite party. It would have been unworthy of his just cause. Calmet. — He observes he had been governor of the province many (eight or nine) years, to insinuate, that had he been a seditious man, as he was accused, Felix would not have failed to have heard of his misdeeds before.

Menochius.

Ver. 11. Since I went up from Cæsarea to Jerusalem, not to profane the temple, or excite sedition, but to adore the one true God.

Ver. 12. In Jerusalem there was only one temple, nor could there, by an express command of the Almighty, be any more throughout the whole kingdom. (Perhaps the Almighty may have wished by this singular circumstance to have impressed more forcibly on their minds the absolute necessity of unity in religion. A.) But there were many synagogues, which were a kind of schools, in which the law was publicly taught, and the people assembled to read the Scriptures, and to pray. Calmet.

Ver. 14. The Father,[3] and my God. In the Greek, the Lord of our fathers. Wi. —

According to the way. The Protestant version has sect for way; but in this, as well as in many other points, the original is not attended to, in which we read kata ten odon, as in our translation.

Ver. 22. Felix . . . knowing most certainly of this way. That is, knew even by Lysias's letter, that Paul and the Christians were not guilty of any thing against Cæsar, but only accused of disputes relating to the Jewish law. Wi.

Ver. 25. Felix being terrified, &c. When S. Paul spoke of God's judgments, and hinted at such sins as his conscience reproached him with. Wi. — Whoever knows the infamous character of Felix and Drusilla, will not fail to admire the apostle's fortitude, that he durst speak (as formerly the Baptist did to Herod,) to them on the subject of justice and chastity. Suetonius says of the former, that he married three queens. Drusilla, one of the three, was Herod's daughter, and wife of Aziz, king of Emesa, whom he had seduced by the enchantments of a Jew of Cyprus. Hence it is not surprising he was terrified at the thoughts of a future judgment, when expounded by a S. Paul, whose

zeal to make these wicked people enter into themselves, hurried him beyond the bounds of worldly prudence, but made such impression on his hearers, as to disarm the indignation his discourse was calculated to produce. See Josephus, ut supra.

Tirinus, Calmet, and others. Next to the worship of God, the Christian religion requires of its followers, in the first instance, justice and chastity. Felix was unjust, avaricious, cruel; and both Felix and Drusilla were guilty of adultery.

Such was the wickedness of the Gentiles in those degenerate days, that fornication was not looked upon as a crime. How much had they deviated from the excellent maxim we read and admire, inter Socraticas disputationes!

omnem virtutem niti continentia, et incontinentem nihil a bellua brutissima differre; that all virtue was built upon continency, and that the incontinent man differed in nothing from the most brute beast. — At a convenient time I will send for thee. Such is the expedient Felix has recourse to, to silence the voice of conscience: and in this how often is he not imitated by the sinner, who dreads nothing so much as to enter into himself. Why put that off to another time, which will never arrive? Or why delay till death a repentance, which like the remorse of the damned, will then be as unavailing, as it will be eternal?

[1] V. 2. Per tuam providentiam, pronoias, a prudent foreseeing.

[2] V. 5. Hominem pestiferum, loimon, pestem.

[3] V. 14. Patri & Deo. to patroo theo.

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ACTS 25

CHAPTER XXV.

Ver. 1. Festus having arrived at his province, goes to Jerusalem to be inaugurated. The Jews took this opportunity of requesting S. Paul might be sent to Jerusalem, that they might accomplish the iniquitous purport of their vow. Such consequence did they attribute to the death of this one man, that they had no greater favour to ask of their new governor at his auspicious entry among them. Tirinus.

Ver. 4. It would appear, from their first request being peremptorily denied them, how little solicitous their governors were to please them. The successors of Felix and Festus were not better disposed than their predecessors. Their extortions and oppressions were pushed so far, that the Jews attempted at last to deliver themselves by rebellion, which proved their utter ruin and extirpation. Indeed it was in vain to resist, for they already began to feel the truth of our Saviour's prediction, in their subjugation to the Gentiles. Josephus bears ample testimony to the fulfilment of the prophecy. De bel. Jud. lib. ii. c 16. &c. A.

Ver. 5. Among you that are able.[1] It may signify, such as are powerful among you, or such as are able by health, and willing. Wi.

Ver. 8. Paul making answer,[2] or his apology, by the Greek. In the Latin, giving an account. In like manner, (v. 16.) have liberty given to defend himself; in the Greek, to make his apology. In the Latin, till he take a place of defending himself.

Ver. 10. S. Paul, seeing Festus only sought a plea to get rid of his cause, by putting it into the hands of the Sanhedrim, appeals to Cæsar. According to the ordinary rules of jurisprudence, appeals are only made after sentence is pronounced; but Roman citizens had a privilege of anticipating the sentence, when the judge did any thing contrary to justice; as Festus evidently did in this case, by wishing to deliver Paul, a Roman citizen, to the tribunal of his declared enemies, the Jews. The apostle knew he was secured by making this appeal: as the Roman law declared provincial governors violators of the public peace, who should

either strike, or imprison, or put to death a Roman citizen, that appealed to the emperor. Calmet. — Hence Pliny sent some Christians to Rome for this same reason, as he writes himself in his epistles. Lib. x. ep. 97.

Fuerunt alii similis amentiae, quos, quia cives Romani erant, annotavi in urbem remittendos.

Ver. 13. Agrippa. This was son of the king of the same name, who imprisoned S. Peter, and put S. James to death. Bernice was his sister, and one of the most infamous of women. Her character has merited her a place in one of Juvenal's satires, 5th.

Ver. 19. Their own superstition.[3] Their particular religion, and manner of worshipping their God. Wi.

Ver. 21. Augustus Nero, who was then the Roman emperor.

Ver. 22. Agrippa has the same curiosity of hearing Paul, as Herod formerly had of seeing Jesus. The apostle's name had, no doubt, become famous enough to reach the ears, and arrest the attention of Agrippa. Curiosity is certainly not the best motive a person can bring with him to the investigation of religious truth: still it may occasionally become productive of good. The king was half persuaded to embrace the Christian faith. A better motive, or more serious attention, may induce some to embrace the truth, which accident may first have discovered to them. A.

Ver. 26. To my lord. This was a title the emperors afterwards took, but which Augustus and Tiberius are said by Pliny, in his epistle to Trajan, and by Tertullian, to have refused, as too assuming and too high, ut nimis sublimem atque gloriosum. This was perhaps done, that none might bear the title at a time when the Lord of lords was to appear on the earth. Tirinus. — Whilst we can approve and admire the motives which actuated the emperors in refusing this title, we cannot go the lengths which some modern enthusiasts do, (mostly Americans, quakers, &c.) who pretend it is blasphemy to call a mortal man a lord, as if that name were incommunicable to any but the Creator of the

universe. Whence they derive this article of faith it will not be easy for us to guess; certainly not from Scripture, in which the word Dominus or Lord, applied to man, occurs almost as frequently as King. Certainly not from our Saviour's words, who give both himself and others this title, (Mark xiv. 14. et alibi passim) nor from S. Paul's doctrine, who also uses this word indiscriminately through his epistles, Gal. iv. 1. Eph. vi. v. &c. Hence we are justified in retaining this practice, in opposition to their cavils; and in treating that opinion as superstitious and void of foundation, which makes it a necessary part of religion to use no titles. A.

[1] V 5. Qui potentes estis, oi dunatoi en umin.

[2] V 8. Paulo rationem reddente, apologoumenou. V. 16. Locum defendendi accipiat, topon apologias laboi.

[3] V. 19. De sua superstitione, peri tes idias deisidaimonias.

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ACTS 26

CHAPTER XXVI.

Ver. 1. S. Paul having obtained liberty of speaking, stretches out his right hand, disengaged from his cloak. We must recollect that S. Paul still bore his chains about him, those chains in which he gloried; (v. 26.) it is therefore necessary to suppose that his left hand only was tied; or, what is less likely, that these chains were not so tight nor heavy as to hinder the easy motion of the right. It is observed by Apuleius, that orators in this action closed the two shorter fingers, and had the others extended. Calmet.

Ver. 5. According to the most sure sect.[1] In the Greek, the most exact or approved: for such was esteemed that of the Pharisees. Wi.

Ver. 6. For the hope of the promise. That is, of the promised Messiah, and of salvation by him. Wi.

Ver. 8. He speaks now to the Sadducees, who denied the resurrection. Can you say it is impossible for Him, whom you all allow to be omnipotent, to raise any of the dead to life? Is it not easier to reanimate a body, whose parts are dissolved by death, than create what had no existence? "And why should He, who daily from the corrupted seed brings forth plants, leaves, wood, not be able to call back into their primitive state the flesh and bones from the dust into which they have been dissolved." S. Greg. hom. xxvi. in Evang.

Ver. 10. I brought the sentence.[2] That is, from those who in the great council were judges of life and death, to those officers who were to put the sentence in execution. This seems to be the sense of these words, rather than, I voted, or gave my voice in condemning them; for we have no grounds to think S. Paul was one of the council, or of the judges. Wi.

Ver. 14. It is generally supposed that S. Paul addresses king Agrippa in the Greek language, which was the common tongue of a great part of the East. V.

Ver. 16. Wherein I will appear to thee. From whence interpreters take notice, that Christ divers times appeared to S. Paul to reveal things to him. Wi.

Ver. 17. Delivering thee, &c. That is, from many attempts, both of the Jews and Gentiles, against thee. Wi.

Ver. 18. That they may be converted from the darkness of error to the light of the gospel, and from the power of Satan to the liberty of the children of God.

Ver. 23. That Christ should suffer, &c. Lit. if Christ be passible. If, here is expounded not as implying a condition, but as an affirmation; so that the sense is, that Christ, according to the predictions of the prophets, was to suffer, was to be the first that should rise from the dead, &c. Wi. — First, &c.

Many had been raised from the dead before Jesus; the child of the widow of Sarepta, Lazarus, and others. How, then, is Jesus first? He is the first who rises not to die again; and as such the Messiah is always represented by the prophets. Others were raised from the dead, but returned again to their graves.

Jesus dies no more. He is the first too who raises himself. Calmet.

Ver. 24. It is not surprising that Festus should have taken S. Paul for a madman. The resurrection of the dead, remission of sins, receiving baptism, and faith, announcing light to the nations, &c. were subjects completely unintelligible to a Roman. To a Jew the terms were customary and common.

The eloquence and manner in which he spoke on these subjects, might shew him to be a man of great learning.

Ver. 28. In a little thou persuadest me to become a Christian. According to the common exposition, Agrippa speaks in a jest, and ironically; and as for the words, they are the same as, thou almost persuadest me, &c. Wi.

Ver. 29. Except these chains. That is, I heartily wish all men in the same condition as myself, not only to be prisoners as I am, but to be Christians, as I am. Wi.

[1] V. 5. Certissimam, akribestaten, accuratissimam.

[2] V. 10. Ego sententiam detuli, katenegka psephon, calculum, suffragium. It was the custom for judges to give their votes either by taking up a white or a black stone: that it, a white stone, if the persons judged were found not guilty, and a black stone, if guilty: so Ovid,

Mos erat antiquis niveis, atrisque lapillis,

His damnare reos, illis absolvere culpa.

— So that psephos was a lapillus, or a little stone made use of in giving sentence, and from thence taken for the sentence itself.

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ACTS 27

CHAPTER XXVII.

Ver. 2. Adrumetum. In the Greek, Adrametum, which seems to be the best reading: the former was in Africa, the latter in Asia; and the ship was to make for the coasts of Asia and not those of Africa. — Being about to sail[1] by the coast of Asia. Lit. beginning to sail; the sense can only be designing to sail that way, as appears also by the Greek. Wi.

Ver. 4. We sailed under Cyprus. That is, north of Cyprus, betwixt the coasts of Cilicia and Cyprus, leaving it on our left, instead of leaving it on our right hand.

Wi.

Ver. 7. We sailed hard by Crete, now Candia, near by Salmone, sailing betwixt them. Wi.

Ver. 8. Called Good-havens, a port on the east part of Crete, near the city of Thalassa, in the Greek text Lasea. Wi.

Ver. 9. The fast was now past.[2] An annual fast. Some take it for the fast of the Ember-days, which Christians keep in December: but S. Chrys. and others expound it of the Jewish fast of expiation, in their seventh month, Tisri, answering to our September or October. Wi. — Most interpreters understand this of the solemn fast of expiation, mentioned in Leviticus (xvi. 29. and xxiii.

27.) which fell about the end of September and beginning of October. At this time sailing on the Mediterranean is dangerous. Though this phrase is at present obscure to us, we must recollect that S. Luke was writing for Christians, who being for the most part converted Jews, easily understood the expression. Calmet.

Ver. 10. Ye men, I see, &c. This S. Paul foretells as a prophet. Wi.

Ver. 12. Phœnice, on the south part of Crete, a convenient haven to ride safe in, lying by south-west and north-west. Wi.

Ver. 14. Called Euroaquilo.[3] In the Prot. translation, Euroclydon, as in many Greek copies. In others Euraculon, which Dr. Wells prefers. Wi.

Ver. 16. An island that is called Cauda. In some Greek copies Claudia, which the Prot. have followed; in others Caudos. — We had much work to come by the boat, or to hoist up the skiff belonging to the ship; which we did, lest it should be broken to pieces by the wind against the ship, or separated from it. Wi.

Ver. 17. The used helps, under-girding the ship.[4] Perhaps bracing or binding about the vessel with ropes or chains, lest she should be torn asunder. — Into the quick-sands. Lit. into a syritis, such as are on the coasts of Africa, whither now they were almost driven. — The let down the sail-yard.[5] This seems to be the sense of these words letting down the vessel. Some translate striking the sail; but others think they were in apprehension for the mainmast. Wi.

Ver. 18. They lightened the ship by throwing overboard part of their loading and goods. Some call it, they made the jetsam. Wi.

Ver. 19. The tacking, or furniture of the ship that they could spare; others express it, they threw out the lagam. Wi.

Ver. 21. Not . . . have saved this harm and loss, which you have brought upon you by not following my advice. Wi. — All the company being in consternation and hourly expectation of death, did not think of taking meat. For it appears they did not want provisions, and nothing else forced them to fast. Calmet. —

The mildness of S. Paul's address to them on this occasion is admirable. He mixes no severe rebuke for their past want of confidence in his words, but seems only solicitous for their future belief. In telling them that none of them should perish, he does not utter a mere conjecture, but speaks with prophetic knowledge; and, if he says they were all given to him, it was not to enhance his own merit, but to engage their faith and confidence in his veracity. S. Chrys.

Act. hom. lii.

Ver. 23. An Angel of God. Lit. of the God whose I am; that is, whose servant I am. Wi.

Ver. 24. God hath given thee all them; that is, the true God, maker and master of all things. It is sometimes a great happiness to be in the company of the saints, who by their prayers to God, help us. Wi. — S. Paul prayed that all in the vessel with him might be saved; and an angel was sent to assure him his prayer was heard. If such was the merit of the apostle whilst yet in this mortal body, that the Almighty, in consideration of it, granted the lives of 276 persons, what do you think, will be his interest before God, now that he is glorious in heaven? S. Jerom contra Vigilant.

Ver. 27. In the Adria. Not in what we call the Adriatic gulf, or sea of Venice, but that which lies betwixt Peloponnesus, Sicily, and Italy. Wi.

Ver. 30. The ship-men . . . having let down the boat into the sea; that is, had begun to let it down with ropes, &c. Wi.

Ver. 31. Paul said . . . unless these stay. Providence had ordered that all should escape, but by helping one another. Wi.

Ver. 33. Taking nothing. That is, without taking a full meal, but only a morsel now and then, and nothing to speak of. Wi. — Though S. Chrysostom understands these words in their full rigour, and therefore supposes them to have been supported by a miracle; yet is is not requisite to adhere to the severity of these words in the interpretation of them. Not having had time to prepare any regular meal during that time, they may justly be said to have taken nothing, though they had occasionally eaten a little now and then to support nature. Such exaggerations in discourse are common. Interpretes passim.

Ver. 40. Loosing also the rudderbands. Some ships are said heretofore to have had two rudders: and this ship perhaps had two, unless here

the plural number be put for the singular, which is not uncommon in the style of the Scriptures. — And hoisting up the main-sail. The word in the text may signify any sail, either the main, or mizen-sail, which latter by the event was more than sufficient. Wi.

Ver. 41. Into a place where two seas met.[6] It happened that there was a neck or tongue of land, which being covered with the waves, they who were strangers to the coast did not discover: this stranded the ship, the prow sticking fast, and the poop being torn from it, so that the vessel split by the violence of the winds and sea. Wi.

Ver. 44. The rest . . . they carried on planks. That is, let them be carried on planks; and all got safe to land, in the number two hundred and seventy-six souls, or persons. Wi.

[1] V. 2. Incipientes navigare, mellontes plein, navigaturi.

[2] V. 9. Jejuniū prāteriisset S. Chrys. om ig. nesteian ten ioudaion.

[3] V. 14. Euroaquilo, eurokludon. Dr. Wells prefers the reading of eurakulon.

[4] V. 17. Accingentes navem, upozonuntes to ploion, bracing the ship with something.

[5] V. 17. Submisso vase, chalasantes to skeuos. The word skeuos, has many significations, and may be taken for the ship, or any part of it: here it may signify the main-mast, which they might take down, lest it should be torn away.

[6] V. 41. In locum dithalassum, eis topon dithalasson.

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ACTS 28

CHAPTER XXVIII.

Ver. 1. Melita, now called Malta, famous for being the residence of, and giving the title to, the military order of Knights, who strenuously resisted the Turks, when they threatened to overrun Christendom. The inhabitants are called Barbarians, not as a term of reproach, for the manner he speaks of their humanity testifies the contrary; but in the classical sense of the word, it was applied by the Greeks and Romans to all who did not speak either of those languages. Their hospitality was rewarded by the light of faith, which they still maintain, although infidels have sometimes for a century had dominion over this island. Tirinus, &c.

Ver. 4. Murderer. In this instance we see how unfounded are the judgments of men. As if the misfortune itself were not sufficient to endure, the man upon whom any temporal calamity falls, must be also judged to be an object of divine vengeance. How cruel and preposterous, yet how common are such proceedings! Whence can it happen that man is so forward to think evil, so slow to suspect good in his neighbour? A. — Not to live. The inhabitants of the island, called Barbarians, had a notion of a Deity, and also that murder was against the law of God and nature. Wi.

Ver. 6. That he would suddenly fall down and die. It is not then by the natural situation and temper of the air, that this island has no venomous creatures. Wi.

Ver. 16. To dwell by himself, with a soldier that guarded him. S. Paul was chained, as it appears by the 20th verse: and it was the custom to fasten one end of the chain by a lock to the prisoner's wrist, and the other end of the chain to the wrist of the soldier who was to guard him. In most Greek copies we read: the centurion delivered the prisoners to the captain of the guards: as it is in the Prot. translation, and very probable; but these words are not found in divers Greek MSS. nor were read by the ancient interpreter of the Latin Vulgate. Wi. — S. Chrysostom attributes this liberty S. Paul enjoyed at Rome of going

whither he liked, to their admiration of him. Hom. liv. in Acts. — Others to the moderation of Afranius Burrus, who was prefect of the Prætorium in the year 61, and who used his authority, as long as he possessed any over Nero's mind, to repress that emperor's bad inclinations, and direct his councils with wisdom. Calmet.

Ver. 17. Chief of the Jews. We have seen before, that the emperor Claudius banished all Jews from Rome. It would appear from this verse, that many of the principal Jews returned at his death, which happened five years before S.

Paul's arrival. Calmet.

Ver. 20. Because that for the hope of Israel. That is, of the Messias, so long expected and hoped for by the Israelites. Wi. — According to the Roman custom, S. Paul must have been fastened by the right hand to one end of a chain, the other end of which chain held to the left hand of the soldier who guarded him. V.

Ver. 22. It is every where gainsayed. Here we observe one of the characters of the true religion. It is contradicted and spoken against. As singular as this may appear, it is however true. Jesus, the author of that religion, had foretold it should be so. If the world hateth me, it will hate you also. The situation of the Catholic religion in this country, at present, is something similar to what is related here of Christianity: and those who have the candour to inquire seriously into its merits, have generally the reward of being convinced and of believing in it. Christianity, like some plants, grows the better for being trodden upon. A.

Ver. 30. Two whole years in his own hired lodging. That is, in the lodgings which S. Paul was permitted to hire for himself, and to live there, with a soldier chained to him for his guard. Happy soldier, if he knew how to make use of such a favourable opportunity! We may take notice by all this narration of S.

Luke, (as when he says here, v. 16, when we arrived at Rome, &c.) that he was all the way in the ship with S. Paul. Wi.

Ver. 31. Here terminates the history of S. Paul, as contained in the Acts of the Apostles. The other actions of this great apostle, for want of being recorded, are involved in much obscurity. That he obtained his liberty again, and made many voyages to carry the light of the gospel into many countries, is certain: but nothing is known as to the manner or time. He finished his labours by martyrdom, being beheaded at Rome in the 66th of the Christian æra, and the 13th of Nero. What a degree of virtue might we not attain, were we animated by the spirit and courage of a S. Paul. Let us at least try to imitate his example; and, if in dangers and difficulties we cannot clothe our souls in adamant, as he did, we may certainly avoid yielding ingloriously to every light impression. Let us at an humble distance tread in his footsteps and live so that we may navigate in safety the boisterous ocean of life, and by the grace of Jesus Christ arrive at the port, where danger is no more to be apprehended. S. Chrys.

hom. lv. in Act. ad finem.